

Law Victory



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Part VI

Prologue

65 Foggy Street, 8

“CAN you come right now?” The voice was demanding, deep, vibrating. The clock showed quarter to three in the morning. The curtains trembled like a freshman’s skirt on a first date.

“Of course.” The wet, sticky receiver slipped from his hand like a jellyfish. It wheezed intermittently, resembling the breathing of a dying patient. The room was stuffy, like a sauna on a Sunday morning. The half-empty bottle on the table was pleasantly covered with condensation.

There was no way he could go. He couldn’t go. There was nothing to do there. This wasn’t his exit, not his performance, not his repertoire, not his theater, not his role, after all. He couldn’t. He wouldn’t escape from there; wouldn’t succeed, just like last time. He couldn’t, couldn’t, couldn’t.

Catch a taxi, make it by four. Not for long. Just say: “Hi, how are you?” Two hours — and the metro would open. To the station, to the airport, to the cosmodrome. To any place swarming with transportation. A one-way ticket. Somewhere where mobile phones haven’t been invented yet.

Two big gulps, straight from the bottle. Quenching passion; oil, canvas, second half of the seventeenth century. Outside the window — rare lights of streetlamps, occasional cars, belated pedestrians. Five to three.

Another gulp that turned into a strained cough. Drops of sweat ran down his face and dripped from his nose onto the floor.

"I can come right now."

Everything in the room seemed to sigh with relief when the door, heavily sighing in farewell, released the hunched figure onto the street. Such people had no place in enclosed spaces. Space thickened around them, wiring sparked and faucets leaked. They should live somewhere in the jungle, or, better yet, in the desert. And not sit for hours, hunched over, on a hard uncomfortable couch with the lights off, staring at a dead television screen. There was nothing else to look at in the room — in its simplicity of furnishing it could easily compete with the cave of Paul of Thebes.

Footsteps tapped out a muffled march on the stairs and the entrance door slammed. A random passerby disappeared around the corner. Wind drove empty beer cans away from the bus stop. Exactly three in the morning. The quietest time for a megalopolis. The height of siesta, lasting here only a couple of hours. By four the first janitors would emerge, squinting at the consumptive dawn.

"I can't come right now..."

The city is beautiful in its own way at night. The gaping black holes of windows make buildings look like chainmail. Streetlights lazily and surprisingly look down at their own poles. Tree crowns lose color, as if rehearsing their autumn parting with leaves. The rustle of tires of taxis prowling for prey can be heard two blocks away, and from that distance resembles not the rustle of rain, but the scratching of mice in the far corner of a basement. The city in its underwear of asphalt and concrete, without the tinsel of cars, lights, colorful crowds — is nearsighted and shy. The loud headlines of tabloids about dangers lurking in the night are absurd and false. The journalists churning out such notes in batches of three thousand characters should at least once leave home and walk along the sidewalks resting after their day shift. At this very moment you can hear a

thrush's cry, see the friendly cheerful blinking of traffic lights, breathe in the smell of the city.

Sneakers allowed him to walk silently. Rare cars paid no attention to his waves and bows. At this rate he might be late.

"I'll be there in half an hour." It seemed this formulation won. "I'll be there in half an hour."

A dark burgundy, at this time of night practically black, car stopped nearby. Behind the wheel — a swarthy elderly man, hiding kindness and fatigue in his mustache.

"Where to?"

"Foggy Street, 8."

"Get in."

Part I

The Encounter

1 The Call from Liels

THE phone crawled across the table toward a stack of magazines, buzzing unpleasantly, like a large wasp trapped in a closet. Ever since mobile phones gave any random person the ability to catch you off guard, quite some time had passed. Everyone got used to it. Almost everyone, to be precise. Victor never could.

The room was smoky, the television with the voice of a prosecutor reading a verdict droned the crime report. And now — that annoying “buzz-beezz-buzz-bazz.” He should have turned it off, but now it was too late to do anything about it.

“Listening and not obeying,” Victor habitually responded to an unknown number.

“Hi, recognize me?”

Victor hated idiotic manners even more than bad ones. He easily tolerated crude profanity, sloppy meals, colloquial pronunciation, absence of creases in trousers, and limp handshakes. A writer, if he’s not a science fiction writer, has to put up with the very fact of others’ existence, otherwise he’d have no one to write from life. Others, contrary to Chekhov’s precept, were lucky if they were significant in at least one thing. Victor had adapted to looking at people as if through a set of filters, noticing only the spectral component that interested him. A mechanic in the garage, *six-foot-seven*, who couldn’t fit behind the wheel of his compact car. A waitress at a restaurant, who invariably greeted him with a *half-bow and an obsequious question*: “Hello?” The

editorial *Casanova* Dmitry, with whom he sometimes drank beer.

He was always genuinely surprised if Dimka, instead of the traditional “evening assault,” rushed home, or if the waitress wasn’t at her usual place. For him these signs of others’ full lives were as unnatural as if a comic book hero suddenly peeled off from the sixth page and asked for the bathroom.

Two hundred years ago Victor would have been known as an anchorite and freethinker. These days he led the life of a sporadic extrovert. Sometimes, no more than once a month, he’d suddenly put on a bright tie and start some extravaganza at the editorial office, or at a friend’s birthday party that happened to come along. He’d make all unfamiliar ladies fall in love with him, joke brilliantly, recite poetry, dance like an ox. On quieter evenings he’d sit in on underground poker games in basements along Sretenka — the mathematician in him calculating pot odds while the journalist bluffed with a face carved from limestone. Then imperceptibly drink a full glass, quietly say goodbye to the chosen few and disappear toward his den in Maryina Roshcha. After such benefits — he’d walk around gloomy for a week, then return to his usual emotional state of a cunning oyster. Victor disliked people.

Not that he avoided them — no; they irritated him slightly. No more than a mosquito’s whine in the evening in a dark room when you’re trying to overcome insomnia. But no less either. Short for a man, wide-boned, solid, from a distance resembling a rugby player — Victor was a mysterious person not only to others, but often to himself as well.

And now — the phone receiver, instead of introducing itself, asked him in an unfamiliar bass:

“Recognize me?”

"More no than yes," Victor completely muted the television sound. — "Snezhana, is that you?"

"Latov, when was the last time you went on a blind date?"

"In a past life," Victor answered, lazily trying to recognize familiar overtones in the caller's voice. Unsuccessfully.

"You didn't recognize me?"

"Well, since we're on informal terms — hello, papa."

"Stop being an idiot. Vitya, it's Liels."

Damn. He and Valdis Liels had studied together at the university, then Valdis had left for his historical homeland, peacefully reclaimed. The accent in his voice, barely audible even twenty years ago, had disappeared completely.

"Li-i-e-els! Hi." Victor was even a little pleased. "You're in Moscow, are you?"

"Not me. But you haven't answered my question yet."

"I haven't changed much since then. I still prefer to sleep with the light on."

"Listen, an absolutely wonderful young lady. Right up your alley."

"An old hag too? Buys new socks so she doesn't have to wash dirty ones? Can she do a back squat with a heavy barbell?"

"Vitya, can you meet her tonight? She's in Moscow passing through, leaving tomorrow. Lives in Berlin."

"German?"

"Why German? Domestic Russian, just lives there."

Victor paused, considering options.

"At least pretty?"

"Just how you like. Most importantly — smart."

"But she's flying out tomorrow morning, you said so yourself. What, should I spend all night with her solving crosswords?"

"Latov, is it difficult for you? Believe me, it's worth it."

Victor glanced at his watch. Half past five.

"Seven at Magnolia work for her?"

On the other end of the line came a joyful exhale, immediately caught between clenched teeth.

"She'll be in a red skirt and green blouse."

"Then I'll wear my best blue suit and yellow tie," Victor answered to the short beeps on the line. He got angry, threw the phone on the couch and for some reason smiled at his reflection in the mirror. "You're already too old for adventures."

2 Valeria

GERMAN citizen Valeria Lehmann was taking a bath. When she had claimed a room, the hotel administrator was treated to a single question from the polished lady with a foreign passport but speaking fluent Russian:

"Is there hot water in the room?"

"There's even a toilet." The clerk, tired from a long shift, couldn't help but be sarcastic. He'd seen thousands of foreigners, and only our former compatriots considered it their duty to emphasize the supposed inadequacy of Russian service.

Valeria unexpectedly liked the room. Clean, spacious, bright, like Monet's gardens. She quickly unpacked her travel bag, filled the bathtub to the brim and dove into the hot water.

Athletic people who in childhood trained to third rank in swimming, as a rule, prefer showers. Sharp, pointed streams; hot, then cold, alternating like episodes in Kubrick. Non-swimmers, lazy ones, more often prefer passive bathing. Valeria didn't like to swim. She could, but didn't like to. She loved hot, like an Abkhazian's oath, baths, pasta bolognese, Chesterton's prose and dramatic entrances. Tall, stately, with thick dark hair and a vulgar tattoo on her forearm — a memory of wild youth — Valeria gave the impression of a powerful woman. Colleagues behind her back called her "*Adolf*," which was not only unfair but also somewhat vulgar. Frau Lehmann knew about it but paid no attention.

The water began to cool. The phone in the room was ringing desperately. Valeria approached and picked up the receiver with two fingers.

"Lerka, hi. Liels."

"Valya?" "Hello. What brings you?"

"I found you a gentleman. Today, at seven."

"Wait, wait." Valeria looked at her watch in alarm. "What seven, what gentleman, have you lost your mind?"

"I ordered you a taxi for half past six, they'll take you. Wear the red skirt and something green on top. That's it, bye, I'll call again in the evening."

Short beeps sounded on the line. Valeria looked at the silent phone in amazement. Once long ago she had complained to Valya about the impossibility of meeting a decent person in Germany. Half past two in the morning, some dive in the center of Moscow. They had met by chance then, and parted without regret in different directions after a couple of hours. Turns out, Liels hadn't forgotten about that conversation and she had a date in an hour and a half.

Valeria suddenly laughed merrily and jumped on the bed. Why not? She opened the suitcase and pulled out

the red skirt she'd bought at the Berlin airport just to kill time. Back then it seemed she'd just thrown money in the trash.

"There you come in handy!" Valeria cheerfully muttered and headed back to the bathroom. The door slammed behind her with a sharp click, abrupt and alarming, like the shot of a starter pistol.

3 Dinner at Magnolia

A small hall in oriental style. Walls draped with fabric, elegant wooden tables and chairs. On the walls — an eclectic exhibition of cold weapons, dishes, women's jewelry. Under the ceiling — an ornament associating in the mind of an unsophisticated person simultaneously with the Altufyevo flea market and the word "Samarkand." Not deserted, but not too crowded either.

"Hello, Victor."

"Very pleased, Valeria."

"Let's go over there."

An unoccupied table in the corner. A sign saying "*Reserved*"; Victor casually flipped it over when they approached. A prim waiter, two menus in dark leather bindings, opened exactly in the middle. Please, choose. Victor immediately opened the wine list. They were silent.

"Will you allow me to order?"

"Try me."

Awkward silence waiting for the instantly vanished waiter. A glance slightly over the shoulder, furtively. The skirt suited Valeria, Victor wore his best shoes. None of this was visible behind the tablecloth hanging

almost to the floor. Finally, they were given the opportunity to order.

"Carpaccio, two gazpachos..."

"And *Corbaccio* by Boccaccio, please."

"What?"

"Nothing, sorry, slipped out."

"Uh... Are you hungry?"

"Not particularly."

"Then also two cutlets in mustard sauce, a glass of Chilean dry wine and two hundred grams of vodka."

The waiter bowed sickeningly politely, took the menus and retreated toward the kitchen.

"Do you like Chaucer?"

"Expected question. The tales are somewhat bloated, like the face of a hungover aristocrat in the morning. The poetry, however, is unexpectedly elegant and even poignant. No, I don't like him. But he's certainly more diligent than Boccaccio, especially in relation to plot overall and to the fair sex in particular."

"Mandelstam?" Neither of them could figure out where the path of this conversation was leading, but both obediently followed it, just so they wouldn't sit silently staring at empty plates.

They brought the carpaccio.

"Mandelstam clearly lacked technique."

"That smacks of snobbery. Is Prigov the idol of millions?"

"Perhaps I simply don't understand poetry well."

A bow toward the examiner. Your head is big, you think. And I'm just here casually dining.

People around were conversing animatedly, discussing recent matches, talking about career successes, gossiping. Under the ceiling hung a dense hum of voices,

as if someone had disturbed a beehive hiding behind the ornate lamps. The velvet wall covering muffled timbres but didn't absorb sound. The feeling — like in the metro. A little more, and the next train would arrive.

"Why did you bring up Boccaccio?"

"Can't stop at the *Decameron*. Besides, I don't like Italians. They're somehow ornate in all their manifestations. From cuisine to architecture."

"How's your salad?"

"Salad?"

"Yes. It's silly to ask about the taste of a dish you just ate yourself. Even sillier — about something only your companion tried: what do you care about his preferences! I prefer discussions on abstract topics. A game of imagination."

"Aha. Flight of fancy, parade of illusions, triumph of discourse, Higgs boson."

"You graduated from philology or something?"

"Done."

"What?"

"*Graduated from* — is incorrect. The right wording is *finished*."

"Forgive me graciously. If you haven't noticed, you're the only language purist in this city. *Language purist*, by the way — is an excellent epithet. He was grandiloquent and language-puristic."

"... The salad is disgusting. Too much arugula, croutons undercooked, chicken practically cold. Instead of parmesan — who knows what."

"You have good imagination."

"What I have, you can't take away. Besides, I happened to lunch here recently."

They noticed the second course had appeared on the table. There are such waiters, inconspicuous, as if made of glass. Until the moment they need to replace an ash-tray or fill a glass. Then they grow from nowhere, perform their ritual with polished movements and dissolve back into space.

"May I call you V. L.?"

"Don't be shy, use the full abbreviation."

"Full?"

"A. V. L. — That's what they called me in school. Achat, Vente, Location. Or Adelson-Velskii and Landis. It depends on what kind of trees you prefer."

"I have the feeling you're mocking me."

"I never mock anyone. At most — I tease gently."

Silence. No longer as viscous as before the carpaccio. Then — another three hours of conversation about nothing. More precisely, about something that certainly has nothing to do with yesterday's football match results, business successes, or the chief accountant's new earrings.

"How long have you lived in Berlin?"

"Long enough to hate the city."

"Then why don't you leave?"

"Home," she stumbled and Victor for some reason felt embarrassed. "Work. You're not a native Muscovite?"

"No."

"From St. Petersburg?" She articulated too clearly, like a news anchor at a speech therapist appointment.

"Nope, Yekaterinburg. More precisely, Sverdlovsk."

"So why do you live in Moscow?"

"Home,..." Victor couldn't resist the phonetic parody. "...Work."

Valeria smiled sadly.

"Will you allow me to see you off to the plane tomorrow?"

"Are we leaving already?"

"Allow me not to fake an important phone call, especially since I left my phone at home. But I really do need to gradually go."

"Yes, I should go too."

The waiter materialized from nowhere again.

"Two coffees, blacker than night in Addis Ababa. And the bill. And please call a taxi."

Victor drank the ristretto in one gulp, glanced at the receipt, put some cash on the table. Bowed primly, smiling only with his eyes.

"Flight's tomorrow at ten to seven."

"Thank you for a pleasant evening. And yes. Mandelstam — is a good poet. Brilliant."

4 Morning at Domodedovo

THE road to Domodedovo turned out more pleasant and faster than Victor expected. He chuckled, remembering how suddenly yesterday he had offered his escort services in such a perversely truncated form. He considered himself quite good at reading people and knew this woman would have gotten to the airport on her own in any case.

Valeria had talked with him as an equal for several hours straight. Didn't take offense at his barbs — sharp, on the edge of acceptable. Submissively smiled at unsuccessful jokes.

Victor turned off the Third Transport Ring and pressed the gas pedal almost to the floor.

Passing the checkpoint at the turn to Kashira, he waved amiably from the window to a half-asleep young sergeant. The latter perked up, blinked and straightened his uniform — exactly like a sparrow awakened by the first ray of dawn.

The parking lot had plenty of free spaces. Victor took a ticket, carefully parked and got out of the car. Now he could take his time.

Last night he'd called Liels, hoping to ask more details about his new acquaintance, but Valdis didn't answer the phone. Apart from her condescending attitude toward Chaucer and the Silver Age poets — Victor knew nothing about her. He began building hypotheses.

For some reason he was certain Valeria dealt with finance. Not trading stocks, of course, not playing the exchange, no. Some university, PhD, "Laws of Chinese trade relations' impact on the development of young economies of young South American democracies." Something like that. She spoke German fluently enough, he'd checked. When he suddenly switched to Berlinisch — she wasn't scared, didn't even seem surprised, simply continued the conversation in Hochdeutsch. She'd left Russia in the mid-nineties, with her surname that hadn't been difficult. Native Muscovite, or had worked long with image consultants — Victor didn't ask directly.

She'd heard the surname Ovechkin, knew who Vasmer was, had read Chandler.

If she weren't flying out in two hours — he should marry her right today.

Lost in thought, he almost missed her in the flow of people pushing through the revolving doors. Rolling a suitcase behind her, small, shamelessly bright yellow. In her hands — an elegant handbag of unknown color. Blue jeans, white blouse. Stands out in the crowd. Miss Sex Appeal and Charm.

Victor took several steps forward, waved his hand, waited while she passed through the metal detector frame.

Looks fresh, as if it were noon on the clock.

Valeria strode broadly in his direction. Smiled. Unbuttoned the top button, casually, as if by accident. With a habitual gesture threw a strand of hair behind her back.

5 Airport Meeting

“WELL look at that, he came”, thought Valeria. “Pity Valya didn’t answer the phone yesterday. Questions. Is he really a reporter, like he says? Unlikely. Doesn’t seem like it. Too much dignity, slightly worn, but still polished. Well-read, erudite. Naïvely hoping to surprise me with Canterbury gossip. Pretends he knows German and understands dialectal differences. Barely restrained myself from answering in Bavarian.” Fifteen steps remained to Victor. “He came, imagine that.”

Shouldn’t have played *Marie de Gournay* yesterday, should have asked for a ride to the airport, since he’s so glad about the acquaintance. He could use about fifteen centimeters of height, otherwise all these shoes will need their heels sawed off.

“Attention passengers departing on the Moscow London flight, six fifty, Domodedovo Heathrow” suddenly, as always in airports, the sky spoke in the voice of a deadly tired teacher giving dictation. Valeria flinched.

She disliked waiting areas. She had to fly a lot, she could have gotten used to it long ago, but — hadn’t. She disliked changing places and distrusted the axiom of commutativity. People in such settings become mere ants, completely lose their individuality. Everyone has

identical black or blue (Valeria specifically bought herself a yellow one) suitcases; everyone hurries, rushes, fusses, though boarding hasn't been announced yet. As if their homes were destroyed by a sudden hurricane and they found themselves on the street, in a crowd, alone and lost.

Valeria slowed her pace to avoid crashing into Victor.

They greeted each other and fell into strained silence. At five in the morning even old friends find it hard to conduct polite conversation.

They announced the start of registration and Victor with visible relief grabbed the handle of her suitcase. It turned out heavy, like a sack of cement.

"Didn't expect that," Valeria chuckled to herself. "Probably thinks I'm hauling rose petals back and forth. Why did I unbutton that blouse? How can I bend down now to adjust my shoelace? Button it back up — he'll be offended, or, worse yet, upset. If he even notices."

"Come visit Berlin sometime." She suddenly said. Surprised herself with such forwardness.

"I'm there sometimes, on business. Would be happy for tours, otherwise I can't get out from under the lindens when I manage to take a walk."

Is he smiling, or am I imagining it? What kind of habit — squinting the corners of his eyes, as if a speck got into both at once? I'll give him a tour, why not.

"So when should I expect you next time?"

Victor released the suitcase handle and frowned. Patted his pockets for some reason. On his face — such an expression, as if he remembered something very important.

6 The Ticket to Berlin

“**W**AIT for me here.” What am I doing? I am to be in the office by three... — I’ll call, say I’m sick, until Monday no one will bother me. Yeah, over there.

Looked back: standing in place, waiting, slightly, it seems, surprised. At least something can throw her off balance. Damn, what an inconvenient window. Damn, damn, damn. If only I can make it. Thank God it’s Air Berlin — not Aeroflot.

“Miss, tell me, are there tickets left on the next flight to Berlin?”

“Uh...”

“Visa’s open, there won’t be problems. Here.”

“Registration is ending.”

“Don’t mess with my head, registration just started. Just sell me a ticket — if they don’t let me on, I’ll throw it away and go home.”

How much will be left on my card? Should be enough for a return ticket and a couple of döners, and we’ll see from there. I’ll write a series “Berlin Holidays.” “Planeta” might take it. Forgot to grab the camera, idiot. Will have to pay a fortune for parking.

“Check: Moscow–Berlin, flight, departure, gate.”

“I trust you completely. Thank you so much,” Victor added sincerely.

Now to return to the lady gracefully. Isn’t it a lovely day today, and all that.

“You asked when to expect me next time?” You don’t need to wait, I’m already here. — Victor grabbed the suitcase handle, like a first-grader in a pool — the lane rope. — Let’s go. Registration is at counters 40–42.

“I can manage on my own from here, thank you.”

Does she really not understand, or is she pretending? All right, we'll figure it out.

"Let's go, let's go. I must make sure you actually leave the country."

Victor thought he distinctly heard a thought flash through Valeria's mind — dense, like a tweed jacket: "What a bore."

They approached a tight scarlet clerk with a pasted-on smile and such a smooth shiny bang, as if it had been licked by a French bulldog. Victor extended his hand, palm up.

"Give me your passport."

Valeria glanced at the departure board, at the administrator behind the counter. Lowered her hand into her handbag, took out her passport. Placed it on the counter. Victor placed his next to it.

"Seat us together, please."

"You're flying first class too?" Victor became embarrassed, barely noticeably, but enough for Valeria to laugh quietly. "Like all these people in fancy clothes?"

Valeria nodded toward the short line at the neighboring counter. Four Chinese men were dressed in tuxedos, probably believing that in Europe it's customary to pretend to mock penguins around the clock. Behind them stood compatriots, two of them, in shorts and Hawaiian shirts. The taller one secretly unscrewed the cap from a flask. First class clearly promised a costume party.

The seats turned out to be in front of the emergency exit. Victor knew how to smile at unfamiliar women on duty. Courageously and modestly at once. Like Schwarzenegger in "Commando."

"So what are your plans for the evening?"

"I'll take you on a tram ride through Marzahn. It's the most unforgettable experience Berlin can offer."

"I'd like to visit the Museum of Engravings. I'm passionate to etchings."

"It's still closed at this hour."

There were no problems with documents and soon they took their seats in the cabin. Playing a game, despite the early morning. A game without a name. A game whose rules neither of them knew. The match seemed to be transitioning to the middlegame.

7 Berlin Flight

"YOU still haven't told me why you came to Moscow. It was a forced, labored, prepared in advance question. Like a freshman at winter exams. Now she'll wave it off: "On business," and he'll have to come up with a new topic for conversation.

"Certainly not on business."

They were silent.

"Candies, please. Caramel, mint." Victor extended his hand and took two candies. Passed one to Valeria: "You don't like caramel."

"Sure. Neither do I like mints." Took it, unwrapped it, carefully popped it in her mouth.

"You wouldn't happen to know where in Berlin I could rent a camera?"

"I happen to know purely by chance. I have a decent SLR."

"I intend to at least recoup the tickets with a couple of reports. *Love Parade* or something like that."

"They haven't been held since 2010. You could photograph rabbits in Tiergarten. They're terribly cute."

They took off.

"But still, why did you fly with me?"

"Don't know." A smile, fleeting, with the corners of her eyes. "I want to buy myself the same yellow suitcase."

"I bought it in Moscow."

"Then I'll steal it and sell it in Berlin. Good business."

"How did you manage to become a journalist?"

"Dreamed of it since childhood. You know, would wake up at night and write articles for the school wall newspaper. Everyone wanted to be firemen or cosmonauts, but I — a reporter. Since about age six. I didn't like uniforms, and I was very envious of Phil Donahue's shagginess."

"That being said, you applied to the faculty of Math Mechanics, failed, had to go into journalism?"

"Why jump straight to 'failed'..." Seems she's from Petersburg. In Moscow they call it 'Mechanical Math'. "Maybe we should switch to informal address, since we're flying on a plane together?"

"I'll try. If I slip up — don't pay attention, with unfamiliar people it's easier and more natural for me — formal address."

"Me too."

"Don't change the subject. Why are you asking me about a camera now instead of about volume two of Fichtenholz?"

"Because Fichtenholz — is a textbook for beginners, to begin with."

"And you're a pro?"

"What do you think?"

"I think it's time for them to bring lunch."

"In general, already in my last years at the University — I was freelancing. Defended my thesis, and continued down the well-worn crooked path."

"Into television?"

"I'm not particularly photogenic. Into glossies."

"Ten tips on how to win a woman in one evening?"

"Analytics, cooking, travel."

"An unusual set."

"Gentlemanly, insofar as that's even possible in our profession."

"Verifying culinary art with algebra? Calculating routes on a logarithmic ruler? Ana-, goddamn, -lyzing?"

She laughed merrily. Threw her hair off her forehead, looked out the window, then down the aisle. For the first time turned her gaze to Victor, eye to eye.

Iris dark, almost black. Lashes tactfully made up, from a meter away you wouldn't notice. Nose straight, a couple millimeters longer than ideal. Eyebrows swooping up, like the silhouette of a swift at sunset. Lips dry, on her chin — a dimple.

8 Valeria's Perspective

UP close he's something. Smoothly shaven, smells like morning man. White shirt collar reveals a strong neck, which has known both yoke and silk ties. Eyes green; strange, yesterday they seemed gray. Hair neat, though he last visited a barber several months ago. Ears as if glued to the skull, on the right one — a poorly healed cartilage.

"You did boxing or something?"

"Jujitsu a bit, in my youth. Why, is Berlin so dangerous?"

"Can you not be sarcastic?"

"Can't. If I stop being sarcastic, I'll start snoring and drooling."

"Why did you ask about Mandelstam yesterday?"

"Had to ask about something. Discussing the weather seemed vulgar to me. I had a choice: retell my latest article or..."

"...Ask some non-committal question."

"Well yes."

"But why specifically Mandelstam?"

"Because I was afraid to embarrass you with Rilke's name. Not to mention Keats and W. H. Auden."

"Do I make such a bad impression?"

"Only in the first half hour."

"Your incubation period lasts much longer."

"I'm just really like this."

"Playing poor is customary at the immigration office."

"I can never manage to schedule a *terмін*."

Another smile.

"Yeah, I also terribly dislike when they stir language with foreign words."

They were profoundly silent, each about their own thoughts.

"Let's still plan today's route. If you didn't lie to me about your free evening."

"Nobody said anything about a free evening."

"But what about tramming this Marzahn?"

"Will have to postpone several business meetings and two dates scheduled half a year ago."

"Forgive my immodesty, not for profit, only for the cause and maintaining combat professional spirit..."

"On Wannsee."

"What — on Wannsee?"

"I live on Wannsee. You were going to ask about the camera, right?"

"Yes, but it's not necessary."

"We'll arrive around eight local time. I need to change and take a shower anyway. You can walk near my house around the cemetery, or study the best examples of German periodicals."

"You live opposite a cemetery?"

"Rather, the cemetery was laid out opposite my house."

"Please fold your tables." They didn't notice how the flight attendants rolled the cart with lunch up to them. Victor felt a sudden attack of hunger. So did Valeria.

9 Berlin Arrives

THE packets with provisions rustled like a herd of hedgehogs pushing through thickets of burdock. Lunch on a plane — a ritual as far removed from consuming food as a black-and-white newspaper reproduction of the Sistine Madonna from the original. Nevertheless, all two hundred passengers dutifully cut the bun with a dull plastic knife, spread butter on it and eat this half-baked product, washing it down with tasteless tea with a limp slice of lemon. People don't eat to the plate's bone in restaurants, buy excess food in supermarkets, throw out expired canned goods. But no one has ever seen anyone refuse lunch on a plane. It's blasphemy. Same as eating pasta with a spoon, or showing up at a premiere at the Metropolitan Opera in a bikini.

Into the stale, flattened on both ends, cut-in-half ball of bread — thoroughly rub in jam, whose color and taste resemble flavored plasticine for small children. Carefully put down the knife, take the cup with the same hand. Take a sip, bite, swallow. Put down the cup, perch the sandwich on the edge of the table, spear an olive with the fork.

“Do you always side dish olives jam?”

“These are not olives. These are oil berries.”

“Oil berries and olives — are the same thing. Synonyms.”

“Sure.”

No argument ensued. Amazing. Usually people like to show off their vocabulary precisely in this part of the gastronomic spectrum.

“As a child I really loved dill pickles...”

“...With kefir?”

“With Pepsi-Cola.”

“Hard to imagine your childhood fell in the mid-nineties.”

“The very beginning.”

“And where did you get Pepsi-Cola?”

“Distilled it from ‘Theater’ caramel, ‘Buratino’ lemonade and baking soda.”

“Mm-m-m.”

“Returning to the olives. You’ve read Joyce, of course?”

“Of course not.”

“Nobody did. And Fowles?”

“It’s happened.”

“Remember in ‘Mantissa’ he tries to grow an olive tree; only after many years does it start to bear fruit, but gives only maslins?”

"A madman's expectations are never fulfilled. Otherwise the fundamental law of psychiatry would be violated."

"That's not the point. Imagine: you spend your whole life growing an olive."

"An unenviable fate."

"In this — lies the entire purpose of your existence. Nothing can distract you from fanatic passion. Natural disasters, deprivations, wars — everything passes as if by you, not touching the essence of your life, not affecting emotions and feelings. But all the seedlings die and you start over. Year after year."

"Am I a Greek botanist-sociopath?"

"And finally the tree grows."

"And bears maslins instead of olives?"

"Yes. But you don't know they're — the same thing. You wanted olives, you got maslins. Your life, filled with meaning, breaks off, like film in a projector with a careless operator. You know you won't have time to grow an olive tree, life has passed and it was wasted."

"But actually, it wasn't in vain. And the question is only terminology."

"Yes, but what good is that to you? You don't need *maslins*, you need *olives*."

"Knowledge that they're the same thing — is all the more insufficient for me?"

"It will kill you. People tend to die along with their dream."

They finished their tea and were now looking for flight attendants with their eyes to return the empty containers.

"Fowles never wrote anything like that."

"Well, maybe not precisely. He definitely had written something about an olive tree."

"Have you tried yourself as a philosopher?"

"I lack profundity and I don't have a frock coat."

"You know, it's surprisingly easy to talk about nonsense with you."

"Everyone wants to discuss exclusively trivia, but in certain circles for some reason it's customary to be embarrassed by such chatter. As a result the conversation becomes convoluted, saturated with incomprehensible terms and, as a consequence, meaningless."

"People are afraid of seeming ridiculous."

"The main tragedy of civilization. After the atomic bomb and the bow tie, of course."

"Actually, everyone likes clowns. Nobody likes tiger tamers, except maybe militant suffragettes."

"Paraphrasing Churchill, I can say I love omelets, but I'm not ready to learn to lay eggs for that."

"Churchill never said anything like that either."

"Do you know all the statements of all Churchills in the world without exception?"

"About eighty percent."

"My quote is from the remaining twenty. As it should be."

"The 'fasten seatbelts' sign lit up, by the way."

"About time."

"In about twenty minutes we'll be in Adlershof."

"Doesn't Air Berlin fly to Tegel?"

"What's the difference."

"Yeah, basically none."

The plane tilted to the right side, turning. In their window appeared little houses covered with tiled roofs.

The pilot muttered something unintelligibly over the loudspeaker. In ten minutes they would exit onto the runway of one of Berlin's airports.

10 Metro to Wannsee

THE chassis touched the ground and the back rows clapped raggedly. From the first class cabin came even humming, the Hawaiian shirts were discussing something in muffled basses. Flight attendants smiled with effort and asked not to leave their seats until complete stop. Another flight, unnecessary risk, absurd conquest of space and time. Two hours — and there is a foreign language all around you, different climate, flora and fauna. The pilot was relaxedly mumbling something in German. His workday was over.

Passengers began to fuss, jumped up, started rummaging in the overhead compartments, pushing and interfering with each other.

Victor grabbed the handle of the yellow suitcase.

"Are there hotels on your Wannsee? I'd also like to take a shower after the road."

"No, where from? Only a cemetery and several houses around."

"And a lake?"

"The lake was drained in the early 20th century. Land reclamation."

They opened the hatches and people streamed toward the exit. Valeria fixed her hair, stood up.

"Let's go, or we'll miss the metro."

The clerks sitting behind them, unbearably Soviet-looking, stopped glancing around and stared at them. One opened his mouth, sat for a bit like a pelican dummy, but didn't dare say anything. Valeria laughed again.

They quickly passed the people waiting for luggage, passed the smiling customs officer and went out into fresh air. Berlin greeted arrivals with sunny, welcoming weather.

The metro train arrived almost immediately. Victor froze before the closed doors. Valeria paused appropriately and pressed the button opening the entrance to the car. Shook her head.

Old train, which had seen better times. Walls and glass inside scribbled with markers. Predominating are ugly letters, intertwined like thoughts in the head of a postmodernist philosopher. Seats narrow, hard. Almost noone inside.

From the depths of the car a terrifying-looking dog was advancing toward them, dragging a young man falling asleep on his feet on a leash. The guy looked about twenty. Sparse bushes of hair on his chin, tied in a ponytail long unwashed hair. On his shoulders — a patchwork blanket resembling both a faded tent cape and a moth-eaten poncho. In his hands — a tin can. Gaze — indifferent, detached, lost in the depths of pupils.

Victor stepped aside.

"Gibt's vielleicht ein paar Pfennige?" the language of the homeless, understood by all peoples of the world.

"Keine Pfennigen seit 2001, nur die Cents, Du arschloch," the idle burgher muttered good-naturedly, sprawled on a bench, solving a crossword in *"Berliner Zeitung."*

The guy walked on.

Valeria secretly scrutinized her random companion. He raised his eyes and suddenly asked:

"You were always a straight-A student, right?"

"Only until fifth grade. B in physics and biology."

"Don't accept Darwin's theory?"

"The theory is beautiful, but it's built on completely absurd axiomatics."

"Come again?"

"Why is man suddenly appointed as the pinnacle of evolution *a priori*?"

"Because three hours ago we were in the Moscow airport, and now we're already riding under German soil on a big clattering machine, for example."

"So what? The world wouldn't collapse if we went here on foot, like two wild chamois."

"It wouldn't occur to us to go here if we were wild chamois. Besides, I'm not attracted to the fate of ungulates. They're too close to the source in all kinds of food chains."

"But they have beautiful eyes."

"Yours are pretty good too."

"Good Lord! Is that a compliment?" "I thought you were only capable of mocking and looking at accidentally undone buttons on my blouse."

"That's not a compliment, it's a statement of fact. And there's nothing reprehensible in me monitoring your wardrobe. Maybe I intend to hire on as your valet? And you undid the button yourself, to begin with."

"So about food chains. Imagine the *real* hierarchy is this: clover, then cow, human, mosquito, swift — and, at the very top, a hawk. Or whoever eats swifts?"

"Swift-eaters. Though they went extinct about fifteen thousand years ago. You managed to get a B? Was the teacher a young graduate student, fond of short skirts and meek glances from under a coquettishly uncombed bang?"

"Have you ever been told you talk like a butler in Bunin's novels?"

"Pompously and vulgarly?"

"Yeah."

"No, never. Except the first wife after the divorce. Actually, swifts are hunted by the hobby. Such a caricature falcon."

"Making it up again?"

"Would never allow myself such liberty, ma'am."

"You're surely an agnostic?"

"I don't even know such words. I always got C's in theosophy. And that only thanks to a young graduate student."

"Fond of clumsy flattery, heavily sprinkled with languid glances at slightly opened knees?"

"While I still hoped for a B, had to go even further."

"But didn't live up to expectations? We transfer at the next stop."

"We'll transfer."

"Listen, if I were uglier and dumber..."

"I'd fly to Tegucigalpa."

"That's if uglier."

"That's if dumber."

The train stopped, they exited onto the platform, leaving the conversation threatening to venture onto a dangerous mountain trail in the car. Victor concentratedly rolled the suitcase forward.

"You navigate yourself well."

"There are signs everywhere and only one of them says 'exit'."

"What are you actually planning to write your report about?"

Shrug of shoulders, barely noticeable nod. Either gathering thoughts, or just his arm went numb.

"Berlin Holidays. I'll translate Dalton Trumbo's libretto to German, from there to Russian. My own mother won't recognize it."

"Plus some photos from last year's Love Parade?"

"Something like that."

A train arrived.

"Then the usual route 'Reichstag — Siegessäule — Charlottenburg — Kudamm' isn't interesting to you."

"Why not."

"I have an idea. Let's go to Potsdam tonight?"

"Let's just walk the streets where no tourist foot has trod? Today is our walking day."

"So, Marzahn after all?"

"I'll treat you to a döner."

Long, lingering look, head to toe. As if the wardrobe immediately needed replacement — from shirt collar to polished early morning, but already slightly dusty, boots.

"You have enough even for two döners?"

"Worst case, I'll find a homeless dog in Marzahn and go begging."

"There's your ready material for a whole series of articles."

"Indeed."

"Okay, it's early nine now. We'll be home at nine. There's a café nearby — you'll have breakfast and I'll pick you up there at eleven."

"Just keep in mind, I'm completely alone here, don't know the language, if you abandon me — I won't even get to the embassy. Especially from your boonies."

"But yesterday you were showing off your terrible Berlin accent?"

"An accent isn't enough if you need not to make an impression, but to find the way."

"I haven't tamed you yet, so I'm not responsible."

"Yet' sounds promising."

The train stopped at Wannsee. Three bus stops flashed by instantly. Outside the window — a landscape resembling Moscow suburbs. Lots of greenery, sedate pensioners walking dogs.

The café turned out to be right at the stop.

The suitcase politely but firmly transferred to its owner. Wave of hand, expressive glance at the wrist, adorned with tiny watches. So tiny Victor had been taking them for a bracelet this whole time.

She turned and walked springily to the crosswalk. Back straight, hair behind her back quivering with each step. Didn't look back.

Victor sat on the terrace, looked around and nodded to the waiter. A minute later they brought him coffee and a fresh newspaper. He needed to freshen up his German a bit.

What if she really doesn't come back?

11 The Coffee at Wolf's

V^ALERIA appeared at two minutes past twelve, earning a demonstratively admiring glance from Victor at his watch. She'd changed jeans to a light floor-length skirt, tied her hair back and left her yellow suitcase somewhere. Find three differences from the morning look.

"I checked. Tegucigalpa — is the capital of Honduras."

"Antananarivo."

"What?"

"Antananarivo. They brew good coffee here, I'm ready to wait while you go check the atlas again."

Insolent, but taste and sense of measure don't fail him. What else can you expect from a person who makes decisions in thirty seconds to fly with a stranger to another country? Reading "*Die Welt*." Or pretending to read. Mathematician working as a reporter. Herr "shoe shine." Here, in Berlin, clean shoes can only be seen early morning near the Sony Center.

There's something about him. Completely different from others, Charlotte Brontë would say about him. And at the same time alive. Doesn't reek of mothballs like the intellectuals from the Russian club in Kreuzberg. And won't rush to brush his teeth after coffee like their director.

While taking a shower, she was humming. Good thing the sound doesn't reach the neighbors, otherwise respectable Herr and Frau Zimmer might think that prim Valerí "*Guten Abend, wie geht es Ihnen*" Lehmann has lost her mind.

Today's Thursday, could make an interesting weekend. Really go to Potsdam? Doesn't look like a gigolo. But didn't offer to sit down either.

"Are you going to keep impersonating a monument to the soldier-liberator? Coffee here is indeed not bad, you probably already know that."

"I know." Waved toward the bar. "Wolf, *noch ein Kaffee, bitte*."

"Do you have your driver license with you?"

"Yes."

"Then for the weekend we would've gone to Wernigerode. Will you believe in witches?"

"Ve voo vee ve ve. Ve veel-y veel ve-lieve in vee-tches.
Ve vee ve ve."

"What?"

"Indulging in alliteration. Like Golding's heirs."

"It's about three hundred kilometers, but it's worth it."

Wow. The weekend. Pressed her lips tightly, like a hockey goalie — pads at a penalty shot. Stay calm. This is what you wanted. Already more than sixteen hours — you've been trying not to think about this only.

"You don't work on Sundays?" What am I saying?

What is he saying?

"Don't work. Like all the rest of Germany. Strong unions here. Even stores are closed."

"Then we'll definitely go."

"Today we'll walk around the center."

"And the camera..."

"...I left it in the car. We won't walk from here on foot."

"Thank you."

"Not yet for anything."

Victor with a habitual gesture tossed back the coffee remains, put his credit card on the table. Valeria with a flick, more like a flick on the forehead, sent it along the glass surface of the table back toward Victor.

"You're a guest and, besides, you're saving up for döners." Wolf, *zu meinen Account, bitte*.

"Ja woll." Came from somewhere behind the counter.

"It's not customary here to pay with credit cards for coffee. High taxes, this and that."

"I'll know."

Valeria drove a bright yellow, suitcase-colored *Smart*. It looked like a matchbox on wheels. Victor had a part in his childhood construction set that clearly inspired the creator of this car.

"It won't flip over at the nearest turn?"

"Not impossible, but together we'll easily put it back on its wheels."

"Maybe we'll drive in the bicycle lane?"

"You probably love jeeps?"

She became still, waiting. She's interested. Apparently, she left the country just in the era of raspberry blazers. Back then only bandits and traffic police colonels drove jeeps.

"No. I'm just an adherent of stability."

"It's stable, believe me."

"Even when you press the gas pedal?"

"Even when you turn the wheel."

Need to stop this topic. She clearly likes the car. Why needle her? Victor opened the door on the passenger side.

"If you want, you can try it yourself."

Holds out the keys, smiles, sparkles in her eyes.

"I haven't driven an automatic in a long time."

"Accelerated driving courses. Two in one. Buy the lady coffee and get two hours driving an automatic free."

"Technically, you paid for coffee, but all right, let's."

He's one of those who'll crack jokes even in line for the dentist. Fun at first, but gets boring quickly. Offends the *Smart*, but clearly not maliciously: look how he got embarrassed and changed the subject. Well, for once I'll drive on the right.

Victor climbed into the driver's seat and looked around.

"That lever there..."

"Yes, thanks, I've already remembered something."

Closed the doors, started moving.

"Don't your grimaces, dodges, smirks ever bore you?"

"Terribly boring."

"Then..."

"...why? Something like a protective reflex. Everyone takes me for a fool and doesn't notice when something really annoying to others slips through."

"A misanthrope in a jester's cap?"

"All jesters — are misanthropes. If you believe Shakespeare."

"If you believe Shakespeare — all people are misanthropes."

"That too."

"There's a speed limit here."

"Really?"

"Seriously. I don't want to spend three years paying off the fines you'll collect in half an hour."

"Sorry."

"It's nothing."

He drives well. Confidently, not too fast, as if casually leaving behind self-assured dandies in sports cars.

"So how do you like the automatic?"

"An ordinary go-kart dreaming of becoming an SUV."

"Ugh on you."

Said it playfully.

How playfully she said it!

Too bad the mirror only shows the road running away behind.

"Where's your Autobahn?"

"It's hard to get to the center via Autobahn."

"We're going to the center?"

"Well yes. Sights."

"Right."

"Do you like music?"

"I do. But don't understand it. So I prefer listening to news."

"You understand the news?"

"Not always either, but, you know... Politics has a certain charm, akin to abstract art. You can be absolutely clueless about it and pass for a knowledgeable person."

"Why?"

"If you think about it — no reason. Honestly, I don't really believe René."

"Which one: 'politics will take care of you'?"

"That one. Seems to me, the less we deal with politics — the more time remains for weeding beds. Not that I often weed beds."

"The question was just snatched from my tongue."

"That's why I don't do reports from political events. Used to try. They say something even came out."

"No doubt."

So, I admitted his abilities aloud. If he doesn't curl up and start reflecting bronze — he's ours.

"Anyway, they sometimes still invite me to planning meetings. I'm ready to blurt out something. But laying out a couple of thoughts consisting 80% of profanity — into three thousand tolerant characters — isn't a job for me. That's what interns are for in any editorial office."

"So you just give them ideas for free from which they can make a good article?"

"Rather, they give me the opportunity to do reports like today's."

"Reports?"

"Well yes. Show me your camera, by the way."

"Turn left here. We'll arrive in a couple minutes. You can look at your camera there."

"Well, it hasn't become mine yet. But if it turns out even slightly similar to its owner — I'll be very happy to meet it."

If he makes all his compliments in this style, no wonder the first wife left him, and the rest since then never came. Nobody would like it.

She seems to like me. Woman-oxymoron. Probably good to drink beer with her on Fridays in a sports bar. Or play chess. Suspiciously beautiful, though. But that's not really a problem.

12 Alexanderplatz

THEY parked near Stadtmitte. Victor hung the heavy camera around his neck. The sidewalk, narrow as the neck of a Soviet vodka bottle, forced them constantly to step aside and let oncoming pedestrians pass. After a few minutes they slipped out of the alleys onto a wide boulevard. Stopped at a pedestrian crossing. In the distance — a grotesque building hidden behind a high fence. A huge brass plaque was bolted to the gates; the text indiscernible from where they stood.

"Let everyone in, let no one out, right?" Victor nodded at the plaque.

"Rather, the opposite. I gave this place several hours of my life."

"An oasis of homeland in the desert of triumphant capitalism?"

"I'd say, an enclave."

On the other side of the gates strolled imposing young men with machine guns in their hands. Hard to imagine that a person could so easily divide the world into two touching but completely alien parts.

"Yin and yang."

"Yeah. Doctors in China thought clearly broader than papa Zigo. This sign, it's about unity and struggle of opposites, light and darkness."

"Corpuscular-wave dualism."

"About that. Eternal opposition. Collision of morals, principles, goals. The limit of the permissible. State border. And the dots — that's us, emigrants."

The light turned green. Valeria took her companion by the arm and they stepped onto the pavement. Crossed to the opposite side and walked on, toward Friedrichstrasse.

"So we're no longer under the lindens."

"If I were eighteen, I'd sit sideways on that bench over there, throw back the tails and write a lyrical poem."

"You write poetry too?"

"Calling it poetry could only be done by a seminarian in a fit of juvenile self-admiration. And only in the first three minutes after writing."

"Why?"

"Like any other craft, poetry consists of two components: mastery and talent. Have you ever seen how a master and apprentice lay a stove?"

"No."

"The art of the stovemaker is much closer to true art than it's customary to think in high society. It's wrong, by the way, to smile. First the apprentice learns for a long time: to mix mortar, determine geometry; so to

speak, the form factor of the future stove, based on available room volumes, to wield the trowel. All this a good mentor teaches. When the basics of mastery are completed, the former apprentice begins working alone. And here no master can help him: only talent, intuition and a sense of beauty."

"Joking?"

"Not at all. A stove laid according to all canons of mastery, from a textbook, with perfectly calculated proportions, from the best brick in the world and the thickest mixed mortar — can turn out to be a simple decoration, occupying a bunch of useful space. With closed dampers it will smoke, with open ones — blow all the heat outside. For the stove to hold heat, talent is necessary. Unfortunately — and this is one of the most global tragedies of human life — to find out whether you have talent for laying stoves is possible only after completely honing mastery. This often takes more than a year. You have no other profession. And here — you lay one, second, third stove — and they light poorly, spit smoke and soot into the hut... and that's it. All this beautifully laid pile of bricks, lovingly wrapped in conscientiously made mortar needs to be dismantled and call a master. Who from the cement remains and broken shards, hungover and gloomy, contrary to all rules, in two days will lay something lopsided, slightly crooked, with an oven in the heavens and a poorly fitted damper. And this something will light the first time, like native. With two bundles of firewood it'll heat the hut to the state of a Finnish sauna, giving all the smoke up, into the chimney, to the sky, and all the heat — into the house. Same with poetry."

"Beautiful metaphor."

"The problem is that learning the mastery of rhyming — is much easier than mastering the profession of stove-maker. And to understand in time that as a poet you're

like a kilt from grandma's blanket, is practically unrealistic on your own. Around poems there's no hut where you can measure temperature and concentration of carbon monoxide. Besides, there'll always be a friend ready to read and praise your verses. Or a girl who'll go limp and sincerely consider the stanzas genius simply because at the top of the sheet, between the title and the first quatrain, her initials will be carelessly scrawled."

"Affected cynicism doesn't suit you."

"Affected cynicism doesn't suit anyone; this isn't cynicism, it's the harsh truth of life for practically all failed journalists. Many write a novel at night — and that's only half the trouble. Much worse if between reports from summits and conferences, such a would-be creator obsessively seeks new rhymes for the word 'love'."

"Above?"

"Dove. Glove. Carrot. Socks."

"What?"

"Everything I just said was already outlined in summary by Sasha Cherny a hundred-plus years ago."

"You talk as if anyone can learn to write poetry."

"If you replace 'write poetry' with 'rhyme,' then that's exactly right. Want me to teach you?"

"Right now?"

"Why put it off. You played around in senior year, didn't you?"

"I'd coyly prefer not to talk about it."

"Excellent. Lesson one. Forget all your themes back then, all the words from John Keats' vocabulary, all those moons, deaths, centuries. At the end of the nineteenth century, if I'm not mistaken, scholastics trained in rhetoric, gathering together and conducting lengthy disputes on 'how many devils can fit on the tip of a knife.' So the

theme wouldn't distract from honing mastery. Here, for example, lindens."

"What — lindens?"

"Let's quickly rhyme a couple quatrains about lindens. Following the bouts-rimés principle. — On a boulevard running east to the West... — Now you do a line, try just to hit the beat. It's like a dance. Need it so you want to hum these lines to yourself to some vulgar tune and waltz around. — So. — On the boule-*e*-vard run-ning from east to the West. Pam pam ba pam, pam ba pam, pam ba pam pam ba."

"In boundless striving to soar and fly."

"Sit down, D. What the hell fly? We crossed this street, barely waiting for our traffic light and, heels flashing, fled into the alleys. Leave soaring and flying to Keats and Byron, let's chronicle our day. Okay, I'll do the first quatrain myself. — How was it? — On the boulevard running east to west, where embassy holds wrought and precious fence, where lindens spread wide their clawed paws..."

"Love and peace overwhelm those erring stray souls."

"How do you feel about invective lexicon?"

"Sorry. I'm just used to poetry being about lofty things."

"Poetry *should* be about lofty things. Strictly speaking, not even all of it, only sonnets. But that still doesn't mean they should contain the dust of words long dead in unequal battle with the century, the fetid breath of archaisms and other murky aesthetics of decadence. We're just writing a rhymed report. Cognac, for example, needs many years aging in oak barrels. But if you simply pour grape juice into a vat — you'll get vinegar at best. So please remove your silk gloves, put down the fan and let's try again. — On the boulevard running east to the West, where embassy holds wrought and

precious fence, where lindens spread wide their clawed paws..."

"Victor teaches the lady to rhyme reefs of prose."

"Not bad. Though the al-lit-er-a-tion is per-haps pre-dominantly pres-ent."

"... poking his nosy nose to the rhythm, I suppose."

"See, I told you you'd manage. All that's left — a couple verses. Now you start. When my impresario sells the hit to Rammstein — we'll split the money in half."

"What about now?"

"Look around. A prosperous burgher there's sitting on bench."

"Will you always talk in iambs now?"

"It's amphibrach."

"Who-brach?"

"Don't get distracted."

"A prosperous burgher there's sitting on bench, plunging eyes into us like a nut in the wrench!"

She clapped her hands. Delighted, like a small child.

"He might want to say hi but he's humble and shy, let us leave him alone make his smile to shine. No... Drains saliva in vain through his chin wicked and sly. 'Plunging eyes,' by the way — very cool. You're doing great. — There's the guard, hanging gun like a pompous knight, all non-issued visas fly past his blind eye."

"When above olden lindens soars darkness in night, he's The Catcher in Salinger's aureate rye."

"Hooray."

Valeria quickened her pace slightly, walked with an almost imperceptible dance. Victor smiled reservedly. Like a good coach prides in a first-grader who for the first time in front of parents brought victory to his team. The Spree suddenly appeared ahead of them, and Valeria gently pulled her companion to the right.

13 The Dance

EVERYTHING feels almost too simple. Just trudge side by side, just talk, just stroll. What the hell are we doing in Berlin together? How did this happen? What changed since last night? Seemingly nothing, except the time zone (imperceptibly) and the humidity of the air (not much either). And yet, here we are.

She walks beside me, carefree. Either whistling or humming. Her hair a little tousled: wind off the river. Three quatrains in five minutes — strange how easy it all is. Like climbing to the Parthenon: a moment ago the majestic stone was high above you, almost in the sky — you, eyes never leaving it, not counting the steps, just stepping — once, twice — and here you are already wandering among the columns.

The city around — like a cardboard set. Germans aren't a particularly noisy people to begin with, and in the very center of the city — all the more so — concentratedly quiet. Curiously, our stride is almost the same. No need to hurry ahead or accommodate. Walk on, look at the sky; it's a touch too blue as it is.

"So it's all that simple?

"Not hard. But don't forget: it's only the first step.

"On a journey of a thousand miles?

"The road may be shorter; that's not the point. On this path there are no signposts, no road signs, no striping. No map, no navigator, no co-pilot. A couple months of practice and a couple years of reading the greats — and muscle memory will start composing congratulatory addresses for distant relatives' birthdays for you. Though sooner than that, you'll be bored. And you'll try to create a masterpiece.

"I won't.

"You will. Otherwise you wouldn't be half-dancing right now, like a schoolkid after a first locker-room kiss.

"And?

"And nothing will come of it. With something like a hundred percent probability. Although, looking at you now, it seems to me you might be the exception. With me — it didn't work out.

"And I'll drink myself down, lose my human semblance, and shoot myself with a starter pistol stolen from the gym teacher?

"In the best case. In the worst — you'll become a journalist. To stay next to the object of desire. Next to the written word. A eunuch in the harem of Sultan Odin, surrounded by muses and other riffraff. Unattainable, like the Promised Land for a Soviet Jew.

"So you don't love your trade?

"Why not. The trade I do love. I'm a mathematician — I managed, in time, to recognize and outlive my own limitations. Once you see the ceiling overhead — the urge to squint and jump fades. I forgave the universe the surplus of lyricism mistakenly wedged into my character. But colleagues... Colleagues — yes, I'm not fond of them.

"Teach me something else.

"Well, in my youth... ahem... in adolescence — I brewed coffee rather well. Even as a guest I often had to get up to the stove. Back then I lacked the sense to hide my potentially in-demand skills.

"You're not exactly modest now either.

"There's simply no stove nearby. Anyway. Once I landed in a house where the cezve was porcelain. Some antique thing, with historical backstory and a family tree as tall as a ship's pine. It supposedly brewed coffee by itself; you only had to pour water and turn off the gas in

time. But in my hands it was to sing with new aromas. Like the organ of the Salzburg Cathedral submitting to Mozart's fingers. Reverently I poured in the coffee, added water, set it on the flame...

"And you got some vile, disgusting swill.

"Something like that.

"Forgot to utter the incantation?

"No, it's just that all my skill came from battling shitty Turkish *μπρίκι*.

"Watch your mouth, this is Berlin.

"Useless *cezves*. This one didn't need fighting — it needed simple trust. That was exactly what I didn't know how to do.

"And now, as I understand it, you've learned?

"Happy to be deluded. I'm a diligent student.

"Better you'd devoted those years of training to some worthier aim. For instance, to wean yourself from Hamletian pathos and Gertrude's intonations.

"No time left for that. Besides, provincial young ladies like it.

For a while they walked in silence. The camera thumped evenly against Victor's chest. Time, probably, to grab a bite somewhere.

14 Poetry Lesson

ASPHALT rustles underfoot. A strange sensation: you're here and at the same time not here. Once, at night, Victor found himself on a small boat off the southern coast of Crete. Silence, parted by the prow of the flimsy craft. The barely audible *susurrus* of waves. And the stars overhead. Sprays of stars, as if a miserly jeweler's hand had scattered them across the velvet of the

sky. They glittered, gleamed, and shimmered. The few passengers trying to get from a little village by the lagoon formed by the Samaria Gorge to civilization spilled onto the deck and whispered in voices tight with awe. Even the crew, surely used to this sight, did. Everyone crowded by the rails and, heads tilted back, revered. Each thought about something of their own, and all thought about the same thing. The hyperonym of every stray private thought — the eternal question of being.

“Have you, by any chance, ever been to Greece?”

“More than once. My favorite place on earth. I dream of retiring, buying a tiny café somewhere on Crete, and brewing strong black coffee for the neighbors and for tourists who’ve strayed into this backwater.”

“A noble profession.”

“Like all the others where deceit is impossible. A builder cannot tell his client, ‘Just imagine: there’s a house standing right here.’ Kyrios Kafeneo will instantly be left without a single customer if he stirs instant muck in the cups and unctuously serves it to patrons with the words ‘The best coffee on the island’ or like.”

“If you can’t work with your head — work with your hands.”

“Unfortunately, for the last hundred years this apophthegm has been inverted beyond recognition.”

“You’re looking around — afraid of running into acquaintances?”

“Afraid of not running into a kebab shop. Somewhere around here they make absolutely wonderful döners. I just don’t remember exactly where.”

“You gotta be kidding. There’s a main railway station nearby.”

"Yes. In a place like this a tourist won't eat — unless they're literally starving. So the main clientele are locals. They won't come back if the meat turns out not juicy enough, and the sauce — not quite spicy."

"Strictly speaking, we don't have to follow plan A. We can eat more substantially."

"In the evening. Let's just snack now: enough not to fall asleep on the move, but not collapse from fatigue."

"I listen and obey."

She stopped, fastidiously inspecting the facades around.

In contre-jour she's dazzlingly beautiful. Not even a full day has passed. Who would have said yesterday at this time: in a day you'll be hunting for an inconspicuous döner shop on Friedrichstrasse to fortify yourself before continuing a walk with a German woman of Russian origin (or vice versa? — doesn't matter) — would have laughed right in their face. How well that blouse suits her after all.

On the other side of the street an elderly German couple floated slowly by. Glasses glittering in the rays of the midday sun. For some reason the first thing you notice about all elderly foreigners is their glasses. Walking hand in hand. The man balding; thin and tall as the staff of Seraphim of Sarov. On his feet — ankle boots, gaiters, Bavarian knee-breeches. A white, meticulously ironed shirt. Young Europeans don't iron shirts now, at least not until they land a job at a bank. A feathered hat, a hawkish nose. His wife — short, dry as a leaf accidentally fallen from the sixth volume of the first edition of Brockhaus. Her lips — a bright crimson scrap of embroidery thread, accidentally caught on an invisible hangnail on her chin. Victor instinctively grabbed his camera, took several shots. The German woman barely perceptibly raised the corners of her thread-lips upward and waved. Her husband said something to her, leaning toward her ear. With a confident, imperious sweep she

waved him off. A habitual gesture, like the snap of a clapperboard by an assistant director.

Valeria waited patiently while Victor earned his unlikely fee. Suddenly he whirled around sharply and took several quick, fleeting shots of his companion. Her hair a bit disheveled, in her eyes sparkles burned and shimmered, like those very stars in the Cretan night. Clapsed her hands above her head, spun around her axis. Click-click. Click. Made a curtsy. A few more frames.

"Since you've uncovered it already, — Victor muttered. — Besides, it seems to me you're very photogenic."

"I hate being photographed."

"I noticed."

"I never come out looking even remotely like myself."

Valeria suddenly put on a serious expression, as if blinds had descended over her face. Pointed a finger at one of the buildings across the way.

"That's where we're going."

Three minutes later they were already greedily chewing their döners, pinching off crumbs from the bun and tossing them to the insistent pigeons circling around.

How deliciously he eats... As if he's not wolfing down a piece of white bread with finely chopped chicken, but performing a ritual of taking food at an exquisite reception for a king.

Victor chewed, looked to the side and said quietly:

"Consuming a döner becomes you greatly. Truly. I never pay compliments — only truth."

"Better compliments after all," Valeria laughed. With an elegant wrist movement sent the last piece into her mouth, wiped her hands with a napkin.

"Well, shall we continue our tour."

15 Along the Boulevard

“YOU grew up in Leningrad, didn’t you?” Stealthily cast a glance to the left, returned it. Assumed the air of a bored dandy at the racetrack who’d secretly bet his entire fortune on a no-hoper.”

“Can’t hide anything from you.”

“Wouldn’t even advise trying.”

“I learned to say ‘Math and Mech’ here in Berlin already. It’s customary to breach ramparts with the heavy end.”

“Still.”

“I’m — a boulevard girl.”

“Bold intro.”

They emerged onto Alexanderplatz. The famous clock literally forced Victor to remember his profession. Put the camera in his hands. Habitual movement, the viewfinder flies to his eyes. Several shots on the go. The composition lacked foreground; Victor knew: the photos would come out resembling theatrical scenery before the performance begins.

“Please walk ahead.”

“For a magazine cover I’m short about three hundred grams of makeup.”

“One second.”

Victor bolted from his spot and in three leaps found himself beside some black man selling meaningless junk with pretensions to authenticity. Returned in a couple seconds bearing in his hands a Mexican shawl of unimaginable coloring and a sombrero.

“Try it on.”

“Are you a color-blind psychopath with fetishistic tendencies?”

“Just try it on.”

Valeria threw the shawl over her shoulders, stuck on the sombrero, drew her brows to the bridge of her nose and threw up her arms. Grasping the ends of the shawl, rose on tiptoes and began mincing her feet rapidly. Victor selflessly clicked the camera.

Several idle strolling tourists stopped nearby, started clapping; at first out of sync, but quickly oriented themselves. The applause turned into a canvas, a beat, a rhythm, directing Valeria in her spontaneous dance. On-lookers clustered around, formed a closed ring. The clapping grew louder and louder, someone took on the functions of conductor. Valeria closed her eyes and continued spinning, like a medieval shaman performing a ritual. Victor clicked the shutter in unison with the rising roar around. Suddenly Valeria stopped. Opened her eyes, smiled dazzlingly, took a step toward Victor. The spectators started clapping out of sync, then the ovation subsided. Victor lowered the camera and intently enchanted stared at Valeria approaching him. Eyes wide open, on her cheeks — a flush. Out of the corner of his eye he noticed the equipment vendor from earlier in the crowd. The final step.

Valeria embraced him with both arms and kissed him firmly. Pressed her entire dance — into his lips, put a period. Fat, weighty — like a signature under a verdict. Applause rang out with renewed force. Valeria turned to the people, bowed barely noticeably. Victor, mouth agape, stood in the middle of the proscenium, like a monk who’d wandered by mistake into the locker room of a women’s rugby team.

Gradually people began dispersing. Timidly and enthusiastically glancing back, showing Valeria extended upward thumbs — a gesture of admiration and approval understandable to anyone. Many looked at Victor, and it seemed to him that envy distinctly flashed in the men’s eyes.

Valeria touched him with her lips once more — this time on the cheek. He turned his dazed gaze to her. She removed the hat, lowered the shawl from her shoulders — and, with this movement, the enchantment of the last ten minutes vanished, evaporated. Before him stood the previous Valeria. Strict, composed, in her primness somewhat resembling an English literature teacher.

"You dance amazingly."

"Just let your body go."

"What?"

"You should have seen your eyes three minutes ago."

"I was frozen in admiration."

"That's probably exactly why I wanted to dance."

"The cause-and-effect link limps a bit, but I'm very pleased to hear it."

"Doesn't limp at all. You didn't give me a single reason to doubt that you wouldn't object if I suddenly accidentally went briefly mad."

"Flattery is accepted on Mondays from three to six."

"So, shall we move on? Marzahn's over there."

"I must treat you to a glass of something refreshing. Can we get a little drink somewhere around here?"

"A real holiday?"

"The realest. — Thank you," Victor suddenly caught himself awkwardly, as if remembering something very important.

"For what?"

"For moments of communion with the beautiful."

"How about instead of thanks — you just buy me a little glass of port wine? No need to make me blush."

"You can't blush, you flimsy liar."

They turned into some alley and in five minutes were already sitting in the dark empty café hall. The bartender was slightly surprised by the patrons' early order — two coffees, a shot of vodka and a shot of port wine, — but fulfilled everything more than promptly and immediately returned to the eternal occupation of all bartenders — polishing glasses.

"Doesn't it seem to you that among bartenders there's a belief that to get into paradise — it's enough to never once leave a single glass insufficiently sparkling?"

"Seems? I know for certain. One of them told me himself."

"A real sect!"

"Yep."

They clinked glasses in passing, drank. Two swift gulps of coffee. Rose to their feet.

"Does the holiday continue?"

16 At the Café

JUST OUT OF CURIOSITY... Do you keep a blog?" They left the café and wandered narrow streets, turning this way and that constantly. Valeria seemed not to be following the route at all, but from time to time she tossed her head up and in the tone of a professional tour guide announced the name of this or that landmark. Victor nodded obediently, not remembering a single word. Before his eyes stood the dance. The beautiful dance under the clock at Alexanderplatz. And suddenly he asked:

"Do you keep a blog?"

"Keep what?"

"Do you have a Facebook page?"

"Yes, I kinda do. Have I bored you alive?"

"Quite the opposite. Just curious to know where you were dancing yesterday and the day before."

"Yesterday I walked around Moscow all day, and in the evening — had dinner with you in that pathetic pseudo-Asian café. The day before — was resting after a conference."

"The whole week before that — you prepared for the conference, before that two months you strolled around Berlin, and before that you went to kindergarten?"

"Approximately."

"I know nothing about you. Except the main thing: you prefer yellow and dance like a goddess."

"I hate yellow."

"Aha. And you can't dance."

"Just trying not to wear a plaid shirt and cowboy hat at the ranch."

"Afraid of getting lost in the crowd?"

"Don't want to give anyone reason to think I'm with them."

"A bunch of carrots in the lapel? A hook to the liver of morality and ethics?"

"There's life between white and black too."

"Gray, like a church mouse?"

A sad look. She pulled a cigarette from her purse. Victor remembered he hadn't smoked since five in the morning. Hastily pulled out his pack, lighter. Lit Valeria's cigarette, lit his own. Rolled up his shirt sleeve.

"Know what this is?"

"A watch?"

"Grandpa gave it to me when I was eight. At twenty-five I bought a Swiss chronometer, like everyone. At thirty — started wearing these again."

"Well, don't mess with my head."

"I don't know how to mess with beautiful ladies' heads. Unfortunately."

Valeria suddenly shook herself, pulled herself together, like Cristiano Ronaldo before a penalty kick. Quickly thought something over, by the look of it. Made up her mind.

"Listen, you need a story, don't you?"

"Wouldn't hurt."

"Let's go to Greece this weekend?"

"Why not South Africa?"

"Not ready?"

"I'm all for it. If you'll let me bring the camera."

"So, a holiday?"

"So, a holiday."

Giving in to a sudden impulse, they embraced. Valeria waved her hand, a taxi immediately pulled up beside them. The way to the place where they'd left the car seemed too long to both of them.

When they got into the Smart, Victor risked a glance at Valeria. She responded with a long, transparent gaze. What it meant, Victor didn't understand. He smiled encouragingly and pressed the gas pedal. Less than half an hour later they were at Wannsee.

17 The Flight to Greece

— **A**T the beginning of the twenty — first century the Eskimos encountered the internet, and this term had to be translated into their language. Experts chose the word "ikiaqqivik" "journey through layers." Previously this word was used to describe the

actions of a shaman who, to find an answer to some question, “traveled” through time and space.

“Turn off the TV.”

Valeria emerged from the bathroom, in jeans and a canary-yellow T-shirt with a “DG” monogram. In her hand — a towel. They hadn’t noticed when they’d switched to informal address. Somewhere halfway home. Victor had just decided to subject the Smart to an exam on road-holding. They nearly got thrown into oncoming traffic, Valeria yelped and hissed: “What the hell are you doing?” Victor straightened the car, smirked and continued driving smoothly, like a pregnant ballerina.

“You’re the one who sat me at the computer. I book tickets faster than you shower. We’re flying on some mysterious charter, regular flights are either sold out or priced at several gold bars.”

“What do Eskimos have to do with it?”

“Eskimo culture — especially semantic manifestations — is the main key to solving the mystery of the ancient Greeks.”

Valeria launched the towel toward the armchair where Victor sat with the laptop. Aerodynamics won out, the towel opened like a parachute midway, hung for a moment like the carcass of a gigantic amphibious jellyfish in the air — and glided to the floor.

“Do the ancient Greeks have some special mystery?”

“Of course. You’ve surely heard that, according to Dr. Khomenko’s version, the pyramids were built in the region of Thessaloniki, before the earth’s crust rifted, and only much later transported from there to the Giza plateau on logs, like the pedestal of the Bronze Horseman.”

“The Etruscans got lost on the way and the route ended up going through Yakutia?”

"You catch on fast. The pyramid is called *Akhet-Khufu*, it's believed to mean *Khufu's horizon*. In reality, it's a corrupted Greek *Ασχετ χυ φυ* — 'erected on blood.' And Kheops — isn't his real name either, but an anagram of his electronic signature *P.S. Όχι*. The pharaoh was known as a philanthropist and every letter to him ended with numerous petitions. As a result he was forced to order a seal from laurel root to stamp at the end of each reply epistle. An illiterate slave, carving his stamp, made errors not only in the unstressed vowel but also in mirroring, mixed up the letters. Hence it went: Kheops, yes Kheops. And he died as Kheops. Had he been more generous — he'd have entered history as Neps."

"Oh come on. So what about the tickets?"

"Booked them."

"We've got another hour and a half."

Valeria approached the armchair, leaned toward Victor's shoulder, looked at the computer. Her Facebook page, a photo from three years ago, affected and pretentious, like all female avatars. Damn, why hadn't she noticed this before? Several posts fit on the screen. Mostly — links to videos and comics. Impersonal, made on the run, notches on a doorframe. Evidence of a life full of events in a social vacuum. All except one, yesterday's. Yesterday's read: "Smart good-looking guys haven't died out in Moscow yet, yo-ho-ho." Valeria blushed.

Victor snapped shut the laptop lid, stretched in the armchair.

"Your relationship status is amusing."

"It is what it is."

"So I'm more smart than good-looking?"

"Let me rewrite it properly."

"No way, let it stay as is. For posterity. Besides, for such a knockout beauty as I am — seeing the superlative there is flattering."

She shrugged, went to the closet. Pulled out a pile of clothes from the middle shelf, glanced through it briefly, as if leafing through the pages of a boring magazine, tossed it into the suitcase open on the floor.

"I'll go make coffee."

"If you don't have a porcelain cezve, I can shake off the old days."

They went out to the kitchen together, Valeria opened one of the cupboards. Cezve, coffee, sugar. Victor bent over the stove. Water hissed on the walls of the hot cezve. In the same cupboard they found a pot-bellied bottle of cognac and two small glasses. Five minutes later they were already drinking the thick tart beverage. Victor playfully raised his glass and in the voice of a boxing match announcer pronounced:

"To the journey!"

Cinked glasses, drank. Looked at each other. Laughed merrily; first quietly, as if afraid to wake someone sleeping, then louder and louder. Three minutes later both were roaring with laughter, Valeria's damp hair scattered, Victor with an awkward movement spilled several drops of coffee on the table. If they'd been asked what made them laugh so, they couldn't have answered. Such a feeling visits us so rarely that people haven't bothered to invent a special word for it.

18 In the Air

THE apartment immediately seemed too cramped. Valeria hastily threw a few more clothes into the suitcase, slammed it shut. They agreed to stop by some

supermarket on the way; they decided to dress Victor right there on the spot, but the arrival time hinted that these were — already plans for tomorrow morning. Toothbrush and change of underwear had to be bought before departure.

“Have you ever been fishing?”

“I can’t stay concentratedly silent that long.”

“Fishing — isn’t a damp cigarette, pleasant conversation doesn’t interfere with it.”

“I heard fish get scared.”

“Fish are deaf, they have gills instead of ears. Besides, scientific-technical progress has for about two hundred years allowed urbanites to classify fishing as ‘recreation,’ not ‘subsistence.’ Journalism, by the way, is the same as fishing. A reporter’s tackle is a drag net. A correspondent’s — a spinning rod. A columnist’s — a bottom line. Photographers ply with a harpoon. Therefore those who completely lack patience become decent reporters. Lazy creatures like me, sooner or later drift to the tribe of photohunters. If you’re lucky, you’ll learn to see a shot and even on Tverskaya at eight in the evening, you’ll snap enough for bread and butter. Not lucky — sit with a tripod at the zoo, or in the forest a couple kilometers from some reclusive rocker’s villa, a retired oligarch, a thief-in-law. However, the end is usually the same — for a shot or two you’ll definitely get punched in the face, whether on Tverskaya or at Yasnaya Polyana.”

“So the profession’s not only ancient but dangerous?”

“Everything ancient is dangerous. Man invents masses of devices to make his existence safer. And as a result — loses basic survival skills. Let an average modern manager get lost in the forest without a mobile phone — and he’s done for. I recently had the pleasure of witnessing a remake of Krylov’s fable. In the modern edition it’s

called 'The Grad Student and the Scythe.' In this half-educated fellow's hands — an agricultural tool instantly turned into a cold weapon of mass destruction, more fearsome than a Scythian dagger."

"Were there no casualties?"

"I didn't have the heart to let him continue trying to commit suicide. As a result I got blisters on my hands. Does that count as a casualty?"

They entered the metro.

"Let's play that game again?"

"Let's. Which one?"

"Rhymes. I've thought of a theme."

"Easy. Go ahead."

"In the grad student's hand there's a scythe gleaming bright, and the sky blushed ahead with sunset dim light."

"He dulled the scythe on the roots in the rain, and someone cried out: 'Akela, you've missed again!' "

"They called him Akela for good reason indeed."

"They called him Akela, it's true. Then a wasp stung him right in the ass turned him sick, and his ass ached then for a long nasty week. Sorry."

"No, no, it's fine. I was even getting worried: how could it be, a journalist without any obscenity, not even in his gaze. Do you write a novel yourself?"

"Of course. Actually — no. I'm — an adherent of small forms. In everything that doesn't concern the fairer sex."

"Into basketball?"

"Played in my youth. Then my dislike for running in circles started showing, at the University I switched to volleyball, then everything smoothly transitioned to

billiards, bridge and poker. Golf and curling scare me off with their requirement for large spaces."

"Bridge didn't work out for me, but at billiards — we'll have to face off sometime. At poker — you'd clean me out, I can already tell."

"No problem. But you'll have to wait a bit; in Crete I somehow didn't notice a great number of green baize tables."

They transferred to the blue line. More people in the metro, Friday evening was approaching.

"On weekends you always need to leave big cities."

"And necessarily, to some island."

"Yep."

The crowd surrounded them and carried them into the car. Until Tegel they smiled at each other silently, only occasionally shooting glances at passengers who'd caught their attention. Valeria nodded at an elderly German who'd entered wearing a bandana and sporting a goatee. On his chest, like a powder tattoo, showed a half-faded inscription from frequent washings: *'Don't say me no!'*.

Victor strictly whispered to Valeria, "Negative." Then he himself nodded at an aging German woman holding a scrawny hideous little dog. Trembling like a tiny demon. The woman's shoulders, despite the heat, were wrapped in a cape of the same balding, half-decayed fur as her pet's.

"Dog in eternal fear, gone bald and waned. Mommy and Daddy — lie on her shoulders, unchained."

"Sh-sh-sh. Walk one stop? There should be a supermarket somewhere there."

Half an hour later, with a razor sticking out of his shirt pocket and wearing a white short-brimmed hat, he held the airport entrance door for Valeria. They had no more than an hour left to spend on German soil.

19 Conversation at Altitude

A NY journey begins at the moment of realization: the world that surrounded you just a couple hours ago has disappeared, evaporated, annihilated. Instead, an unknown magician has pulled from his top hat another reality, other sensations, other space and time. You begin noticing small, insignificant details around you that recently you wouldn't have noticed in passing. The flight attendant is taking you on a business trip — a blurry spot of bright uniform, distributing incubator food and helping adjust the air conditioner. The stewardess on the charter you're flying on for vacation — turns out to be a pretty young lady, about twenty-five, with an elegant ring on her pinky and a mole above her right eyebrow. Senses sharpen. Unexpectedly you notice peeling paint on the window shade, a fiber of bright scarlet wool caught on the armrest, the turned-up edge of carpet runner in the aisle.

"Do you fly often?"

"Have to. In childhood — it was very scary, my ears always got blocked. One time it was so bad that the pilots invited me to the cockpit and showed me some blinking lights. Switches, toggles. Now it would be breathtaking, but back then I just wanted it all to end quickly and for us to land."

"Seventh heaven."

"What?"

"The number seven. My favorite."

"Really? — Mine too!"

"Not just a number. Seven notes is no accident. God created them slowly and thoughtfully. Music is the only language understood by all peoples of Earth. Matike-topelasu."

"Topela-what?"

"That's what Finns call notes. There's a legend according to which the higher mind showed special love for one of the notes. He couldn't decide whether to put it at the beginning of the row, as the title so to speak — or conversely, at the end — as a coda. As a result, in Germanic languages the note *C* traditionally begins the row, while in Slavic ones — it closes it. In Finnish this note is called 'su.' Full name is 'sunnantai'."

"And today's mood is best suited to the note 'pe' — 'perrjantai'?"

"Exactly! By the way, the interval between *A* and 'su' — is smaller than between the others for a reason."

"Do we need to hurry?"

"No, we've got nowhere to rush to at all."

The sea appeared below. Water, expanse, vastness.

"When I look at water, I always regret not becoming a videographer."

"And at fire."

"Yes. But water's stronger. More multifaceted. Fuller."

"More powerful."

"Yes. Bright photographs of fire exist. Of water — no. Fire — is a destroyer, water — a creator."

"Tsunami victims will appreciate your optimism."

"That's not the point. Fire can also warm, help cook food, fire pots. Man managed to tame it, like a wolf. But the moment you let your guard down — fire will growl, bare its teeth, attack its master. Water — is the opposite. It helps man willingly, deliberately. And only an accident, the will of evil fate can turn it against us."

"What about the other two elements?"

"People and work?"

"Earth and air."

"Earth's handy for putting out fires, and wind is the perfect means to enrage a wave."

"What's this theory of yours called?"

"Not mine. Something similar was published about two years ago in *Okkulte Deutschland*. The title my selective memory has capriciously erased."

"They asked them to fasten their seatbelts."

"Do you have any hobbies?"

"I love to think."

"Hobby?"

"Thinking is akin to fishing."

"Sort of like meditation?"

"Meditation has nothing to do with it. Unless in the sense of 'thinking positively,' of course."

"*Thinking positively* is necessary if you want to become a *bright shiny person*."

"Somehow I don't have much desire for that. All these bright little people, the moment you end up alone with them in a room locked from outside, instantly begin spreading clouds of boredom and despondency of such density that you could sculpt a snowman from the air."

"That's not even the worst part. Real catharsis comes when several of them gather together."

"The reality show?"

"Something like that. A smart person, unfortunately, is rarely *bright and shiny*."

"Never. They have no time."

"Exactly. And these are all so positive, sparkling directly."

"We should make the same show for intellectuals. Gather several intellectuals, set up video cameras everywhere and broadcast it live."

"That show already exists. It's called *What, Where, When?*"

"No, no. For a long time, in a home setting, or something like that."

"Aha. That'll be a hit. Breakfast. Everyone comes down, in reverent silence drinks a cup of coffee. They get up, nod to each other and disperse to their rooms. To read."

"And so for six years. A heartbreaking spectacle. Could be shown alternating with reports from wrestling tournaments."

"Look, we're landing."

"Can't even believe it. Thank you. It would never have occurred to me that you could just get on a plane and fly to the sea. A real sea."

They were let out right onto the field. From the asphalt came such heat, as if hell itself lay beneath it, and tongues of flame pressed right up against the underside of the runways. The air trembled, distorting the outline of the airport building. It seemed if you brought a match close, everything would explode. Victor hastily pulled his hat down over his nose, Valeria settled for dark glasses.

"Where's the metro exit?"

"They haven't dug it up yet. Let's go, I guess we'll try to rent a car."

Part II

Forty-Two Hours

20 Arrival in Crete

THE Greek gleaming golden cup of King Minos, handed them keys, barely glancing at the licenses. "That black Volkswagen is parked over there, on Sunday put it back somewhere nearby. Leave the keys under the mat."

Victor circled for some time around the plaza adjoining the building, packed with cars, buses, barrier shields and advertising signs so chaotically, as if they'd been dropped from the cargo hatch of a passing plane. Finally, right above himself he saw a traffic light and a whimsically ornamented inscription "*Εξόδος*."

"Good that the Greeks at least didn't abandon the alphabet, with all these reforms. How subtly they rhymed time and money semantically, before the advent of eurocents on this blessed land."

"Λεπτό?"

"Yeah. So, shall we eat first, then look for a hotel? Swimming today will have to wait till closer to night."

Victor focused on driving the car farther and farther from the sea.

"Do you know where we're going?"

"Of course. Did I already tell you that you have very beautiful hands?"

"No, but it seemed to me you've been examining my ring finger the whole way."

"Only within its allotted ten percent."

"Did you graduate from a technical school for producing clumsy compliments?"

"Why technical school? Now it's called a 'lyceum.' Actually, I had very worthy teachers. 'You taught me to speak your language. Now I know how to curse — thanks for that too.'

"Süskind?"

"Early Fowles. Very early. Süskind didn't use iambs."

"So where are we actually going?"

"To Matala. We don't have reserved chambers in a five-star hotel — will have to make do with little. We'll rent a couple cots in a bungalow from some local peasant... Matala has the most beautiful sunset on the island, and the tastiest mussels. Besides, if we have absolutely no luck with housing, we can spend the night in a cave, together with hippies. Matala — is their summer Mecca."

"I swear by my life and love, that something there and that I won't allow the gloom of caves, solitude and evil suggestions of wicked spirits to defile my dreams, transform reverence into lust?"

"Süskind?"

"Almost."

"Mocking me, yes?"

"A little bit. You just had such an important pompous look when you started declaiming... Immediately wanted to don rags and take a seat in the mezzanine."

"Queens ought to have a comp ticket to the box."

"And coffee in a folding cup."

"Also possible."

Ahead of them drove a fuel tanker. Yellow as a canary, and calm as The Great Sphinx of Giza. Victor overtook it several times on deserted stretches, but as

soon as they entered some village, it, without slowing down, rushed past. Around them grew olive trees, thick air filled the cabin, intrusively got behind the collar, enveloped and lulled. Through the open windows poured the smell of wild thyme and heated stone, mixed with something sweeter — carob, or perhaps the resinous breath of cypresses growing in dark clusters along the road. Dust rose behind the car in a lazy amber cloud, hung for a moment, then settled back on the road like a stagehand lowering the curtain after a scene. The olive trunks, twisted and gnarled as the hands of very old women kneading dough, cast short shadows that flickered across the windshield in a stuttering semaphore. After another sharp turn the road went down, as if they were swinging on giant swings. In the distance the sea sparkled, violet and heavy, like molten glass in the last minutes before the kiln is sealed. Valeria gasped.

“How beautiful!”

“Gasp in my ear on a turn one more time, and I’ll mix up the pedals.”

The road twisted mercilessly. On straight sections — it seemed they were descending directly onto the beach on a funicular.

“Soon will we arrive at your hippy-town?”

“If I make this right turn now — in about half an hour. If not — we’ll fly there in a couple minutes.”

The tanker turned to a gas station in Sivas. For some time they drove completely alone on the deserted highway, then oncoming cars began appearing. A few turns — and Victor stopped the car at the pier. Got out, stretched their legs. The pier smelled of salt and tar and something faintly vegetal — kelp drying on the bollards, or perhaps the iodine breath of the sea itself, exhaling after a long hot day. Underfoot the planks were warm and rough, bleached to the color of old bone. The water in the harbor was so clear that the bottom shimmered

three meters down — pebbles, a rusted anchor chain, a beer can glinting like a fallen coin. Stood looking at the setting sun. Victor put his arm around Valeria's shoulders. She pressed against him. Stretched. Kissed him on the cheek. Holding hands, they walked along the shore. Vacationers preoccupied with urgent needs hurried toward them. Someone carried past an inflated mattress, brushing Victor. He didn't notice. He noticed nothing, striving imperceptibly to press closer to the tense, like a fishing line after the strike, body of his companion. Valeria clung to him, trying very hard to make it imperceptible; first of all — for Victor himself. They entered a restaurant stylized as a fishing schooner with a pirate slant. Sat down. Victor smiled at the friendly waiter.

"Kalispera. My wife is here for the first time. Can you do everything so she'll remember the way to you forever? And bring retsina right away, please."

The Greek beamed in a smile, scribbled something in his notepad and disappeared behind the bar.

"Wife?"

"Wife."

"Well indeed, can't very well say 'beautiful stranger with whom I accidentally had dinner yesterday, this morning flew from Moscow to Berlin, and then, carried away with flights, here to Crete too.' "

"Waiters here don't speak English very well, he simply wouldn't understand."

"And this way, apparently, he understood."

"This way, apparently, he understood. By the way, on Crete all else being equal it's better to use English. German and Russian they also understand a bit, but the average tourist from our countries..."

The waiter almost ran bringing retsina and in a couple moments set out dishes, uncorked the bottle and

poured wine. Victor slightly tilted his glass toward Valeria.

"To a beautiful evening."

"Na Zdravie!"

"With me you can continue speaking in normal language."

A couple hours later the sun completely went beyond the horizon line. They were finishing coffee, leaning back in their chairs. The Greek did everything so Valeria would remember this place. With her last strength she speared an olive the size of a ping-pong ball and sent it to her mouth. Victor eyed the uneaten shrimp that had apparently fulfilled its childhood dream of growing to lobster size. In the best Moscow restaurant such a monster would be served on a separate platter; on Victor's plate already lay the tails of five of its less fortunate predecessors.

"Now we need to solve the main problem of this evening."

"How to get up from the chair?"

"Where we'll while away this night."

Groaning, they extracted themselves from the table. Victor, who'd managed in the airport to secretly slip away to an ATM, left exorbitant tips. They were forcibly handed a "compliment" half a watermelon, a pile of sweets and ice cream in a plastic container.

"Kalinihta. Yassas."

The coastal houses were dotted with signs in broken English offering lodging. Soon they were knocking at one of them, hanging over the sea on the opposite side of the lagoon from the caves. A short elderly woman opened, wrapped in black. She didn't understand a word of English, but within five minutes had ushered them into a tiny room with a window covered

by linen curtains. Victor in broken Greek asked about a small house perched right on the shore, behind the vegetable garden. The Greek woman rattled something in her native language. Victor pretended he perfectly understood her and held out several bills. The woman nodded vigorously, quickly hid the money in her apron pocket, slipped somewhere into the depths of the house. A minute later she appeared holding a huge key, a pair of sheets from the same linen as the curtain in the previous room, and a jug with some beverage. The key she solemnly handed to Victor, the linen and jug — to Valeria. Twenty steps, fussing with the lock that hadn't opened, apparently, for several years — and they stand at the threshold of the bungalow. Inside it smelled of whitewash and dried oregano and something older — the faint mineral tang of stone walls that had sweated through a hundred summers. The plaster was rough to the touch, cool despite the heat, pocked with tiny craters like the surface of a distant moon. Under their feet the tile floor clicked and whispered with each step, loose pieces shifting in their mortar beds like piano keys in an ancient instrument nobody tuned.

"The window opens right onto the sea!"

"Means we'll have to get up at dawn."

Victor put the suitcase in the corner, took the jug from Valeria's hands, placed it on the rickety table by the window. Took her hand, gently pushed her outside.

"Let's go. Today is a magical day. Can't sit at home."

21 Sunset

THEY went to the shore, returned along the water's edge to the beach. The sun had set almost completely, the last rays gently played with the surf, scattering reflections across the water's surface like an unknown director of a shadow theater. To the right rose

a sandy hill, dotted with caves like a giant beehive. Victor bent down and scooped a handful of water, watched it seep through loosely joined fingers. Looked around. Illuminated by the sunset, Valeria looked like a silhouette cut from golden paper. As if Renoir himself had put down his brush for a minute and picked up scissors to capture fragility, the fleetingness of charm. Silently smiling, looking somewhere toward the low evening waves. Waved her hand.

"Look, a ship."

"Logical. This is the sea after all."

Victor peered into the distance, against the heavy glistening ocher water.

"Fishermen going out to set nets."

The beach completely emptied.

"Do you like solving riddles?"

"Very much. I remember, we once agreed to go with friends to the dacha. For the weekend. Shashlik, banya, this and that. And at the office, Friday evening, I was already preparing to leave, someone in passing told me about two ropes and measuring forty-five minutes."

"Oh really?"

"Right now. The solution didn't come to me immediately, though the problem isn't from the first category, frankly speaking. Got stuck. Until midday the next day I annoyed everyone with a sour face and absence of ego. Though I dutifully chopped wood, heated the banya, made toasts. But to questions addressed directly — either didn't answer at all, or mumbled something extremely unintelligible. Around two in the afternoon, Saturday, I remember it like now — it hit me. I loudly yelled something grossly invective, scaring the pious neighbor to convulsions, and returned to formation."

"Yeah, in school after math I could also turn off the outside world during history or biology. Even invented a name for this trance — 'going into Skanavi.' So what about the ropes?"

"Well, there are two ropes, one burns for exactly thirty minutes, the second — an hour. They burn unevenly, meaning half the rope doesn't necessarily burn for half the time. Need to measure forty-five minutes. Just don't go into Skanavi until tomorrow evening."

"Won't. Remind me day after tomorrow, will have something to occupy myself at Monday's meeting."

At Monday's meeting. The words sliced the air like a box cutter — festive wrapping of an expensive gift. In two days he needs to submit material at his editorial office in Moscow. Valeria at that time will be solving the problem — his problem about the ropes — at her meeting in Berlin. Over two thousand kilometers. Three hours flight. And — about fifty hours ahead.

"Why the question about puzzles?"

"Life threw me one here. In the city of Dmitrov there's a street called 'Birlovo Field.' Located on the outskirts. It's known that house №8 has a store. What's the minimum number of houses that could be on this street?"

"Five. If we dismiss the variant with a mad architect who numbers houses by throwing dice."

"Why five?"

"In Dmitrov, like in the rest of Russia, unlike, say, Germany, houses are numbered by even and odd sides of the street."

"So."

"Therefore in Berlin the presence of the eighth house promises the presence of the previous seven, and with us — guarantees only the presence of the second, fourth and sixth."

"That's still four."

"House on the outskirts — I assume this condition didn't arise by chance and can only mean that the street is recently built, meaning it's unlikely a couple houses have already been demolished."

"That's all true, but where's the fifth?"

"If there were four houses, the side would be odd. Numbering in countries that agreed with Arabs on gematria, starts from one. So there also exists house №1."

Victor smiled. Approached, embraced Valeria. Carefully kissed, as if afraid to tear an invisible web. She clung to him. Responded to the kiss, parted moist lips. Time stopped. They learned each other, stronger and more recklessly. When Victor opened his eyes, the sun had completely set. He firmly pressed Valeria to himself, tilted his head and looked at her slyly.

"Let's go over there. Since we came to the sea — makes sense to swim."

"My swimsuit's in the suitcase back there."

"Not going back for the suitcase over that."

They walked deep into the beach, to the caves themselves. The sand, still warm from the day's sun, yielded under their bare feet with a faint sugary crunch; closer to the cliffs it turned coarser, mixed with pebbles and fragments of shell that pricked the soles pleasantly. From the caves came a low, hollow breathing — the sea pushing air through rock, a sound like a sleeping giant's exhale. Crickets stitched the darkness with their needles, and somewhere far up the hillside a goat bell clanked once, twice, then fell silent. Natives at such a time already go to bed. Turning away from each other, quickly threw off their clothes. Victor swam from shore with sweeping strokes, Valeria unhurriedly followed him with classic breaststroke. He stopped, turned, froze on the water, waiting for her. Waited, embraced, kissed. He

still felt how tense Valeria's body was; but that was already a different, new sensation. Anticipation, expectation, languor — but not fear and wariness. He continued kissing her salty lips, eyes, neck. A minute later the world around collapsed into a point, ceased to exist. They loved each other. Valeria cried out, apparently Victor miscalculated the strength of his hands. Immediately pressed against him even stronger, literally burned into his body with nipples sharp from tension, wrapped his legs with hers, bit his earlobe, shuddered and went limp in his arms. She was no longer tense. She trusted him, he held her on the water, still clutching her in his hands, not letting her turn. Studied her eyes in the dim reflection of lights from shore.

"You didn't bring cigarettes with you?"

"Held them in my teeth, but they accidentally fell out."

Victor released Valeria and without agreement they swam toward shore. Victor no longer stroked forward, he swam with rare confident breaststroke beside Valeria.

"So what about your Facebook status?"

"Was 'it's complicated.' Now became 'it's very complicated.' Let's better smoke."

Came ashore, hastily dried off with Victor's T-shirt, pulled clothes onto damp bodies. Valeria grabbed the lighter, Victor gently took the flame from her hands, brought it to the cigarette. Pressed against him again. They stood, smoked, alone on the seashore, in the epicenter of silence, darkness and real happiness. Dense, tangible happiness that doesn't last long. They both knew this from experience.

22 First Night Together

WALKED more along the shore, went into a bar. Bought matching bracelets from a late-staying young Irishman dressed in an unimaginable poncho and panama hat usually worn by elderly Frenchwomen at resorts. He spoke monstrous English, interspersing speech with Irish, German and Flemish curses. All the while smiling, as if inoculated with a strain of permanent delight. Here, in Matala, he's been for half a year already. And won't leave here for anything until the cold comes, which seems never will come. He smelled strongly of sweat, marijuana and sea. "Smell of luck," whispered Victor secretly. The adventurer who found his peace of mind was named Rick.

Said goodbye to the Irishman well past midnight. Left the bar; around not a single light burned. Only stars — the Milky Way sprawled overhead, indecent in its extravagance, as if someone had smashed a chandelier across the vault of the sky. The air had cooled to the temperature of skin; you couldn't tell where your body ended and the night began. Jasmine exhaled from somewhere unseen, mixed with the salt-rot of drying nets and the lingering sweetness of raki on their breath. The gravel path crunched softly underfoot, and the silence between the crunches was so total that you could hear the sea thinking. Slowly, stepping in rhythm they walked to their shelter. Silently crept past the hostess's door to the little house. As soon as they stepped across the threshold, they were like different people. With quick, sharp movements Victor pulled Valeria to himself, found her lips in the darkness, without breaking away from them, with one movement threw off her blouse. A second later they stood at the door completely naked. Victor easily lifted Valeria in his arms, stepped toward the bed. Strongly hit his hip on the table, something fell and clanged. Carefully lowered the precious

burden onto the bed; light creak, like a greeting. Continuing to kiss Valeria, lowered himself beside her.

Several moments later dawn broke. The first ray penetrated the window, stirred the curtain. They smoked, relaxed, tightly pressed against each other. Victor rose on his elbow and in the barely discernible light looked into Valeria's eyes. She squinted, stretched sweetly. Smiled.

"I want to say some stupidity, vulgarity, or banality."

"Me too."

"Then let's discuss possible solutions to Fermat's theorem."

"Major or minor?"

"You're not confusing theorems with Ursas?"

"Since childhood."

"Then better talk about something simpler."

"I'm experiencing a completely unknown, but no less wonderful feeling. I can say anything. With you I'm not afraid to seem stupider, funnier, ruder or scarier than I really am. I'm not afraid to offend you, but not because I don't care — I simply know you'll understand everything correctly. If I don't finish, or can't find the right formulation, or cut off a thought mid-sentence — you'll still feel what's needed. Not even understand — but sense, or something."

"Pro-smell."

"I'm serious."

"Me too."

"Also serious?"

"Feel the same thing. And you know, it's the best feeling I've ever experienced. We constantly encounter being misunderstood. In kindergarten..."

"My grandmother raised me."

“Me too, that’s not the point. Okay. In school you know where to put a comma in an essay — but they require you to learn a rule. You guess that the problem about pipes in a pool is solved in the real world with an experiment; until all the water spills out — you simply won’t go home, but they make you do meaningless calculations. As a result they manage to teach almost everyone to think by template. And if you suddenly with such an average graduate of an average school start talking about something that has a rational explanation — he’ll apply it like a stencil, and whatever you say next — he thinks he understood everything.”

“That’s not so bad.”

“Yes, but not for those trying to think with their own head. In perception instilled by compulsory education — lacks such a trifle as sensitivity. Receptiveness. No matter how clearly you prove that light — is half-wave and half-particle, only a handful of crazy people with disheveled hair and eyes red from eternal sleep deprivation will understand you. And half a century later they’ll put your theory in a physics textbook — and zombify another batch of innocent teenagers with it. They’ll learn that ‘*corpuscular-wave dualism*,’ and that ‘*E equals em-cee-squared*.’

“Though almost no one still understands what it means *actually*.”

“Yes. A theorem taught as an axiom — kills brain cells stronger than methyl alcohol. People are deliberately taught not to think. Knowledge imposed from above is equally harmful, whether it’s absolutely true or outrageously false. If it’s not about mechanical actions; and even here the one who burned the first hundred pancakes — the hundred-first will make certainly tastier than someone who looked up the article ‘Preparation of flat thin cakes in a pan’ in a cookbook and saved a couple packs of flour. What use is it that I memorized two hundred thousand katakana hieroglyphs by heart, when

I encounter the two hundred thousand first? Those who understand... rather, even feel — how they were created — will always understand that *forest-under-water-side-wind* — isn't 'some unknown crap,' but a tsunami."

"Tsunami — is *big wave in harbor*. And you can memorize *all* hieroglyphs."

"Yes. That'll be enough to read newspaper editorials and poems glorifying the communist party. In principle, as the world shows, that's more than enough to succeed in any modern society. But you want — to be an artist. For that you need to be able to create your own hieroglyphs."

"You mean you're not afraid to write me letters in unknown hieroglyphs?"

"Don't ruin my fairy tale. When everything's clear — just be quiet."

"Then we should eat."

"At six in the morning? Will have to go to the mountains and slaughter some sheep."

Victor got up, approached the jug standing on the table. Inside turned out to be ginger kvass. He took a big gulp and passed the vessel to Valeria. Pulled on jeans, then T-shirt.

"Okay, you lie here for now, I'll go try to get some delicacy."

"Take the razor."

"To slaughter the sheep?"

"Go already, I already had no doubt you remember all quotes by heart."

Victor paused in the doorway.

"Remembered. My college friend, Pavlik, once said: 'With Vitya all phrases divide into two categories: it's either a quote or stupidity.'"

23 Morning in the Village

THE village seemed completely dead. No Greeks, no tourists, not even hippies. Victor tugged at the door under a sign eaten away by time and sea air "*Καφενεριο*." Locked. Once more — with the same success. The razor in his shirt pocket protruded threateningly, like a shark fin in shallow water. Interesting, he thought, how much would a roto-printed brochure cost: "How Not to Look Like a Fugitive Maniac Early Morning in a Backwater Greek Village?" The section about razors sticking out of pockets probably occupies central place there.

Walked further along the sun-bleached road. Asphalt cracked and resembled the skin of a prehistoric lizard offering its back to the rare step of passersby. Another door. Under it — a plastic tray with cat food. The tray's owner, a red impudent cat the size of a young lynx, looked at Victor appraisingly with one eye. The second, judging by the scar, remained in some roadside ditch.

"Odysseus, by chance?"

The cat yawned, demonstrating universal boredom, and turned away.

From around the corner emerged an ancient, implausibly old Greek on a bicycle without pedals. The bicycle rolled on its own, the Greek performed the role of ballast, occasionally pushing off with his foot from the ground. Stopped opposite Victor. Didn't say anything, just looked at him with surprisingly young, clear eyes.

"*Καλιμέρα*." Victor nodded respectfully.

The Greek silently raised his hand, as if giving a blessing, and rolled on. His back was straight, head held high. Like a king inspecting his domain.

Victor walked on. The sun was already warming noticeably. Need to find something to eat. Even if just

bread and cheese. Valeria probably woke up already. Waiting. Hungry.

And I wander around the village like an idiot. Could have just brought her to a normal hotel. With breakfast. Room service. But no — needed romance. Bungalow. Sea outside the window. Now she's lying there hungry, and I — I can't even find a store.

But luck finally smiled. Around the next turn appeared a small shop. Open. Inside — a stout Greek woman. She smiled broadly when Victor entered.

“Καλιμέρα! Tourist?”

“Yes. Need to buy breakfast. Bread, cheese, olives.”

“Ah, breakfast!” The Greek woman nodded enthusiastically. “For you and beautiful lady, yes? I see yesterday evening. You very lucky man.”

Victor was surprised but didn't show it.

“Yes, for two.”

“Good, good. I know what you need.”

She began bustling about, taking down various packages from shelves. Bread, cheese, tomatoes, cucumbers, olives, feta, a bottle of wine, honey, yogurt. Packed everything in a paper bag.

“Honey — from my husband. Best on the island. Wine — also ours. You try — will come back for more.”

Victor paid, generously tipped. The Greek woman blessed him, made the sign of the cross in the air.

“Go, go. Lady is waiting. Don't make her wait long. Women don't like when men make them wait.”

Victor left the shop, smiling. The village turned out not so dead after all. Just sleeps. Like everything in Greece at this hour.

24 Valeria Wakes

VALERIA lay on her back, staring at the ceiling. The ceiling kept silent, which was reasonable on its part. Had it tried to speak — Valeria would have had to acknowledge the fact of her own insanity. And that she categorically did not want to do. At least, not before breakfast.

Last night — or this morning, temporal categories had become thoroughly confused, — she had made love with a man she'd known less than two days. In the sea. Then — in this bed. Twice. Or three times? Doesn't matter. What matters is different: she felt not a gram of shame, embarrassment or regret.

Moreover. Moreover — she felt completely, idiotically, indecently happy.

This was wrong. This doesn't happen. Serious adult people don't meet in the evening, don't fly the next day to an island and don't... Valeria squeezed her eyes shut. Fine, it happens. But then they wake up, sober up in both the literal and figurative sense, and the awkwardness begins, the excuses, the escape.

But here — nothing of the sort. He'd gone for breakfast. With a razor in his pocket. He'd return in half an hour, they'd drink coffee, chat about all sorts of nonsense, and all of it would seem absolutely natural. As if they'd been married for twenty years and had come here on another vacation.

"I'm going crazy." She said aloud. The ceiling didn't answer. Apparently, it too considered this diagnosis premature.

She got up, threw on his shirt. Big, almost to her knees, could wear it to the office. Smells of him — tobacco, sea and something else elusive. Went to the window. Outside the window — the sea. To the right — caves, to the left — rocks. The sun had already risen

high, though the clock showed only half past six. What time was it in Berlin? In Moscow? Doesn't matter. Right now only what's happening here and now matters.

Victor returned to the bungalow. Quietly opened the door. Valeria pretended to be asleep, curled up under a thin sheet. Victor put the bag on the table. Approached the bed. Sat on the edge. Stroked her hair.

She opened her eyes. Smiled. Stretched.

"Good morning, Frau Lehmann! Or is it a day already? I lost track of time right between the third kiss and the sunrise."

"You came back and you're unbearable in the morning.."

"Promised I would."

"What's that?"

"Breakfast from Greek Penelope, a hundred-year-old elder who serves breakfasts around the clock. Besides, she called you a beautiful lady, which earned him my eternal goodwill."

They unwrapped the bundle. Inside were flatbreads, feta cheese, grapes and two bottles of water.

"I already had breakfast. This is for you. And for the road."

"Where are we going?"

"Haven't a clue. Maybe we'll stay here? I could apprentice myself to Odysseus, and you — catch fish and weave baskets."

"I can't catch fish or weave baskets."

"All the more interesting. Imagine the material for articles: 'German citizen of Russian origin learned to weave baskets on the island of Crete.' Bestseller for years."

"How a journalist-mathematician went mad in the Greek sun' — will sell faster."

"That's already autobiography. Sells worse."

Valeria ate the flatbread, washed it down with water. Victor sat on the edge of the bed and smoked, looking out the window.

"What are you thinking about?"

"About how the day after tomorrow I need to be in Moscow, and you — in Berlin. And that of the fifty hours we've been given, we've already spent eight. Forty-two — is catastrophically little."

Valeria came over, sat beside him. Laid her head on his shoulder.

"Do you always count time like this?"

"Only when it's ending too fast."

They were silent. Outside the window a seagull cried. Somewhere in the distance a boat motor started.

"Listen." Valeria raised her head. "What if we just don't think about the day after tomorrow? Forty-two hours — is a whole eternity, if you use them right."

"You're suggesting we live them like they're our last?"

"No. Like they're our first. As if nothing came before, and nothing comes after — nothing will be. Just us, the sea and forty-two hours."

Victor stubbed out his cigarette, turned to her.

"You know that in strength and firmness of thought even Einstein can't compare to you?"

"They say it happens sometimes."

"Then here's the plan. Today — we laze on the beach, swim, eat, drink wine and make love. Tomorrow — we laze on the beach, swim, eat, drink wine and make love. Day after tomorrow in the morning — the airport. Sound good?"

"One question. In what order?"

"We improvise as the play unfolds."

"Then I vote yes. Unanimously."

Victor embraced her, pressed her to himself. The shirt slipped from Valeria's shoulder. He kissed the exposed skin.

"You realize we're both behaving like complete idiots?"

"I realize. And I love it madly."

"Me too."

The world around them froze, only Valeria's hair trembled in the draft. They looked at each other. Slowly, tenderly, as if they had the whole world and eternity ahead. And outside the window the sea murmured with surf, the sun climbed higher and higher, and somewhere in the caves hippies were waking to begin another endless day in the paradise they'd found at the edge of Europe.

25 The Beach

THE beach by ten in the morning was about twenty percent full. Decent tourists, those who'd settled in hotels with air conditioning and buffet breakfasts, appeared here no earlier than eleven. Hippies made a point of emerging from caves after noon. So for now Victor and Valeria had the rare opportunity to feel like discoverers of an uninhabited island.

Victor didn't like sunbathing on principle. Valeria — for practical reasons: her skin turned red instantly, then peeled, and for two weeks she'd have to walk around resembling a molting cobra. So they settled under a

canopy, constructing from improvised materials something like a shelter.

"What shall we do?" Valeria asked, leaning back on the towel.

"Philosophize. That's the main occupation on Greek islands. Even the air here obliges.

"Then I suggest a topic. Why do smart people do stupid things?"

"Because smart people are bored doing smart things. It's too methodical, and smart people like to tear discourse to shreds."

"So you think our spontaneous voyage — is stupidity?"

"Brilliant stupidity. Which automatically puts it in the category of correct decisions."

"Sophistry."

"Naturally. We're in Socrates' homeland. Sinful not to take advantage."

Valeria turned over on her stomach, propped her chin on her hands.

"You know, I've done the right things all my life. Studied, worked, planned. I have a career, an apartment, a car. Everything as it should be."

"And?"

"And I've never been as happy as I am now. When I did the most insane stupid thing of my life."

"Flew to an island with a stranger?"

"Didn't bring sunscreen."

"Tragedy. You'll have to return to Berlin with a burned nose. Colleagues will stop letting you through doors."

"Let them. I'll say I went to a quantum physics conference in Athens, and there was a particularly aggressive Helios."

"Quantum physics?"

"You said it yourself — nobody checks. The main thing — throw around terms with an intelligent look."

"Corpuscular-wave dualism of suntan."

"Exactly. And what will you tell your editor?"

"The truth. That I met a woman who dances under the clock at Alexanderplatz, rhymes on the go and understands the difference between olives and maslins."

"That's not the truth. I don't understand the difference. You said yourself they're the same thing."

"Means you understand. Paradox — is the highest form of truth, accessible for understanding only to the chosen."

Valeria laughed. Victor took the camera from his bag.

"May I?"

"You're going to photograph me again?"

"I promise these photos won't be seen by anyone. Except me. I need them so that in a month, when I'm sitting in the editorial office listening to nonsense about deadlines, I can remember that all this really happened. That you — are not a product of my fevered imagination."

"Then shoot."

He took several frames. Valeria in profile, against the sea. Valeria covering her face with her hands and laughing. Valeria looking straight into the lens with such an expression that Victor's breath caught.

"That's enough. Now it's my turn."

She took the camera from him, he tried to dodge but Valeria proved quicker. Click. Click. Click.

"I hate being photographed."

"Me too. So we're even. Besides, I also need proof. That a Russian journalist-mathematician quoting Fowles and Shakespeare, pretending to be a cynic and telling stories about Eskimos and pyramids — actually exists."

"Stories about Eskimos and pyramids — are pure truth."

"Especially about dragging them through Yakutia."

"Science doesn't stand still. Someday they'll prove that too."

Valeria returned the camera to him, settled beside him. Victor put his arm around her shoulders.

"Know what I'm thinking?"

"That the day after tomorrow vacation ends?"

"No. That I want it never to end."

"Want to stay here? I could..."

"No." Valeria placed a finger on his lips. "Don't. Don't plan, promise, build. Let's just be here. Now. Forty-two hours. And then — we'll see."

"We'll see."

They fell silent. The sea murmured. The sun blazed. Somewhere in the distance music was playing — probably from someone's boombox. Seemed like Bob Marley. Or Jimmy Cliff. Victor could never tell them apart.

"Listen." Valeria raised her head. "Do you really think I dance like a goddess?"

"Really. Like Terpsichore, descended on Alexanderplatz in search of inspiration."

"Terpsichore — is the muse of dance?"

"Yep. One of nine. Though honestly, I confuse them all except Erato."

"Because she's — the muse of love poetry?"

"Because in school I sat next to a girl named Elya. Very thin, with braids and huge glasses. When the teacher talked about the muses, I kept thinking Erato — was her. Haven't been able to forget since."

Valeria burst out laughing.

"So all your compliments — come from childhood memories of timid Elya?"

"Exclusively. I'm a sentimental person. Live in the past."

"Not true. You live in the present. I can see. You just pretend to be a cynic so as not to seem too romantic."

"You've exposed me. Now I'll have to pose as a romantic so as not to seem a cynic."

"Tangled in your own masks?"

"Not really... I'm like Terry Sawchuk — when you have four hundred scars on your face, no mask is needed."

Valeria pressed closer to him. They sat like that, embracing, for another ten minutes. Then Victor said:

"Shall we swim?"

"Let's. Only this time — in swimsuits. Otherwise Greek grandmothers might not approve of our yesterday's performance."

"Greek grandmothers are long asleep. They get up at four in the morning, by noon they've finished all their business and now they're resting in righteous siesta."

"Then Greek grandfathers."

"Greek grandfathers will approve. They used to swim like that in their youth."

"How do you know?"

"Odysseus told me. Between the second and third shot of raki."

They entered the water. Warm, clear, gentle. Victor swam to the buoys, Valeria — after him. She caught up, wrapped her arms around him, kissed him.

"Thank you."

"For what?"

"For forty-two hours."

"We've only just started spending them."

"Then thanks in advance."

They returned to shore when the sun began tilting toward sunset. They spent the whole day on the beach, swam, dozed, talked about this and that. Victor told stories from editorial life, Valeria — about Berlin, about colleagues, about her apartment on Wannsee, where, it turned out, there really is a cemetery, just not opposite the house, but a five-minute walk away.

In the evening they went to the same tavern. The Greek waiter who'd served them yesterday waved his hands joyfully, seated them at the best table, brought menus.

"Today I'm ordering," Valeria said. "Yesterday you surprised me, now it's my turn."

She quickly scribbled something in the waiter's notepad, he nodded vigorously, rushed to the kitchen. Ten minutes later the table groaned with food. Grilled octopus, moussaka, dolmades, shrimp, salad, and a carafe of retsina the size of a small bucket.

"Lord." Victor stared at this abundance. "Am I not fat enough for you?"

"I want you to remember this dinner. When you're sitting in Moscow chewing your editorial sandwich."

"I'll remember. Promise. I'll remember with every sandwich and cheerfully burp at my neighbor."

They ate slowly, unhurriedly, sipped wine and talked again. About anything and nothing. Words had no

meaning. The music of speech in this little song was more important than the lyrics.

When they returned to the bungalow, it was past midnight. Victor lit a candle — electricity in the cottage, naturally, there was none. The light trembled, casting whimsical shadows on the walls.

"You know what I want right now?" Valeria asked, pulling off her sundress.

"What?"

"Just to lie next to you. In silence. And listen to the sea."

"I knew it wouldn't be a day before you got deathly sick of my chatter."

They lay down, embracing. The candle was burning low. Outside the window the surf roared. Valeria laid her head on Victor's chest.

"How much time do we have left?"

"Thirty-one hours. Approximately."

"Is that a lot or a little?"

"Depends how you count. In seconds — it's a hundred eleven thousand six hundred. A whole fortune."

"Then let's count in seconds."

"Higher-order mathematics."

She fell asleep first. Victor lay staring at the ceiling, thinking that in thirty-one hours he'd be on a plane flying to Moscow. That Valeria would fly to Berlin. That what comes next — was unclear.

But now, in this second, she's sleeping on his chest, outside the window the sea murmurs, and somewhere very close — the happiness he'd been searching for all his life, not knowing what exactly he was searching for.

Victor closed his eyes and fell asleep too. The candle burned down to the end, and darkness softly and

soundlessly covered them, the shack called bungalow, the beach and the sea. Even the moon didn't come out into the sky, so as not to disturb this peace.

26 Waking Alone

THE sun pounded at the window like a creditor at an insolvent debtor's door. Insistently, mercilessly, accepting no refusal. Victor opened his eyes and reached his hand toward Valeria. His hand met cold sheet.

He propped himself on one elbow. The bed beside him was empty. Fine, he thought, probably went for a swim. Or went to Odysseus for breakfast. Though no — they'd agreed not to go anywhere all day. The last day. Twenty-three hours, to be precise.

Victor got up, pulled on jeans. Looked around the room. No yellow suitcase. No handbag either. On the chair, where yesterday her things had lain — empty. Like after a locust raid. Like after a dream, when you wake with the feeling you've lost something very important, but can't remember what exactly.

"Valeria?"

Silence. Only the sound of surf outside the window, indifferent and eternal.

Victor burst outside. Ran around the cottage. Nobody. Rushed to the landlady's house, pounded on the door. The same old woman in black opened, looked at him with surprise.

"Που είναι η γυναίκα μου;" Victor realized he was shouting. "Where is my wife? Lady? Yellow suitcase?"

The old woman shook her head, babbled something in Greek. Victor didn't understand a word, but the meaning was clear: she knew nothing. Hadn't seen. Maybe

very early in the morning, when the old woman was still asleep.

Victor ran to the tavern. The door was open, inside — Odysseus, unhurriedly polishing glasses. Seeing Victor, he broke into a smile.

“Kalimera, Russian friend! You want breakfast?”

“Did you see my... my lady? This morning? *German lady, yellow suitcase?*”

Odysseus frowned, thinking. Shook his head.

“No, no. I not see. She leave you?” In his eyes flashed sympathy, unable to displace completely the twinkle settled there long ago and forever. “Woman... woman like bird. Sometimes fly away.”

Victor didn’t bother explaining. Turned and ran back to the bungalow. Maybe he’d missed something. Maybe she’d left a note. Something.

The bungalow door was ajar. Strange. He clearly remembered closing it when he left. Victor slowly pushed the door. Inside everything was just as he’d left it. Rummpled bed. Cigarette butts in the improvised ashtray — a tin can. His shirt on the chair.

On the table, where yesterday the jug of kvass had stood, lay a piece of paper folded in four.

Victor approached, picked up the note. The paper was thick, as if torn from a good notebook. Unfolded it. Handwriting — neat, rounded, feminine. Just one line, in English:

“Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V.”

Victor reread the note three times. Then once more. The words didn’t change. He turned the paper over — nothing on the other side. Looked at the table, under the table, around the table. There was nothing else.

“Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V.”

Forget it. Not “me.” Not “us.” It. Forget this.

Victor sat on the bed. In his head — emptiness, like what remains after an explosion. When sound hasn't returned yet, but the brain already understands that something irreparable has happened.

Two minutes he sat motionless. Then jumped up, grabbed his things, stuffed them in his jeans pockets and shirt. Camera. Wallet. Car keys. Phone. Everything else didn't matter.

Ran out of the bungalow, not closing the door. Ran to the place where they'd left the Volkswagen. The car stood in place, patient as a draft horse. Victor got behind the wheel, started the engine. His hands were shaking.

Airport. Heraklion. Need to get to Heraklion. Maybe she's still there. Maybe the plane was delayed. Maybe...

Maybe there was nothing at all. Maybe the last two days — a hallucination. Heat stroke. Overdose of raki at Odysseus's.

Victor floored the gas pedal.

27 Return to the Sea

THE road from Matala to Heraklion ran through the heart of the island. First — serpentine upward, past olive groves clinging to the slopes like mollusks to a ship's hull. The trees stood in even rows, ancient, twisted, resembling cripples returned home after a long war. Trunks, wrung by wind and time. Foliage silvery, almost gray. They remembered this land when Knossos still stood here, and young Theseus went to kill the Minotaur. Remembered the Romans and Byzantines, Venetians and Turks. Remembered everything, and kept silent, because olives — are wise trees. They know that talkative witnesses don't live long.

Victor drove the car along the narrow road, overtaking rare trucks and motorcycles. The speedometer

showed one-twenty where the limit was forty. One turn. Second. Third. An oncoming car desperately honked — Victor hadn't even noticed he'd drifted into the oncoming lane. Straightened the wheel. Onward.

The olives gave way to vineyards. Vines, low, pressed to the ground, stretched along the road like green furrows on the island's body. Someone, sometime, very long ago, sat here with compass and ruler and divided the hills into perfectly even plots. Then came people with seedlings and obediently followed the plan. Year after year. Generation after generation. Grapes grew, ripened, were harvested, pressed, made into wine, which was then drunk in taverns by such idiots as he. Idiots who believed that a woman met two days ago could be the one. The only one. Forever.

"Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V."

What to forget? The dance under the clock at Alexanderplatz? The flight here, when they laughed about some nonsense and Valeria nearly choked on candy? The sea at night, when they made love, and it seemed the whole world was the oncoming wave? Yesterday on the beach, when she said: "Forty-two hours — is a whole eternity"?

The road went down, toward the valley. To the right appeared some village — white cottages, huddled together like sheep in a storm. A church with a blue dome. An old man on a donkey, slowly climbing up the slope. He turned, looked at the Volkswagen rushing past. Face — calm, detached. The face of someone who's seen enough to be surprised by nothing. Not even a hurrying Russian tourist racing through the dust, as if chased by Hades himself.

Maybe he is.

Some American novelist wrote that in California the landscape always deceives. Seems the mountains are close — but it's three hours' drive. You think the desert

is dead — but it's full of life, only it hides from the sun and shows itself at night. You think the road is straight — but it winds like the thoughts of someone trying to understand what happened.

Here, on Crete, everything was the opposite. The landscape didn't deceive. It told the truth. Harsh, ancient truth. Mountains — really close, but they're inaccessible. Sea — nearby, but between you and it — kilometers of sheer cliffs. Trees — there they are, but try growing something here besides olives and grapes. Earth — under your feet, but it's rocky, hard, resisting any attempt to dig a well.

And women — they don't deceive here either. They just leave. Leaving a note of seven words.

Victor overtook a tanker truck — that same yellow one they'd passed the day before yesterday. Or was it different? Doesn't matter. All tankers are the same. Like all roads. Like all airports, where you arrive in desperate hope to find someone you won't find.

A sign appeared: "Heraklion — 15 km." Victor looked at his watch. Ten in the morning. How much time had passed since he woke up? An hour? Two? Felt like — an eternity.

Ahead, beyond the turn, appeared the first houses of the city. Heraklion. Capital of Crete. Former Candia. The city stormed by Venetians and Turks. The city Nikos Kazantzakis left. The city where he, Victor Latov, would now search for a woman who didn't want to be found.

He entered the city at a speed that made several care-free pedestrians jump back and yell after him. Airport signs. Follow the signs. It's simple. It's mechanical. It doesn't require thinking.

Because you can't suffer and think at the same time.

28 The Bar and Irish Rick

NIKOS Kazantzakis Airport greeted Victor with indifferent bustle. Tourists with suitcases. Families with children. Lovers embracing in farewell. Everyone — in their own world, in their own story. No one paid attention to the disheveled Russian who burst into the arrivals hall like a Fury into the Temple of Vesta.

Victor stopped in the middle of the hall, spinning his head. Departure board. Flights to Athens, Thessaloniki, Berlin. Berlin — there it is. Departure was at 07:40. Three hours ago.

He ran to the information desk. The girl behind the counter raised tired eyes to him.

"Excuse me, do you speak English?"

"Yes, sir. How can I help you?"

"Berlin flight, seven forty. Did it leave on time?"

"Let me check..." She tapped something on the keyboard. *"Yes, sir. Departed on schedule. Arrived in Berlin at ten thirty local time."*

Victor grabbed the edge of the counter. So she's already there. Already in Berlin. Already...

"Sir? Are you okay?"

"Did you see... woman. German woman, dark hair, tall, yellow suitcase..."

The girl looked at him with the sympathy that exists only in those who see human dramas in miniature every day.

"Sir, hundreds of people pass through here every day. I can't..."

"Yes. Yes, of course. Sorry."

Victor stepped away from the counter. Looked around. A policeman dozing by the entrance. Victor approached him.

"Σηροποι... Excuse me, do you speak English?"

The policeman nodded, not particularly cheerfully.

"Little bit."

"I'm looking for a woman. German, dark hair, about thirty-five, yellow suitcase. She was here this morning. Did you see her?"

The policeman looked at him with suspicion.

"You husband?"

"Yes. No. I mean... To hell with it. 'Friend. She left, didn't say where. I'm worried."

"Many woman here. Every day. I not remember."

Victor understood it was pointless. He could run around the airport till evening, ask everyone in sight — the result would be the same. Hard to find a needle in a haystack when three hours ago a plane carried it to the other end of Europe.

Berlin. She's in Berlin. Wannsee. Yellow Smart. The café where they drank coffee. The house opposite the cemetery.

Victor ran to the check-in counter. Next flight to Berlin — via Athens, departure at 13:20. Will get to Berlin by six in the evening.

"One ticket, please. Economy. One way."

The girl at the counter printed the ticket. Victor paid by card, not looking at the amount. Money didn't matter. Nothing mattered except finding Valeria and learning what the hell happened.

"Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V."

No. He won't forget. He won't return to Moscow until he learns the truth.

29 Dawn

BERLIN greeted him with rain. Fine, tedious, the kind that exists only in Northern Europe. Rain that doesn't intend to end. That will fall forever, methodically turning the city into gray watercolor.

Victor took a taxi to Wannsee. Sat in the back seat, staring out the window. Berlin drifted past — gray, indifferent, alien. The day before yesterday it had seemed beautiful. The day before yesterday there was sun, and Valeria taught him to rhyme on the go, and they danced under the clock at Alexanderplatz, and the whole world was kind and comprehensible.

Now the world was logical as a theorem. And just as cold.

The taxi stopped at the café. Victor paid, got out. Rain immediately soaked his shirt. Who cares. He looked around. Over there, around the corner — the bus stop. Over there — the house where she turned the day before yesterday with the yellow suitcase. Over there — the café where they drank coffee, and bartender Wolf said: *"Ja woll."*

Victor slipped in. Behind the counter stood the same Wolf, still polishing glasses. Universal murder of boredom for bartenders of all countries and nations.

"Guten Abend. Ein Kaffee, bitte."

Wolf nodded, set a cup on the counter. Victor took a sip. The coffee was scalding hot and bitter, like truth better left unknown.

"Entschuldigung..." Victor tried to remember his German. *"Die Frau... Valeria Lehmann. Wohnt hier in der Nähe. Haben Sie sie heute gesehen?"*

Wolf frowned.

"Frau Lehmann? Nein, heute nicht. Warum?"

"Nur so... Just asking."

Victor finished the coffee, paid. Went out into the rain. Walked to the house where she'd turned. Several houses, all identical. Which one exactly does she live in? Third? Fourth?

He started checking entrances. Buzzing intercoms. *"Lehmann? Valeria Lehmann?"* Each time — a negative answer. Or silence altogether.

Fifth house. Sixth. At the seventh the intercom was silent at first, then an elderly woman's voice answered:

"Ja?"

"Valeria Lehmann?"

"Wer sind Sie?"

"Ein Freund. Ich muss sie sehen."

"Frau Lehmann ist nicht da. Sie ist verreist."

Verreist. Gone away.

"Wohin?"

"Das weiss ich nicht. Und wer sind Sie überhaupt?"

Victor released the intercom button and pressed his forehead against the cold wall. Rain drummed on his back. Somewhere a car drove past, splashing him with water from a puddle. He didn't even move.

The phone in his pocket vibrated.

Victor pulled it out. SMS. Unfamiliar number, but the code — Latvian.

Opened the message.

"Don't try to find Valeria in Berlin. Get back to Moscow. — Valdis Liels"

Victor stared at the screen. Reread it. Hit "Call Back." Long rings. Voicemail.

"Liels! Liels, this is Latov! What's happening?! Where's Valeria? What the hell?!"

He shouted into the phone, ignoring the passing Germans who glanced at him with disapproval. To hell with disapproval. To hell with everything.

Called again. Voicemail. Again. Same thing.

Victor lowered the phone. Looked at the gray sky, at the gray houses, at the gray puddles under his feet.

"Get back to Moscow."

Moscow. So the answer — is in Moscow. If this riddle even has an answer, and if Victor wants to know it.

Victor did. He caught a taxi.

"Flughafen Schönefeld, bitte. Schnell."

30 Departure

THE PLANE took off at half past eight. Victor sat by the window, watching Berlin shrink beneath the wing. City lights scattered in darkness. Somewhere down there — the apartment at Wannsee. The yellow Smart. The café where bartender Wolf polishes glasses. Alexanderplatz with its clock. All this was the day before yesterday. A whole eternity ago.

Next to him snored a German weighing about three hundred pounds, who for some reason smelled of jasmine. Behind him teenagers whispered. The flight attendant passed by, offering drinks. Victor declined. He wanted neither to eat nor to drink. He wanted only one thing — to understand.

To understand what happened between last night, when they lay embracing and counted the remaining time in seconds, and this morning, when he woke up alone in an empty bungalow.

To understand why Valeria vanished, leaving a seven-word note.

To understand what the hell Liels had to do with all this.

He pulled out his phone, reread the SMS. "Don't try to find Valeria in Berlin. Get back to Moscow." How did Liels know he was in Berlin? How did he know he was looking for Valeria? Why did he advise returning to Moscow?

Victor tried to remember when he'd last seen Valdis. Three years ago. They met by chance in Riga, drank beer, talked about this and that. Liels worked for some international company, something logistics-related. Or finance. Victor didn't remember. They exchanged phone numbers, promised to keep in touch, and, of course, didn't.

And now — three years later — a call. "Absolutely lovely young lady. Your type." A blind date. Valeria. Who turned out to be not just a lovely young lady, but...

But what? Who was she? Did she really live in Berlin? Did she really work — where was it she worked? Victor realized he didn't know. Hadn't asked. They'd had no time for biographies. They'd had no time for the real world. They lived in their own invented one, where there's only the sea, sun, and forty-two hours.

And now this world had collapsed like a house of cards. And Victor flew to Moscow, not knowing what awaited him there.

Outside the window lights of some city blinked in the darkness. Maybe Warsaw. Or Minsk. Doesn't matter. All cities are the same when you look at them from thirty thousand feet. All cities — just lights in darkness. All stories — just words. All people — just shadows appearing in your life for two days and vanishing, leaving a seven-word note.

"Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V."

Victor closed his eyes. Tried to sleep. Couldn't. Before his eyes stood Valeria. How she danced under the

clock. How she laughed when he told her about Eskimos and pyramids. How she lay on his chest and asked: "How much time do we have left?"

"Thirty-one hours. A whole fortune."

They'd spent that fortune. And now he was bankrupt.

The plane began descending. Victor opened his eyes. Outside the window — the lights of Moscow. Big, bright, endless. The city where he'd lived for twenty years. The city he knew by heart. The city that now seemed alien, like the surface of the Moon.

Wheels touched the runway. The plane braked, rolled toward the terminal. Passengers stirred, reached into overhead bins. Victor sat motionless. He had no luggage. He had nothing at all, except a camera, a phone, and a whole heap of unanswered questions.

He left the plane last. Walked through the empty corridor, through passport control, through the arrivals hall. It was two a.m. The metro wasn't running. Victor went outside, caught a taxi.

"Maryina Roshcha."

The driver nodded, asking no questions. Good driver. Muscovites know how not to ask questions. It's a useful skill in a city where every second person is running from something or toward something, and no one wants to explain — from what or toward what.

The car raced through nighttime Moscow. Empty avenues. Bright advertising lights. Streetlights standing along roads like sentries at their posts. Victor looked out the window and thought that somewhere in this city — was the answer. Somewhere here — the key to everything that happened.

He just had to find it.

The driver stopped at his building. Victor paid, got out. Climbed the familiar stairs, unlocked the apartment door. Inside smelled of dust and stale air. He

hadn't been here for three days. Just three days. Felt like — three years.

Victor turned on the light, threw open the windows, went to the kitchen. Opened the refrigerator — empty. Closed it. Poured himself tap water, drank. Sat at the table.

The phone was silent. No new messages. No calls.

Victor placed the phone on the table, stared at it. Waited. For what — he didn't know himself. A call? Another SMS? Revelation from above?

The clock on the wall ticked. The refrigerator hummed. Outside a motorcycle with a deliberately torn-off muffler drove past.

And Victor sat and waited.

Because besides waiting, he had nothing left.

31 The Note

WHISKY was half a bottle. Irish, bought once at a Duty Free sale. Sat in the cupboard for two years, waiting for its moment. The moment had come.

Victor poured himself a full glass. No ice, no water. Drank it in one gulp. His throat burned, in his stomach a hot lake sloshed. Poured another. Drank slower.

The clock showed three a.m. Outside Moscow wheezed with the anxious breathing of a big city that never truly sleeps. Somewhere a dog barked. Somewhere a car drove. Somewhere someone else couldn't sleep either and sat by the window, staring into emptiness.

Third glass. The whisky no longer burned. It spread through his veins in a warm wave, dulling the sharp corners of thought. This was good. He didn't want to think. He wanted to forget.

"Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V."

Forget. As if it were that simple. As if you could just erase the last three days, like a failed sketch. Snap — and no Valeria. Snap — and there was no Crete. Snap — and he didn't wake up alone in an empty bungalow.

Fourth glass.

Victor closed his eyes. Images floated before them. Not from recent days. From the past. Distant, nearly forgotten.

He's five years old. He stands in the kindergarten yard holding a doll. At his feet — a toy truck. Red, plastic, with a broken wheel. Nearby — a girl named Masha with pigtails. She's crying because Vitya took her doll. Didn't take — traded. Fair and square. Truck for doll. But Masha somehow thinks she was cheated.

The teacher approaches, Aunt Lyuda, fat as a Qing dynasty vase.

"Vitya, give the girl back her doll."

"I gave her the truck."

"The truck has no wheel."

"The doll has no wheel either. Not a single one."

Vitya tried to think rationally from childhood. Aunt Lyuda looks at him for a long moment. Then says:

"You'll grow up to be either a lawyer or a criminal, Vitya."

She was wrong. He grew up to be a journalist. Which, overall, is somewhere in between.

Fifth glass. Or sixth? Doesn't matter.

He's twelve. He sits in the school library reading about Captain Nemo. The librarian, Antonina Petrovna,

dozes behind the desk. It's ten to four, in ten minutes he needs to run to boxing practice. But Vitya can't tear himself from the book. Intrigue, scandal, duels — Latov, is that why you went into journalism?

"Latov!" Sashka Pronichev bursts into the library, friend and enemy simultaneously. "Where are you? The coach will kill you!"

"Wait, one more page."

"You're an idiot. We start in seven minutes."

"I said — wait."

Sashka grabs the book, tries to yank it away. Vitya won't let go. The book tears. In half. Like the heart of a melodrama heroine.

Antonina Petrovna wakes up. Looks at the two halves of twenty thousand leagues. Looks at Vitya. Says quietly, ominously:

"Latov. Parents to school. Tomorrow."

The next day his father bought the library three new Musketeers by Dumas. Expensive, in dust jackets. Antonina Petrovna teared up and forgave him. And Vitya from then on never tore books. Even when he really wanted to.

The whisky ran out. Victor looked at the empty bottle with bewilderment. Where'd it go? Just a moment ago there was half a bottle. Or was that yesterday?

He stood, went to the cupboard. Swayed. The walls drifted slightly. Found another bottle. Talisker, peaty as a bog in Scotland, which Victor saw once, when he went to do a story about whisky. Or about castles. Or about ghosts. Hell if he knows.

Uncorked it. Splashed into the glass. Sat back down.

He's nineteen. First year at math-mech. He and Pavlik sit in the dorm solving a mathematical analysis problem. More precisely, Pavlik solves while Vitya smokes by the window and looks at the courtyard.

"Listen," he says suddenly. "What the hell do we need all this for?"

"What — this?"

"Well, this. Integrals, derivatives, limits. Who needs it?"

Pavlik puts down his pen. Looks at Vitya for a long moment.

"You — don't need it. You need to write."

"Write what?"

"Opera." Pavlik smirks. "If you don't want to show them — don't scatter scraps of newspaper with your poems in the margins all over the room."

Victor gets embarrassed.

"That's nonsense."

"Listen, Vit. Your head is mathematical. But your heart — is literary. Sooner or later they'll retreat to opposite corners of the ring and start beating the crap out of each other. And there'll be no draw."

"So what should I do?"

"I'm a strategist, not a tactician. You'll have to figure it out yourself."

Vitya didn't choose then. Finished his degree, defended his thesis, went to work. But in the evenings he wrote articles. First for the student newspaper. Then for the district one. Then they noticed him. Invited him to "Planeta." Offered him a salary.

He left. Pavlik said then: "You're a fool, of course. But congratulations."

And Vitya thought: "What do I have to lose?"

The glass was full again. When did that happen? Victor looked at his hand with suspicion. Guilty. It poured on its own, without asking.

He's twenty-five. He's just turned in his first big piece. A report from some exhibition. The editor-in-chief, Anatoly Borisovich, gray-haired as Hemingway and bilious as Saltykov-Shchedrin, reads, grimaces.

"Latov."

"Yes."

"Do you know the difference between a good journalist and a bad one?"

"No."

"A bad journalist writes what he sees. A good one — sees what he writes."

Vitya is silent. Doesn't understand.

"You write well. But you're too straightforward. You see shit — you write about shit. You see beauty — you write about beauty. But you need the opposite. You see shit — find the beauty in it. You see beauty — dig around, there's definitely shit hidden there."

"That's cynicism."

"That's professionalism. Cynicism — is when you believe it. Professionalism — is when you don't enter the plane of belief at all. Like agnostics, not atheists. The difference is subtle but fundamental."

Vitya left the office thinking that Anatoly Borisovich — was an old asshole. Ten years later he understood that Anatoly Borisovich was right. Five years after that — that the difference between cynicism and professionalism was even subtler than it seemed.

Victor finished the whisky. Looked at the clock. Half past five in the morning. Outside dawn was breaking.

Gray, murky dawn that only happens in Moscow in early autumn. Or late summer. Or actually always.

His head buzzed. Thoughts tangled. Faces swam before his eyes. Aunt Lyuda from kindergarten. Antonina Petrovna with torn Jules Verne. Pavlik saying: "Choose." Anatoly Borisovich with his professional cynicism.

And Valeria. Dancing under the clock. Laughing on the plane. Lying on his chest: "How much time do we have left?"

"Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V."

Forget — unlikely, but time will soften the focus, everything will blur, and drift away.

Victor laid his head on the table. Closed his eyes. Somewhere very far away a dog barked. Even farther — a car drove past. And then darkness covered him like a blanket, and he fell into sleep.

Drunk, shattered, anxious, deep sleep, in which there was no Valeria, no Crete, no sea. Only emptiness and buzzing in his head.

Part III

The Unraveling

32 The Morning After

THE PHONE crawled across the table toward the edge a closet. Victor opened one eye. The second categorically refused to open. His head was splitting. In his mouth was the sensation that a stray cat in swamp boots had spent the night there.

The phone kept buzzing. Persistently, insistently, like a creditor at a debtor's door.

Victor reached out his hand, missed, tried again. Grabbed the phone on the third attempt. Brought it to his ear.

"Hello." His voice came out hoarse, like a chain smoker's after a night in a bar.

"Latov?"

"...Yes."

"Can you come right now?"

The voice. Familiar. Demanding, deep, vibrating. Victor tried to think. The clock... He looked at the clock. Quarter to three. Day? No, probably night. Outside the window it was dark.

Quarter to three after midnight. He'd slept... how long? Twenty hours? The curtains trembled like a freshman's skirt on a first date.

"Who is this?"

"Liels. Can you come?"

Liels. Valdis Liels. The very one. Who set up the date. Who sent the SMS. Who...

Victor sat up sharply. His head exploded with pain. Doesn't matter.

"Where are you?"

"Foggy Street, 8. Know it?"

"I'll find it. I'll be there in half an hour maximum."

"Excellent. I'll wait."

The connection cut off. Victor looked at the phone. Then at the empty bottles on the table. The half-empty glass of water he didn't remember pouring was pleasantly covered with condensation. Then at his reflection in the window. The reflection was sad. Unshaven,

disheveled, with red eyes. Looked like a heavyweight after a thrown fight. Or a journalist after a sleepless night. Which, overall, is the same thing.

He mustn't go under any circumstances. Mustn't go. There's nothing to do there. It's a trap, a setup, some shady story better not to get involved in. Can't. There will be answers he doesn't want to know. Can't, can't, can't.

Victor stood. Swayed. Made it to the bathroom. Stuck his head under cold water. Stood like that for a minute. Raised his head, looked in the mirror. Water dripped from his hair onto his shoulders. His face was wet and miserable.

"Catch a taxi, make it by three," he told his reflection. "Just listen to what he'll say. Half an hour — and back. By morning, to the editorial office, to work, to normal life. Anywhere where I don't have to think about why and how the hell it all happened."

The reflection looked skeptical.

Victor dried himself with a towel, found a more-or-less clean shirt, pulled on jeans. Grabbed his jacket, keys, phone. Left the apartment.

The street was empty. Rare streetlights, random cars, late pedestrians. Five to three.

Victor caught a taxi. The driver — a swarthy elderly man, hiding kindness and fatigue in his mustache.

"Foggy Street, 8."

"Get in."

The car started moving. Victor leaned back in the seat, closed his eyes. He didn't want to think. He wanted it all to end. For Liels to explain what happened. For it to become clear why Valeria disappeared.

Or, conversely, for him not to explain. To say: "Sorry, old man, it was a mistake." That's all. And he could go home, finish the remains of the whisky and forget.

"Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V."

Why was he riding through nighttime Moscow to a man who possibly knew the truth? Truth in a black robe with a scythe.

33 Foggy Street

FOGGY Street lived up to its name. Light haze spread over the asphalt, turning the streetlights into blurred yellow spots. Building number eight turned out to be a Stalin-era high-rise, grim as a bunker and solemn as a mausoleum.

Victor got out of the taxi, paid. Stood looking at the entrance. The door was ajar. Inside a dim light burned.

He entered. Climbed the stairs. On the third-floor landing one bulb burned. The door to apartment number twelve was ajar. From the crack oozed light and came a quiet voice — Liels speaking on the phone.

Victor pushed the door.

The apartment was almost empty. Minimum furniture — a couch, table, couple of chairs. On the table — a laptop, papers, an ashtray full of cigarette butts. On the couch, legs crossed, sat Liels. Talking on the phone, gesticulating with his free hand. As if it were ten in the morning, time to discuss business.

Seeing Victor, he nodded, gestured — wait. Finished the conversation, set down the phone.

"Latov. Come in. Have a seat."

Victor went inside, sat on a chair. Looked at Liels. He'd changed. Lost weight, aged, in his hair had appeared gray. But his eyes remained the same — intelligent, attentive, slightly mocking.

"You look like shit," said Liels.

"Thanks. You're no Mona Lisa either."

Liels smirked.

"Will you drink?"

"Never again in my life."

"I see. So it was bad."

"Liels. Go to hell. What's going on? Where's Valeria?"

Liels was silent. Lit a cigarette. Drew deeply, exhaled smoke at the ceiling.

"Did you fall in love?"

"That's none of your business."

"So you fell in love." Liels nodded to himself. "Pity. I hoped you'd just have a good time. Didn't count on things going so far."

"What are you talking about?"

"About the fact that I set you up, old man. Set her up too. Though she knew what she was getting into. And you — didn't."

Victor stood.

"Explain. Now. Or I..."

"Sit down, Latov. Sit and listen. Then decide what to do."

Victor sat. His hands were trembling. From the hangover. Or from anger. Or from fear.

Liels stubbed out the cigarette, immediately lit a new one.

"Valeria works for me. More precisely, for the company I work for. We do... let's call it information security. Corporate intelligence, if you prefer."

"Like the NSA, Mossad and James Bond?"

"Not quite. She's a specialist in information extraction. Through people. Understand?"

Victor understood. Understood all too well.

"And I was... what? A target? A source?"

"No. You were cover."

Liels stood, went to the window. Stood with his back to Victor, looking at Foggy Street.

"Valeria needed to meet with a man. A dangerous man. Who knew who she was. She couldn't come alone — that would be suspicious. She needed a companion. Random, not connected to her work, raising no questions."

"And you chose me."

"I chose you. Because I knew you wouldn't refuse a date with a random lady. Because you're a journalist, can hold a conversation, don't ask unnecessary questions. Because you're — a good person, Vitya. And good people — are the best cover."

Victor was silent. Images swam before his eyes. Dinner at Magnolia. The flight to Berlin. Crete. The sea. The bungalow. The whisper: "Thank you for forty-two hours."

All of it was false. A game. Cover.

"And Crete?" he asked quietly. "Why was there Crete?"

Liels turned around.

"That wasn't in the plan. Crete — that was her own idea. Valeria knows how to improvise. Perhaps... perhaps she just wanted to prolong the game. Or she really..."

He didn't finish.

"What? What did she really?"

"I don't know, Latov. I don't know. But her disappearing, leaving a note — that wasn't in the plan. The plan was different. She was supposed to leave Berlin, I

was supposed to call you, explain everything. Calmly, without drama.”

“And instead she ran.”

“Yes.”

“And you don’t know why.”

“No. And she’s not making contact. Phone’s off. Apartment’s dusty. She vanished.”

Victor closed his eyes. His head was spinning. From the hangover. From exhaustion. From the fact that the world in which he’d lived the last three days had collapsed completely.

“Why did you tell me all this?”

“Because you have the right to know. And because... I owe you. You’re my friend, Vitya. Were a friend. Hope you’ll remain one.”

“Go to hell.”

Victor stood, walked to the door.

“Latov!”

He turned around.

“If she makes contact — I’ll tell her you were looking.”

“Don’t. I wasn’t looking for her.”

Victor left the apartment, descended the stairs, went out onto the street. The fog had thickened. Streetlights barely penetrated the white veil.

He walked down Foggy Street and thought that this haze around — was the perfect metaphor for everything that had happened to him. Fog. Obscurity. The impossibility of seeing where truth ends and lies begin.

Where the game ended and reality began.

If it began at all.

34 Valeria's Interlude

THE apartment in Schöneberg belonged to someone Valeria had never met and would never meet. That was the arrangement. Three rooms, sparse furniture, windows facing a courtyard where pigeons argued over breadcrumbs with the methodical fury of parliamentary deputies. The Yellow Pages on the hallway shelf were from 2003. The refrigerator held a single jar of mustard, expired.

Valeria sat on the floor with her back against the radiator, knees drawn up to her chin. The yellow suitcase stood by the door, still packed. She hadn't opened it since Heraklion. Couldn't. To open it would mean to unpack, to stay, to continue being someone. Right now she preferred being no one.

She'd left Matala at four in the morning. Slipped out of bed while Victor slept — his breath even, his arm draped across the place where she'd been, fingers curled loosely around nothing. She stood over him for two minutes. Maybe three. Long enough to memorize the shape of his sleeping face, the way his jaw relaxed into something almost boyish. Long enough to understand that if she stayed one more minute she wouldn't leave at all.

The note she'd composed in her head on the taxi ride to Heraklion. Seven words. Acrostic. A stupid, reckless, sentimental thing to do — leaving a coded breadcrumb for a man whose profession was decoding breadcrumbs. Liels would be furious if he knew. Vichitov would be worse than furious.

But she couldn't leave *nothing*. Not after the sea. Not after the stars over Matala that looked like a smashed chandelier. Not after Victor said "Thirty-one hours. A whole fortune" and meant it the way nobody in her adult life had meant anything.

The radiator ticked. Outside, a siren rose and fell.

The assignment had been simple. Accompany Latov for two days. Be charming. Be plausible. Provide Liels' people with a window to approach a third party — someone in Moscow who would only move if the surveillance shifted. Victor was the diversion. The decoy. The noise that covered the signal.

Crete was not in the plan.

Crete was hers.

She'd suggested it on Friedrichstrasse, standing in that alley where Victor photographed the elderly German couple, and the moment the words left her mouth she knew she was crossing a line that had no return path. Not a professional line — those she'd crossed before, many times, with the calm efficiency of a surgeon cutting through fascia. This was different. This was the line between the person she pretended to be and the person she was becoming in his presence. The person who rhymed on the go and danced under clocks and lay in the sea at night and felt — for the first time in years — that the weight of her own biography could be set down, like a suitcase, and left by the door.

She pressed her forehead against her knees. *Idiot. You're a professional idiot, Lehmann.*

The phone on the floor beside her was a burner. She'd sent two messages from it already. One to Liels: "Abort. I'm out. Don't contact." One to a number in Riga that would forward to another number in Tallinn that would eventually reach someone who could make her disappear for a while.

She could not send one to Victor. That would endanger him. More than she already had.

The note was enough. Had to be enough. He'd solve it — she was certain of that. He'd walk into Vichitov's office, see the statues, and the acrostic would click into

place like the final tumbler of a lock. And then he'd know: she hadn't forgotten. She'd left him a thread.

What he did with it was his business.

Valeria stood. Her knees ached from the cold floor. She went to the window, looked out at the courtyard. A cat sat on the wall opposite, cleaning its paw with the focused indifference of a creature that had never once in its life needed to be anyone other than itself.

"Lucky bastard," Valeria said aloud.

She turned from the window. Picked up the burner phone. Typed a third message — to a number she shouldn't have memorized, but had: *"Don't go to the museum. Dangerous. V."*

Stared at the screen. Pressed send. Then removed the SIM card, snapped it in half, dropped the pieces in the mustard jar.

Picked up the yellow suitcase. Left the apartment. Closed the door without locking it.

The pigeons in the courtyard didn't even look up.

35 Back to the Office

THE editorial office greeted Victor with familiar chaos. Phones rang like a drunk bell-ringer at Easter. Interns rushed between desks. Dmitry, the editorial Casanova, was telling someone on the phone another story of his amorous conquests, periodically laughing so loud the window glass rattled.

Ordinary Tuesday. Nothing had changed. As if the last three days hadn't happened at all.

Victor sat at his desk, turned on the computer. While it loaded, he pulled the camera from his bag. Connected it to the computer. Opened the photo folder.

Crete. Matala. Beach.

Valeria in profile against the sea. Light falls from the side, outlining her silhouette. Hair blowing in the wind. She's looking somewhere into the distance, smiling. At what? At him? Or at her thoughts? Or just playing a role?

Next photo. Valeria covering her face with her hands, laughing. Through her fingers her eyes are visible. Dark, almost black. What's in them? Joy? Or professional imitation of joy?

Another one. Valeria looking straight at the lens. Serious, almost severe. The gaze that then took his breath away. Victor zoomed in. Peered into the eyes in the photograph. Searched them for an answer. Truth or game? Feelings or assignment?

The eyes were silent.

"Latov!"

Victor flinched, quickly closed the folder. Turned around. Behind him stood the editor-in-chief, Anatoly Borisovich. Just as gray-haired as ten years ago. Only more bilious.

The editor's expression could be interpreted across the broadest spectrum: from "good thing you're alive!" to "where the hell have you been?"

"My office. Now."

Victor followed him. Sat down across the desk. Anatoly Borisovich leaned back in his chair, steeped his fingers.

"Where were you?"

"Berlin. Then Crete."

"On vacation?"

"Something like that."

"Without warning anyone?"

"Sorry. It was sudden."

Anatoly Borisovich sighed. Rubbed his face with his hands.

"Fine. I'm not your mother. You're a grown man. Can disappear whenever you want. But next time — at least send a message. So we know you're alive."

"Will do."

"Good. Now. There's a job for you. Interview. Interesting person. Businessman. Gold mining. Just your style."

"Not interested."

"What do you mean 'not interested'?"

"Exactly that. Not interested. I'm tired. Need a break."

Anatoly Borisovich looked at him carefully. Narrowed his eyes.

"Something happened?"

"No. Nothing."

"You sure?"

"Yes."

"Because you look like you just came back from a funeral."

Victor forced a smile.

"Just jet lag. And Moscow weather. After Greece — it's depressing."

Anatoly Borisovich didn't look convinced but didn't press.

"Fine. Take a day off. Rest. Then come back and do this interview. Deal?"

"Deal."

Victor left the office. Dmitry caught him in the corridor.

"Hey! How was it? Meet anyone?"

"Met."

"And?"

"And nothing. It's over."

"Why?"

"Because that's how it is. She's in Berlin. I'm here. Long-distance doesn't work."

"But you could try."

"Could. But won't."

Dmitry shook his head.

"You're an idiot, you know that?"

"I know."

"If you met someone — fight for it. Don't just give up."

"Easy to say."

"Not easy. But necessary. Otherwise you'll regret it."

"Maybe."

Victor went to his desk. Sat down. Stared at the blank computer screen.

He's right. Dmitry's right. I should fight. Should call her. Tell her I don't want it to end. That I want to see her again. That distance doesn't matter. That we can make it work.

But I won't. Because I'm a coward. Because I'm afraid. Afraid of rejection. Afraid of disappointment. Afraid of trying and failing. Better not to try at all. Better to keep the memory pure. Unspoiled by reality.

Coward. That's what I am. A coward who prefers safe loneliness to risky happiness.

The phone buzzed. Message from Pavlik: "Heard you vanished. Alive? Call when sober." Pavlik. Pavel Grinberg. Best friend since the dorm, the only person in

the world who could diagnose Victor's condition from five words or their absence. Now in Riga, doing something with databases and the Latvian tax authority. They talked once a month, irregularly, the way old friends do when proximity is no longer necessary to sustain affection.

Victor typed: *"Alive. Mostly."*

The reply came instantly: *"Mostly means a woman. Details later. Don't do anything stupid before calling me."*

Too late for that, Pasha.

Victor opened his email. Started deleting spam. Reports. Meetings.

Life going on. As always. As if nothing had happened. As if those three days on Crete were just a dream. A beautiful dream that ended when he woke up.

36 The Assignment

THE day off didn't happen. At eight in the morning Anatoly Borisovich called and demanded he come to the office immediately.

Victor had barely crossed the threshold of the office when all plans for the rest of the week and the weekend collapsed.

"Assignment. Urgent."

"I can't. I have material on..."

"Latov. This is not up for discussion. Assignment from above. Very far above. So far above I don't even know who sent it down. Understand?"

Victor understood. When assignments come from such heights that the editor-in-chief doesn't know the

source, it means one of two things: either someone very important or someone very dangerous. Or both at once.

"What's the assignment?"

"Interview. Gold mining company. Called..." Anatoly Borisovich rummaged through papers. — "Lex Vicit." Latin name, translates as "Law Prevailed." Or "Alexei Prevailed," can't remember exactly. Anyway, you need to go, talk with the general director, write a piece. Laudatory, but not too much. Smart, but not boring. You can do that, right?"

"I can. But why me?"

"Because they asked for you. Personally. By first and last name. Victor Latov, journalist, specialization — analysis and reportage. Turns out you're famous, Vitya. Congratulations."

"Congratulations for what? For being ordered by someone?"

"For being in demand. Stop whining. Go, do the interview, get paid. The company's solid, they pay well."

"When do I go?"

"Today. Now. Here's the address." Anatoly Borisovich handed over a slip. "They're expecting you at two. Don't be late. This isn't some prospectors' artel, this is serious business."

Victor took the slip, looked. Address in the center. Not far from the Kremlin. Impressive.

"What's the general director's name?"

"Vichitov. Alexei Vichitov. They say he's self-made. Started from nothing, now he's got assets worth billions. Typical example of the Russian dream. Do the interview, don't nitpick details, write beautifully. Clear?"

"Clear."

Anatoly Borisovich left. Victor opened the browser, typed in the search: "Lex Vicit."

Results — two and a half. Company's official website, consisting of a page with address and phone number. A mention in some industry directory. That's all. No news, no articles, no interviews. As if the company doesn't exist.

Victor typed: "Alexei Vichitov."

Even fewer results. One low-resolution photo — a blurry figure at some reception. Face indistinguishable. And a brief biography on the company website: "Alexei Vichitov, general director of Lex Vicit LLC. Education — higher technical. Work experience in the industry — 25 years." That's all.

Victor leaned back in his chair. A company about which nothing is known. A general director who doesn't exist, at least not online. An assignment sent from above. And they asked for him, Victor, personally.

Coincidence? Or continuation of yesterday's story with Liels?

He looked at his watch. Half past twelve. Time to go.

Victor closed the browser, shut down the computer. Grabbed the recorder, notepad, pen. Left the office without saying goodbye to anyone.

Outside, drizzle. Fine, nasty, Muscovite. Victor caught a cab.

"Corner of Tverskaya and Gazetny."

The driver nodded, started the meter. The car dove into traffic like a barge into a lock chamber.

Victor looked out the window. Moscow floated past, gray, wet, indifferent. People hurrying somewhere, running. Cars hurrying somewhere, honking. Somewhere very far away was Valeria. In Berlin. Or not. Maybe

in Moscow. Maybe quite nearby. Or maybe she never existed at all.

"Specialist in information extraction. Through people."

Victor pulled out his phone, opened the photos. Valeria on the beach. Laughing. Looking at the lens. Dancing. All this was a week ago. An eternity ago.

He closed the photos, put away the phone. He didn't want to think. He just wanted to get there, do the interview, return to the office, write the piece. Live on. Forget.

"Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V."

That's working out just great.

37 Research Begins

THE office building deep on Gazetny turned out to be faux-antique. Facade — beige, with molding and columns. As if the architect wanted to build a palace, but the budget ran out halfway, and he had to settle for imitation.

Victor went inside. The lobby was finished in marble, white and gleaming, like a bald skull at autopsy. Behind the reception desk sat a girl resembling all girls at all receptions in all Moscow offices. Perfect hair, perfect manicure, perfect smile, perfect emptiness in the gaze.

"Good afternoon. I'm here to see Alexei Vichitov. Victor Latov, journalist."

The girl looked at the computer, nodded.

"Yes, you're expected. Fifth floor, right, office number three. Elevator's over there."

Victor took the elevator up. The fifth floor greeted him with silence. Long corridor, carpeted in dried blood color. On the walls — paintings. Landscapes, still lifes,

portraits. All expensive, all uninteresting. Art for offices.

Office number three. Victor knocked.

"Come in."

He entered. The office turned out to be a reception area. At the desk sat another girl, same as downstairs. As if they're copy-pasted.

"Victor Latov?"

"Yes."

"Alexei Petrovich is currently in a meeting. He asked you to wait. Please have a seat."

She indicated a leather couch in the corner. Victor sat. Pulled out his phone, looked at the time. Exactly two o'clock. He'd arrived on time. But he'd still have to wait.

Ten minutes passed. Twenty. Thirty. The clone girl typed something on the computer, periodically answered phone calls. "Alexei Petrovich is in a meeting. Yes, I'll pass it on. Taking note."

Victor scrolled through the news feed on his phone. Another scandal in government. Another accident on the road. Another celebrity divorced another husband. Earth kept spinning, indifferent to his problems. And what special problems did he have anyway, if you thought about it?

An hour passed.

Victor stood, went to the window. Cars crawled on the pavement below. People walked on sidewalks. Life went on. And he was sitting in some mythical gold miner's reception area, waiting.

"Excuse me," he said to the girl. "How much longer?"

"Alexei Petrovich will be free any minute. Would you like coffee?"

Victor returned to the couch. Closed his eyes. Before him photos surfaced again. Valeria on the beach. The sea. Sun. Bungalow. The note.

“Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V.”

And now he was sitting in a reception area, waiting to meet a man about whom he knew nothing. On an assignment sent from above. Too many coincidences. Too many uncertainties.

Another half hour passed.

The office door opened. Victor raised his eyes.

In the doorway stood a man.

Huge. To call him simply tall would be a regrettable understatement. Though I’ve seen people even bigger. This one — shoulders no wider than the Statue of Liberty, and arms no thicker than an ordinary elephant’s leg. The head, covered with thin and slightly transparent skin, resembled a frosted light bulb. Neck — like a bollard on a cruise ship dock. Square face, heavy jaw, unexpectedly thin aristocratic nose looked absurd on that face, like a part from a different set.

And lips. Plump, moist, unexpectedly sensual on this face. Lips that should have belonged to someone else. Lips that looked as out of place as a rose in an executioner’s buttonhole.

Victor stood. The man stepped into the reception. On his arms — tattoos. Sleeves. Victor managed to make out crosses, stars, some inscriptions, a huge green oak with a golden chain. Prison ink elegantly covered over with colored modern work.

The man stopped a meter from Victor. Looked at him from top to bottom. Eyes — deep, intelligent, attentive. Eyes that had seen much. Grief and joy, happiness and pain, birth and death. These eyes had seen too much, but hadn’t stopped being able to wonder and smile.

He smiled. Plump lips stretched, revealing even white porcelain teeth.

"Victor Latov? Journalist?"

The voice was unexpectedly soft. Quiet. Almost refined. A voice that should have belonged to a literature teacher, not this Hulk in a business suit.

"Yes."

"Alexei Vichitov. Pleased to meet you." He extended his hand.

Victor shook it. The hand was hot, dry, powerful. The grip squeezed his fingers like a vise. Not painful, but noticeable. A demonstration of strength. Light, unobtrusive, but clear.

"Come into the office. Let's talk."

Vichitov turned, walked to the door. Victor followed him.

The office was large. Dark wood desk, behind the desk — leather chair. On the walls — paintings, framed diplomas, photographs with some important people. Everything proper. Everything correct. Everything false, like scenery in a cheap theater.

Vichitov sat in the chair, leaned back. Gestured for Victor to sit opposite.

"Coffee? Tea? Cognac? Water?"

"No thank you."

"As you wish." Vichitov pulled a cigar from the desk drawer, clipped the end, lit it. Smoke rose in thick rings. "So, Victor. You're probably surprised that we asked for you specifically?"

"A little."

"A little?" Vichitov smirked. "You're being modest. You must be very surprised. A company about which no one's heard. A director about whom the internet

knows nothing. An assignment sent from somewhere above. Correct?"

Victor was silent. Vichitov blew a few more smoke rings.

"I appreciate your caution. It's a good quality for a journalist. And for a person in general. In our time people talk too much. But you need to listen more. And observe."

He stood, went to the window. Stood with his back to Victor, looking at Tverskaya.

"Tell me, Victor..." The voice became even quieter, almost intimate. "Have you heard anything about Valeria Lehmann?"

The world stopped.

Victor sat motionless. Blood pounded in his temples. Thoughts raced through his head, colliding with each other like cars in a train wreck.

Vichitov slowly turned around. Looked at Victor. On the plump lips played a slight smile.

"Judging by your face, you have. Good. So we can talk."

38 Vichitov's Office

VICHITOV rose from behind the desk. He moved unexpectedly smoothly, despite his size. Like a tank that had completed ballet courses.

"Walk with me, Victor. We'll talk as we go. I don't like sitting still. Stasis — enemy of thought."

Victor stood, followed him. Vichitov opened the door, went into the corridor. Walked fast, with wide strides. Victor barely kept up.

"Valeria Lehmann," Vichitov continued without turning around, "worked for us for some time. Freelancer. One-off assignments. Very capable girl. Very smart."

"Worked?" Victor seized on that word like a drowning man on a straw.

"Worked. Contract ended. Contact broke off. It happens." Vichitov stopped at a door with a sign "Conference Room," pushed it. "Come in."

The room was empty. Long table, chairs around it, projector on the ceiling. Everything proper. Everything boring, like a meeting about quarterly indicators.

"I'm not in the gold mining business," said Vichitov suddenly. "That is, I am. But that's not the main thing. The main thing — I'm a collector. I collect rarities. Documents. Artifacts. Things that have history. Understand?"

Victor didn't understand. But nodded. Journalist rule number one: nod until you understand. Questions, if they remain, ask later.

"Recently I learned of the existence of a certain document. Very rare. Dated 1169. Iberian Peninsula. Details later. Now what's important: I need someone who will find it."

"I'm a journalist, not a private detective."

Vichitov smirked. Plump lips stretched into a smile that was supposed to express good nature, but looked like the contemptuous politeness of a pawnshop appraiser.

"Victor. I studied your biography. Math faculty. Honors degree. Then journalism. You write analytical pieces. Investigations. You find connections where others see chaos. You have a brain made for solving puzzles. That's exactly the kind of person I need."

"Nevertheless, I'm not..."

"The work is legal. No criminal activity, if you mistakenly judged me by my clothes. Simply searching for a document. Archives, libraries, museums. All within the law. Payment — very good. Very."

Victor was silent. In his head spun one thing: Valeria. Connection to Valeria. If he refused — he'd lose the thread. If he agreed — maybe he'd learn what happened. Where she is. Why she disappeared.

"I need to think."

"Of course." Vichitov nodded. "But there's little time. Others might find the document. Competition, you know. Come, I'll show you one more room."

They left the conference room, walked down the corridor. Vichitov stopped at a door at the end. The door was massive, oak, with a brass plaque: "Private Collection."

Vichitov pulled out a key, unlocked the door, went inside. Victor followed him.

The room was small. Square. No windows. Lighting — spotlights in the ceiling, directed downward. Floor cold, even to the eye very heavy and very white. Around the perimeter — pedestals. On each — a statue.

Victor froze at the threshold.

The statues were ancient. Or very good copies. Marble, darkened by time. Figures of people, animals, chimeras. Some whole, some — fragments. Head without body. Torso without arms. Hand holding something incomprehensible.

"My collection," said Vichitov quietly. A new intonation appeared in his voice. Almost tenderness. Like an entomologist driving a pin into what used to be a beetle. "Collected around the world. For years. Some — legally. Some..." He waved his hand. "Doesn't matter. Now they're here. Safe."

Victor walked around the room. Under each statue — a small plaque. Laconic. Simple.

"Figure 1."

"Figure 2."

"Figure 3."

And so on. Twelve in total.

"I'm not an art historian," said Vichitov, as if justifying himself. "So I don't bother with descriptions. Figure — and number. Simple. Clear. Military style."

They stood by figure number five. It was a woman's torso without head and arms. Marble polished so smooth it seemed almost transparent. Drapery of clothing — finest work. Each fold — alive.

"Greece, fourth century BC," Vichitov explained. "Presumably, school of Praxiteles. Or imitation. Not established for certain. Beautiful, isn't it?"

"I'm not an art historian, I only know whisky well."

Victor moved away from the statue. Walked around the others. Figure 6 — lion's head. Figure 7 — chimera, half-woman-half-bird. Figure 8 — naked youth with sword. All numbered. All without detailed descriptions.

"Why are you showing me this?"

"So you understand who you're dealing with." Vichitov turned, looked at Victor. "I'm a serious person. I have resources. Connections. Capabilities. If I'm asking to find a document — that means it's important. Very important. And I'm ready to pay. Generously."

"How much?"

Vichitov named a sum. Victor tried to keep his facial muscles motionless. Didn't work out so well.

"For searching for a twelfth-century document?"

"For searching for *this* document. Unique. Priceless. To me."

Victor slowly nodded. The sum was such that he could not work for a year. Or two. Or just go somewhere warm where he wouldn't need to think about Valeria.

But he'd still think about her. Because the only thing that interested him now — wasn't money. But the answer to the question: what does all this have to do with the woman who disappeared, leaving a note of seven words?

"All right," he said. "I agree. But I need details. What exactly is the document? Where to search? Any, as a detective would say, leads?"

"Tomorrow. Come tomorrow at ten in the morning. I'll explain everything. Show you materials. Give you contacts. Agreed?"

"For such a fee I could just camp out on your doorstep until tomorrow morning."

They left the room. Vichitov locked the door, walked Victor to the elevator. Shook his hand. The same hot, dry, inexorable claw.

"Until tomorrow, Victor. And thank you for agreeing. You won't regret it."

The elevator closed. Victor descended, looking at his reflection in the mirrored walls. The reflection looked bewildered. Like a man who'd just agreed to jump off a cliff into the sea, having no idea about the seafloor terrain below.

39 The Collection

THE metro was half-empty. Evening rush hour hadn't started yet. Victor sat in the corner, leaned back against the seat. The train moved, dove into the tunnel.

Darkness outside the window. Station lights floating past. People entering and exiting. Ordinary life. And his — extraordinary. Completely idiotically extraordinary.

A gold miner who collects ancient statues. A twelfth-century document from the Iberian Peninsula. Valeria, who worked for him as a freelancer. And now has disappeared.

There's a connection. Must be. Too many coincidences.

Victor pulled out his phone, opened the photos. Crete. Beach. Valeria. Scrolled to the last photo. The one where she looks at the lens. Serious. Almost stern.

What were you trying to say? Why did you dance under the clock? Why fly with me to Crete? Why all of it?

Victor closed his eyes. The train swayed. Thoughts spun in his head, colliding with each other.

"Forget it." Forget.

But he can't forget. Doesn't want to. Won't be able to.

"Gone under radar eventually."

Eventually. In the end. Ultimately. Strange word. Why not just "gone under radar"? Why "eventually"?

And why the hell is she writing in English? They spoke Russian the whole time. Sometimes — German. But not English. Not once.

Victor opened his eyes. Slowly spoke aloud, in different ways:

"Forget it. Gone under radar eventually. V."

English. Strange English. With the redundant "eventually." With periods after each phrase, not commas. As if...

As if this isn't just a message.

Victor sat up straight. His heart beat faster.

Anagram. It could be an anagram.

He pulled a pen from his pocket, found a notepad in his bag. Wrote down the letters:

F-O-R-G-E-T-I-T-G-O-N-E-U-N-D-E-R-R-A-D-A-R-E-V-
E-N-T-U-A-L-L-Y-V

Too many letters. Too complicated for a note scribbled hastily on a scrap of paper. Or...

Or not all the letters. Maybe just the initial ones?

F. I. G. U. R. E. V.

Victor stared at what he'd written. Reread it.

Figure. V.

Figure. Five.

Figure 5.

That very one, in Vichitov's room. Torso without head and arms. Greece, fourth century. Presumably, school of Praxiteles.

Victor leaned back against the seat. His head buzzed.

Valeria had left him a message. Disguised as ordinary text. An acronym. That could be deciphered only by someone who'd been in Vichitov's office. Who'd seen the statues. Who knew they were numbered.

So she knew he'd go there. So everything was planned. Assignment from the editorial office. Interview with Vichitov. Room with statues.

But why? What's in the fifth figure? What did she want to say?

The train braked. Victor got off at his station, went up. Walked home fast, almost running. Climbed the stairs, burst into the apartment. Turned on the computer, opened the browser.

“Document 1169 Iberian Peninsula.”

The search returned several results. Victor scanned them.

Chronicles. Royal decrees. Trade agreements. Church documents.

Nothing special. Nothing that could explain Vichitov's interest.

Victor tried differently:

“1169 rare document Iberia.”

More results. He opened the first link. Article in English. Academic journal. Title:

“The Ransom Letter of 1169: A Call for the Redemption of Jews Captured by Crusaders.”

Ransom letter of 1169. Call to ransom Jews captured by crusaders.

Victor read the abstract. Then the full article. Then again.

In 1169, during one of the crusades, a group of crusaders captured a caravan of Jewish merchants in the territory of modern Spain. Demanded ransom. The community composed a letter, sent copies throughout Europe. Called for money to be collected. The document survived in several copies. Rarest example of medieval Jewish epistolography.

Victor closed the browser. Sat at the table. Put his head in his hands.

A gold miner searching for a twelfth-century Jewish ransom letter. Valeria worked for him. Then disappeared. Left an anagram pointing to the fifth statue in his collection.

There was a connection. But what? And most importantly — why?

Victor stood, paced the room. Outside it had gotten dark. Moscow was lighting up. Somewhere there, in this city, or another, was Valeria. Hiding. "Under the radar." From whom? From Vichitov? From someone else?

And what did she want him to find in the fifth figure?

Too many questions. Not a single answer.

Victor lay on the couch without undressing. Closed his eyes. But sleep wouldn't come. In his head spun:

Figure V. Figure 5. Torso without head. Ransom letter. 1169. Valeria. "Forget it." Forget it. But how to forget when this — is the only thread?

Somewhere very far away two o'clock struck. Victor still lay with open eyes, staring at the ceiling.

And the ceiling was silent. As always.

40 Next Morning

VICHITOV met him at the elevator. Smiled broadly, almost warmly. Plump lips stretched like a satisfied boa after lunch.

"Victor! Good to see you. Come in, come in. Coffee? Tea? Cognac? Water?"

"Coffee, thanks."

They went into the office. On the table already stood two cups, a thermos, cookies in a bowl. Vichitov poured coffee, pushed a cup toward Victor. Sat in the chair, leaned back.

"So. Yesterday we got acquainted a bit. Today — to business. But first... Victor, do you follow football?"

Victor frowned. The question was unexpected and completely irrelevant.

"Not really."

"Pity. I love it. Spartak, of course. All my life. I remember, in ninety-one, when we lost to CSKA, but then the next three years... Ah, those were times." Vichitov smiled, looking somewhere past Victor, into the past. "Then it seemed anything was possible. That the country would be reborn, that life would get better. But it turned out — everything's much more complicated."

Victor was silent. Drank coffee. Waited. Understood that Vichitov was stalling. Why — unclear. Nervous? Afraid? Or just enjoying keeping his interlocutor in suspense?

"By the way, about football," Vichitov continued. "Know why the Spanish are so good at this sport? They learned to play ball from the Arabs. In the eighth century, when the Moors conquered the peninsula. The Arabs played some game of theirs, similar to football. The Spanish adopted it, developed it. After several centuries they became the best. Funny history, isn't it?"

"Very. Though I don't know how the English would feel about it." Victor put the cup on the table. "Alexei Petrovich, maybe we could get to business? You promised to tell me about the document."

Vichitov nodded. His expression changed. The smile disappeared. His eyes became serious, attentive.

"The document. Yes. The ransom letter of 1169. You've heard of it?"

"Found it online yesterday. Call to ransom Jews captured by crusaders. Rare document. Several copies survived."

"Not copies," Vichitov corrected. "Exemplars. That's an important difference. A copy — is something transcribed later. An exemplar — is one of several originals. The letter was sent simultaneously to different

cities. Cairo, Alexandria, Baghdad, Rome. Each one — authentic. Understand?”

“I understand. And you need one of these exemplars.”

“I need a specific one. The one written by Maimonides.”

Victor flinched.

“Maimonides? Moshe ben Maimon? Rambam?”

Vichitov raised an eyebrow.

“I see you’re an educated man. Yes, exactly him. The greatest Jewish philosopher and legal scholar of the Middle Ages. In 1169 he lived in Fes, then moved to Fustat, a suburb of Cairo. He was thirty-four years old. He hadn’t yet written his major works, but was already known as a rabbi and physician.”

“And he wrote this letter.”

“One of the exemplars. In his own hand. In Arabic, in Hebrew script. So-called Judeo-Arabic. Common practice for Jews of that time and place.”

Victor leaned back in his chair. Thoughts spun in his head. Maimonides. 12th century. Ransom letter. All this was interesting from a historical perspective. But why was it so important to Vichitov? Collectors pay big money for rarities, that’s understandable. But such money? For one letter?

“Alexei Petrovich, I don’t understand. The letter is certainly rare. But it’s not unique. There are other exemplars. Why search for this specific one?”

Vichitov was silent. Stood, went to the window. Stood looking at Tverskaya. Then turned around.

“Victor. What I’m about to tell you must remain between us. Agreed?”

“Good thing you warned me, I was about to post yesterday’s conversation on TikTok.”

"Maimonides' exemplar contains something more than just the letter's text. It has encrypted information. Additional data. That points to another document."

Victor frowned.

"Encrypted? How?"

"Steganography. Hidden message within the apparent text. Maimonides was a genius. He knew Kabbalah, numerology, many encryption systems. He could embed in an ordinary letter an additional level of information such that no one except the initiated would notice."

"And you know how to decrypt it?"

"Partially. I have a key. Incomplete, but sufficient to understand: the letter points to the next document in the chain."

Victor slowly exhaled.

"In the chain? Meaning there are several documents?"

"A whole chain. Each document contains a pointer to the next. The chain stretches through centuries. Through countries and cultures. Maimonides' letter — is one of the links. Not the first, but important."

"And where's the end of this chain?"

Vichitov returned to the table. Sat. Looked Victor in the eyes.

"At the beginning of our era. First century. Judea. Times of Pontius Pilate."

The world stopped again. Like when Vichitov first mentioned Valeria.

"Pontius Pilate?" Victor heard his own voice as if from outside. Hoarse, incredulous.

"Yes. According to my data, at the end of this chain — is a document. Very old. Very important. Transcript of a trial.

"What trial?"

Vichitov was silent. Then spoke slowly, distinctly, as if afraid of being misunderstood:

"The trial of Jesus Christ."

Silence. Victor sat motionless. Looked at Vichitov. Waited for him to laugh, say: "Joking, of course." But Vichitov didn't laugh. Looked serious, almost solemn.

"You're... serious?"

"Absolutely. I've spent fifteen years researching this topic. Hired historians, paleographers, cryptographers. Studied sources. There are traces. Faint, almost imperceptible. But they exist. There is a document. Transcript of a real trial. Not just Pilate's verdict. But a full proceeding. Possibly even with jurors. With interrogations. With witness testimony. Complete transcript."

Victor tried to gather his thoughts. This was madness. Pure, undiluted madness. A document two thousand years old. Trial transcript. Jesus Christ.

"Alexei Petrovich. Even assuming such a document existed... How could it have survived? Two thousand years. Wars, fires, destruction. It's impossible."

"Not impossible. Difficult. But not impossible. The Dead Sea Scrolls survived. Papyri from Oxyrhynchus. Herculaneum scrolls. If the document was cherished, hidden, passed hand to hand — it could have survived. Could have."

"But why? Why would anyone preserve a trial transcript for two thousand years?"

Vichitov smirked. Bitterly, without joy.

"Victor. If you knew the real story of Christ's trial... Not the one described in the Gospels. But the real one. What happened there. Who made the decisions. On what grounds. With what motives. It would turn the world upside down. Would overturn Christianity. Even Judaism and Islam. The entire history of Western civilization."

"You believe this."

"I know this."

Victor was silent. Then asked quietly:

"Could I look at your collection again?"

Vichitov flinched. Barely noticeably, but Victor noticed. His face tensed for a moment.

"Why?"

"Just... curious. Yesterday I didn't really have time to examine it properly. Would like to again."

"No." The voice became hard. "The collection is closed. I show it rarely. Very rarely. Yesterday — was an exception."

"But..."

"No, Victor. Sorry." Vichitov stood, paced the office. Nervous. Clearly nervous. — "Let's get back to business. Here." He went to the safe in the corner, entered the code, opened it. Pulled out a thick folder, three flash drives. "Here — materials from previous research. Notes, photographs, translations. Work of several people over the last ten years. Study them. They'll help."

Victor took the folder. Heavy, as if filled with manuscripts on clay tablets. Put the flash drives in his pocket.

"Others worked on this before me?"

"Three. One found a trail in Toledo, then disappeared. The second worked in Córdoba, then refused to continue. The third... the third died. Heart attack. A month ago."

"Dangerous work, then."

"Not dangerous. Just complex. And perhaps not everyone's lucky." Vichitov returned to his desk. — "Victor. I understand this sounds fantastic. But please: take it seriously. Study the materials. Perhaps you'll be luckier

than previous researchers. You have a different mind-set. Mathematician. You see patterns. That's important."

"You don't need a mathematician, you need a psychic." Victor stood, tucked the folder under his arm. "I'll look. Study it. If I find something — I'll report immediately. You understand the chances are slim?"

"I understand. But nothing ventured, nothing gained, as one rather unpleasant person used to say." Vichitov walked him to the door. "Stay in touch. Call, write. If you need help — say so. I have contacts. In archives, libraries, museums. I can arrange access."

Again that handshake that numbs your pinkie. Victor left, descended in the elevator. Outside it was overcast. Drizzling rain. That Moscow rain, fine, nasty.

Victor caught a taxi.

"*Planeta* editorial office, Tverskoy Boulevard."

He needed to talk with Anatoly Borisovich. Tell him... what? That a gold-mining-collector hired him to search for Maimonides' letter, which is part of a secret chain of documents leading to the transcript of Jesus Christ's trial?

Anatoly Borisovich would either laugh or send him on medical leave. With a diagnosis.

Victor took out his phone. Dialed Liels' number. Long rings. Voicemail.

"Liels, it's Latov. I need to talk to you. Urgent. Call back, please."

Hung up. Dialed again. Voicemail.

Texted: "Call. Important."

No answer.

Victor put the phone in his pocket, pressed his forehead against the cold window glass. Outside Moscow floated past. Gray, rainy, indifferent.

And in his head spun:

Figure 5. Maimonides. Year 1169. Ransom letter. Chain of documents. Pontius Pilate. Christ's trial. Valeria. "Forget it." Acrostic. "Figure V."

What did she want to say? What's connected to the fifth figure? Why did Vichitov get so nervous when Victor asked to see the collection again?

Time to declare a moratorium on meaningless questions that promised no answers.

41 The Folder

THE editorial office greeted him with its usual chaos. Dmitry was yelling at an intern, who defended himself, waving his arms. Someone drank coffee standing by the window. Someone talked on the phone, phone cradled between shoulder and ear while typing on a keyboard.

Ordinary day. Ordinary life.

Victor went to Anatoly Borisovich's desk. He sat hunched over the monitor, grimacing as if reading the discharge summary for his gastritis.

"May I?"

"Come in." Anatoly Borisovich tore himself from the screen. "Well? How's the interview? Written?"

"Not yet. It's... more complicated than it seemed."

"In what sense?"

Victor sat, placed the folder on the desk.

"He wants me to work for him. Not an interview. Different assignment."

Anatoly Borisovich squinted.

"What assignment?"

"Research. Searching for a rare document. Historical topic."

"And you agreed?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Victor was silent. Then said honestly:

"Because I need to find out something. Personal. This assignment — is the way."

Anatoly Borisovich leaned back in his chair. Looked at Victor for a long time. Then sighed.

"Latov. You're one of my best journalists. But sometimes you get into such shit that I don't understand: are you brave or just an idiot."

"False dichotomy. I'm a fairly brave idiot."

"Exactly." Anatoly Borisovich rubbed the bridge of his nose. "Fine. Take vacation. Two weeks. Do your assignment. But if you feel something's wrong — drop it and come back. Deal?"

"Deal. Thanks."

"Don't mention it. And Vitya..." Anatoly Borisovich looked serious. "Take care of yourself. I don't need dead journalists. They write articles poorly."

Victor smirked.

"I'll try to survive."

Latov headed to his desk. Opened the folder Vichitov gave him. Inside — hundreds of pages. Handwritten notes, printouts, photographs of ancient manuscripts. All in different languages. English, Spanish, Hebrew, Arabic.

Victor flipped through the first pages. His head spun. This was months' work. Years.

He closed the folder, stuffed the flash drives in his pocket. Turned off the computer. Stood.

Dmitry, passing by, asked:

"Where are you off to?"

"Searching for the Holy Grail."

"Right. Find it — share."

"Absolutely."

Victor left the editorial office. Outside the rain had stopped. Sun appeared. Autumnal, pale, pitiful.

Victor walked along Tverskoy Boulevard thinking. About Valeria. About Vichitov. About Maimonides' letter. About Christ's trial. About the fifth figure. About the acrostic.

Somewhere in this tangle was the truth. He just needed to find the thread and pull. Carefully, delicately. So as not to break it. So as not to get even more tangled.

The phone vibrated. Victor took it out, looked.

SMS. Unfamiliar number.

"Don't go to the museum. Dangerous. V."

Victor stopped in the middle of the sidewalk. People walked around him, muttering in annoyance. He stood, staring at the screen.

Don't go to the museum. What museum? Vichitov's room? Or a real museum?

Dangerous.

Valeria was warning him. Meaning she knew what was happening. Meaning she was watching.

Victor typed a reply: "Where are you? What's happening?"

Sent.

"Message not delivered."

Of course.

Victor put away the phone. Walked on.

Don't go to the museum. Dangerous.

Fine. He wouldn't go. For now.

But sooner or later he'd have to.

Because the answers — were there. In that room, with the twelve statues. In the fifth figure.

And Valeria knew it.

42 Prison Visit to Lipkin

THE folder opened like a hungry crocodile's jaws and spat its contents onto the table. Papers, photographs, photocopies. All yellowed, creased, covered in different handwriting in different languages. Victor stared at this pile like an archaeologist at the ruins of Babylon, understanding that reconstructing the whole from fragments — was a lifetime's work.

First page — photograph of a manuscript. Hebrew letters floating across yellowed paper like ants on a dried leaf. Caption in English: "Genizah fragment, Cairo, 1169." Fragment from the Genizah. Cairo. That very repository of forgotten texts where documents moldered that weren't lucky enough to become sacred.

Second page — handwritten notes. Handwriting small, nervous, like the electrocardiogram of a paranoid. "Leo — Manchester. Check poker circuit. Possible connection to Toledo archive." Vincent Leo. Poker player. Manchester. Connection to the Toledo archive.

Third — another photograph. Man about fifty, bald, with a mustache like a Soviet police major's. Face crumpled, displeased. Under the photo — name: Vladimir Lipkin. And a note: "Serving 10 years, Tula. Securities fraud. Refused to cooperate."

Victor flipped further. More photographs. More notes. Fragments of translations. Diagrams resembling genealogical trees of madmen. Names, dates, places. All scattered like mirror shards after an explosion. Could be reassembled, but the picture would be incomplete, and you'd definitely cut yourself.

Two names appeared more often than others. Vincent Leo. Vladimir Lipkin. Were both researchers? Or witnesses? Or victims? Unclear.

Victor took out his phone. Dialed the Federal Penitentiary Service number, explained the situation. Journalist. Interview with an inmate. Yes, have accreditation. Yes, understand the procedure. When can I come?

Day after tomorrow. Tula. Colony number three. Lipkin Vladimir Sergeevich. Fifteen minutes, no more. Through glass.

Victor hung up. Looked at his watch. Two days. Could manage to study the materials better. Or could fail to avoid going mad from this hodgepodge of facts, guesses and paranoia.

He chose the second. Because the first — was boring.

43 To Tula

TULA greeted him with rain. Fine and tedious, like a lecture on macroeconomics. The city was gray, flat, untidily sprawling. Victor rode in a taxi, looking out the window at panel buildings standing along the road like sentries who'd fallen asleep at their post.

The colony turned out to be outside the city. Concrete walls, watchtowers, barbed wire twisted into spirals resembling the guts of some metallic monster. Victor went through security, handed over phone, pen,

notepad. They left only his passport and brain. The latter — by oversight.

The visit was in a room divided by glass. On both sides — plastic chairs bolted to the floor, like prisoners' hopes for early release. Victor sat, waited.

Lipkin entered slowly. Shuffling his feet like an old man, though he was no more than fifty. His bald head gleamed under fluorescent lights. Mustache thinned, sagging. Face was pale; face of a man who'd forgotten what the sun was. Eyes — restless, twitching, unhealthy.

Sat opposite. Looked at Victor. Said nothing.

"Vladimir Sergeevich. My name is Victor Latov. I'm a journalist. I'd like to ask you a few questions."

Lipkin was silent. His hands lay on the table. The left one — with a tattoo on the wrist. Initials intertwined in a monogram. Done clumsily, crudely. Prison work.

"You researched medieval documents. Maimonides' letter of 1169. Remember?"

Lipkin flinched. Barely noticeably, but Victor noticed.

"Don't remember."

Voice hoarse, uncertain. Voice of a man who's lying and knows no one will buy his lie.

"You worked for Alexei Vichitov. Searched for a document. In Spain. In archives."

"Didn't work."

"Vladimir Sergeevich. I'm not from the police. I don't care about your problems with the law. I'm just looking for information. Maybe I can help you somehow?"

Lipkin flinched again. Stronger. His hands trembled. He hid them under the table.

"No one will help me. No one. Leave."

"I can talk to your lawyer. Maybe there's a way..."

"No!" The voice broke into a scream. "There's no way! You don't understand! Nobody understands!"

Victor was silent. Then said quietly:

"The fifth figure."

Lipkin jumped up. The chair scraped on the floor. His face contorted.

"Visit's over!" He spun around, pounded on the door. "Visit's over!"

The guard entered, led Lipkin out. He didn't look back. Walked fast, hunched over, as if being beaten on the back with invisible whips.

Victor sat looking at the empty chair behind the glass. So. Lipkin knew something. And was mortally afraid of it. So much so that ten years in prison seemed to him a lesser evil than a conversation about figure five.

What was there, in that room of Vichitov's? What was hidden in the fifth statue?

44 The Interview

MANCHESTER lay buried in fog. Dense, damp, enveloping, like the embrace of an unloved mother-in-law. along streets, gloomy as Dostoevsky's thoughts, old as Sodom's sins. Victor walked from the hotel to the casino where the tournament was held, thinking the English clearly knew something about depression if they'd managed to build such a city.

The casino was called "Royal Flush." The name was pretentious, like a strip club claiming cultural center status. Inside — gilding, crystal, carpets as thick as a royal featherbed, but hard as bulletproof glass. People in tuxedos and evening gowns. Smell of expensive perfume, expensive whisky, expensive despair.

The tournament was invitation-only, the buy-in obscene. Victor studied the player list posted in the lobby and found what he needed: "V. Leo — Table 3." He slipped the floor manager three hundred pounds and a business card with Vichitov's company name. Five minutes later he had a seat at the high-stakes cash game running parallel to the tournament — the one where eliminated players drifted to nurse their wounds and their bankrolls. Vichitov's money made him invisible in the way only large sums can.

Victor played tight for two hours, the way Pavlik had taught him back in the dorm — only premium hands, small pots, nothing flashy. The mathematical edge was real but narrow; he wasn't here to win. He was here to wait.

Around ten, Vincent Leo appeared. Eliminated from the tournament in the middle rounds, he sat down at Victor's table with the calm efficiency of a man who played cards the way others breathed. Victor recognized him from the photograph — Italian, about fifty. Thin, sinewy, like a bicycle chain. Face tanned, carved with wrinkles like a map of roads leading nowhere. Eyes — smart, attentive, cold. On his wrist — a watch. Swiss. Worth a good car.

Leo played professionally. Calmly. Calculated probabilities, read opponents, bet precisely. Won often. Lost rarely.

Victor observed. Memorized. Waited for the moment.

An hour in, the table had thinned. Five remained. Victor got ace-king of spades. Leo sat opposite. Raised. Victor raised back. Three folded. Just the two of them remained.

Flop — queen of spades, jack of spades, four of clubs. Victor had — flush draw and straight draw. Incomplete but dangerous hands. Leo bet. Victor called.

Turn — ten of spades. The straight came together. Ace, King, Queen, Jack, Ten. Broadway. The best possible straight. Leo looked at the cards. Thought. Bet half the pot.

Victor raised twice.

Leo looked at him. Long. Attentively. Picky. Then said with an accent:

“You play well. But I have better.”

Went all-in. All the money. All the chips.

Victor didn’t hesitate. Called.

They showed cards. Leo had — pair of aces. Pre-flop — the strongest hand. Now — just a pair.

River — two of hearts. Nothing changed. Victor won with the straight.

Leo froze. Looked at the cards. Then slowly raised his eyes to Victor.

Victor leaned forward. Said quietly, so only Leo could hear:

“You’ll lose. I have what’s called figure five.”

Leo went pale. Sharply. As if blood instantly drained to his legs. He dropped the cards on the table. Stood.

“Excuse me.” Voice trembled. “Excuse me. I need... some air.”

He left the table. Stopped at the edge of the hall. Turned. Looked at Victor. Nodded his head toward the exit.

Victor stood, collected his chips. Left the hall. The hall remained behind — green felt of tables, glint of gilding, flicker of watches on wrists, rustle of chips, like the rustle of money counted by death’s invisible treasurer.

45 Manchester

LEO walked fast. Without looking back. Victor followed him. They went out onto the street. Manchester at night was dark, damp, smelling of coal and joyless past. The streetlights burned dimly, like the hopes of the unemployed in this city.

They passed the Palace Theatre. Old building, Victorian, decorated with molding from which pieces were already falling off, like skin from a leper. Past Verizon Wireless Arena — modern, glass, cold as a corporation's heart.

Leo stopped at a bar downtown. Neon sign flashed: "The Crown." Crown. Everything in this city remembered monarchy, even the pubs.

"Wait inside," said Leo. "I need to talk to someone. Two minutes."

Victor nodded. Entered the bar.

Inside was stuffy, smoky, noisy. Smelled of beer, sweat, disappointment. People sat at tables, drank, talked, laughed. Ordinary people. Ordinary life. The kind Victor no longer had.

He went to the bar, ordered whisky. Bartender poured without looking. Movements automatic, like a dishwasher.

Victor brought the glass to his lips.

And heard two shots.

Muffled. But distinct. Merciless as a verdict.

Victor dropped the glass, bolted for the exit. Flung open the door.

On the sidewalk, in a pool of light from a streetlamp, lay Vincent Leo. On his back. Arms spread to the sides. On his chest — two dark stains spreading like ink on blotting paper.

Victor fell to his knees beside him. Grabbed Leo by the shoulders.

"Vincent! What?! Who did this?!"

Leo opened his eyes. Looked at Victor. Lips moved. From his throat came a wheeze, gurgling, terrible.

"Not... Figure..." Words came with difficulty. Each — through pain. "Not Figure Five..."

"What? What did you say?!"

"Ligature..." Leo coughed. Blood appeared on his lips. "Ligature V... L... V..."

Eyes closed. Breathing stopped. Body went limp.

Victor sat on his knees, holding a dead man in his arms. People were gathering around. Someone was screaming. Someone calling the police. Someone crying.

Victor looked at Vincent Leo's face. Dead. Calm. Freed from fear.

Ligature V.

Not Figure. Ligature.

What did it mean?

Sirens wailed in the distance. Approaching. Fast.

Victor stood. Looked at his hands. On them was blood. Someone else's. Warm. Sticky.

He walked away from the bar, from the body, from the crowd. Walked fast, almost running. The police would find him. Interrogate him. Detain him, maybe.

But now he needed to leave. Think. Understand.

Ligature V.

Valeria Lehmann. Lehmann Valeria. The initials matched.

But what did it mean? Ligature — is a joining of letters. Typographic term. Or musical. Or... Or something completely different.

Victor turned into an alley. Leaned against the wall. Closed his eyes. His ears buzzed. In his head — emptiness. In his hands — trembling. Another dead man. Another riddle. Another step toward truth that didn't want to be found. The phone vibrated. Victor took it out, looked. SMS. Unfamiliar number.

“Run. Now. V.”

Victor put away the phone. Straightened up. Headed to the metro.

Run. Yes. He knew how to do that. Only run from what? From police? From killers? From truth? Or from himself?

46 The Casino

THE hotel was cheap. So cheap that the room smelled of the despair of previous guests, mixed with the aroma of disinfectant trying to hide traces of human existence. Victor collapsed onto the bed, hard as a bureaucrat's conscience. Closed his eyes. His head spun.

Behind closed eyelids, Leo's face surfaced — the calm that settled over it the moment breathing stopped, as if death had been not an enemy but a relief. The dark stains spreading on his shirt. The warmth of someone else's blood on Victor's palms, already cooling by the time the sirens started. He clenched his fists. Nails dug into skin. The image receded but didn't vanish; it settled somewhere behind his thoughts, like a watermark on paper you only see when you hold it to the light.

Ligature V. L. V. Lehmann Valeria.

He took off his jacket, threw it on the chair. The jacket slid to the floor with a dull thud. Too dull for an empty pocket.

Victor picked up the jacket. Put his hand in the pocket. Felt something cold, metallic, heavy.

Pulled it out.

A keychain. With a key.

The key was old. Lever lock, long, with a bit carved with notches and protrusions, like a map of mountainous terrain cast in bronze by a mad cartographer. The metal had darkened with time, covered in patina, noble as an aristocrat's gray hair. To the touch — rough, uneven, as if alive.

And the keychain... The keychain was strange.

Metal plate, coin-sized. Crude work, artisanal. As if a blacksmith had forged it in a cave, by firelight, cursing the obstinate metal. Edges uneven, surface — rough. On the plate — a symbol. Engraved or embossed, unclear.

Victor held the keychain up to the lamplight. Looked closely.

A letter. Or two letters. Looked like the Wolfsburg logo. W with crossed lines in the middle. But not quite.

He turned the keychain in his hands. Looked from a different angle.

And understood.

This wasn't W.

This was L and V.

L — tilted left. V — tilted right. Crossed in the middle. Forming something resembling the letter W. But these were two separate letters. Connected. Intertwined.

Ligature.

Ligature V. L. V.

Victor placed the key on the table. Sat. Stared at it.

Vincent Leo slipped this into his pocket. Before death. Or during the conversation at the casino. When? Doesn't matter. What matters — is why.

A key. To what? To a door? To a safe? To a box?

And the keychain. With the symbol LV. Valeria Lehmann.

There was a connection. Obvious. Glaring. But what did it mean?

Victor took out his phone. Scrolled through contacts. Stopped at the name: Misha.

Mikhail Borisovich Grechkin. Seventy-eight years old. Collector of antique locks. For a narrow circle of initiates — legendary safecracker who'd opened safes all across the Soviet Union in his time. Victor had interviewed him five years ago. For the magazine. The article was called "The Man Who Can Open Anything." Misha had laughed then, said it was a metaphor for his life.

Victor dialed the number. Long rings. Then a hoarse voice, smoke-cured and dried by time through and through:

"Hello."

"Mikhail Borisovich? This is Victor Latov. Do you remember me?"

Pause. Coughing.

"The journalist? Who wrote about locks?"

"Yes. I need your help."

"At this hour? Do you know what time it is?"

Victor looked at his watch. Two in the morning Moscow time. Damn.

"Sorry. This is urgent. Very."

Another pause. Then a sigh.

"Talk."

"I have a key. Old. Lever lock. I'll send a photo. Can you look? Tell me what it's from?"

"Send it."

Victor photographed the key. Sent it. Waited.

"Got it?"

"Let me see... Where are my glasses... Aha. I see." Misha paused. Long. So long that Victor was about to ask if he'd hung up. "Interesting. Very interesting. I need time. Dig through books. I'll call back in half an hour."

"Thank you, Mikhail Borisovich. I'll wait."

The call ended.

Victor lay on the bed. Closed his eyes. But sleep wouldn't come. In his head thoughts spun, colliding with each other like bumper cars in the kiddie pavilion at VDNKh.

Key. Vincent Leo. Murder. Valeria. Figure five. Ligature. Vichitov. Maimonides' letter. Christ's trial.

It was all connected. But how?

The phone rang. Victor grabbed it.

"Yes!"

"Latov?" Misha's voice sounded pleased, almost triumphant. "Never would have thought you were Jewish."

Victor sat up on the bed.

"What?"

"Your key. I identified it. Or rather, not the key itself, but the type. Saw ones like it in a museum. In Toledo. Spain. Heard of such a thing?"

"No. Tell me."

"In the late fifteenth century, when Isabella and Ferdinand expelled the Jews from Spain, many families left

taking keys from their homes with them. Like, we'll come back. Understand? Passed them down from generation to generation. Four hundred years, five hundred. Keys from houses that no longer exist."

Victor listened with bated breath.

"And what about this key?"

"Well, the Spanish government, or the Toledo city council, can't remember exactly, promised: whoever proves they have a key from their ancestors' house in the Jewish quarter — will be given the right to return. Symbolically, of course. Citizenship, benefits, all that. Most keys are in museums now. But some — with people. Your key — is one of those. I'm almost certain. Distinctive bit. Length. Thickness. This is a Toledo key. From a door in the old quarter. Sephardim made them like this."

"Mikhail Borisovich..." Victor didn't know what to say. "Thank you. Huge thanks."

"Don't mention it. Only tell me: where did you get such a thing? This is a relic. Family heirloom. They don't give these away just like that."

"Long story."

"Aha. I see." Misha paused. "Take care, Latov. If someone gave you such a key — means the matter's serious. Very."

"Understood. Thanks again."

Victor hung up. Looked at the key.

Toledo. House in the Jewish quarter. Fifteenth century. Expulsion of the Sephardim.

And Valeria. Who left the acrostic message. Presumably sent SMSes. And possibly hid a message in the initials on the keychain.

She was leading him there. To Toledo. To that house.

Why?

Victor opened his laptop. Went to the airline website. Flights Manchester — Madrid. Tomorrow morning. Seats available. Bought a ticket. Then — train or car to Toledo. Hour's drive.

Day after tomorrow he'd be there.

Victor took his phone. Dialed Vichitov's number. Long rings. Then a sleepy voice:

"Latov? What the hell? Three in the morning."

"Alexei Petrovich. Sorry. But I found a lead. Important one."

Pause. Then the voice became alert, interested:

"What lead?"

"Toledo. Jewish quarter. Need to search there. I'm flying to Madrid tomorrow."

"Where's the information from?"

"From a source. Reliable." Victor wasn't going to mention Vincent Leo, or the key, or the keychain. "Trust me. This is what we need."

"Toledo..." Vichitov paused. "Yes. One of the previous researchers was there. Found something but didn't have time to verify it. Then disappeared." Another pause. "All right. Go. Be careful. If you find anything — call immediately. I'll arrange help. Money, contacts, anything."

"Thanks."

"And Latov..." His voice became serious, almost threatening. "Don't you dare deceive me. If you find the document — it's mine. We agreed."

"We agreed."

Victor hung up. Put the phone on the table. Next to the key and keychain.

LV. Valeria Lehmann. What did you find there in Toledo? And why did you have to hide? And why do people die the moment they hear about figure five?

Victor stood. Went to the window. Outside — Manchester. Sleeping, dark, wet. Lights from occasional street-lamps trembled in rain puddles like stars fallen from the sky that couldn't find the way back.

Somewhere there, in this city, a man had just died. Because he knew too much. Or too little. Or just was in the wrong place at the wrong time.

Victor looked at his hands. On them still remained traces of blood. He wiped them on his jeans. Didn't help. The blood had soaked into his skin. Or into his memory. Or into his soul.

He returned to the bed. Lay down. Closed his eyes.

Tomorrow — Madrid. Day after tomorrow — Toledo. And there — what? A house that doesn't exist? A door that won't open? A secret better left unknown?

Or Valeria?

He fell asleep thinking of her. Of dancing under the clock at Alexanderplatz. Of the sea in Crete. Of the note in the bungalow. Of the SMSes that came and disappeared like ghosts in fog.

And he dreamed something strange, confused. Keys opening doors to nowhere. Statues without heads and arms. A letter written in a language he didn't know. And Valeria standing at the end of a long corridor, waving her hand, calling.

But when he came closer — she retreated. Further and further. Until she dissolved in the darkness.

47 Leo's Heritage

MORNING in Manchester was gray as a president's speech after elections. Victor woke early, packed, checked out of the hotel. The clerk looked at him suspiciously but asked nothing. In Manchester it's not customary to ask questions. Especially of those who leave early in the morning with a rumpled face and empty gaze.

The airport greeted him with familiar bustle. People hurried, dragged suitcases, looked at boards, checked tickets. Each — in their own world. In their own story. No one knew that standing nearby was a man with in his pocket — a key to a house that doesn't exist, in his head — a riddle that can't be solved, and in his heart — a woman who can't be found.

The plane took off on time. Victor sat by the window, looked down. Manchester shrank, transformed into a toy city, then into a spot on the map, then disappeared in clouds.

Somewhere there, below, police searched for Vincent Leo's killer. Interrogated witnesses. Collected evidence. And the killer already flew to Madrid.

No. Not killer. Witness. Accidental witness.

Who now knew what he shouldn't have known.

Ligature V. L. V.

Victor took the keychain from his pocket. Looked at the interwoven letters. Ran his finger over the uneven surface.

Valeria. Where are you? What did you find? And why can't you just call and say: "Vitya, come there, do this"?

Why these games? Anagrams, SMSes, keys, keychains?

Because dangerous. Because someone's watching. Because every word can be heard. Every action — noticed. Every step — tracked.

Victor put the keychain back in his pocket. Leaned back in his seat. Closed his eyes. In three hours he'd be in Madrid. Then — Toledo. Then — the door this key would open.

And behind the door — what?

Answer. Or death.

Or both.

The stewardess walked past offering drinks. Victor ordered whisky. Double. Drank it down. Didn't help. The anxiety remained. Sat inside like a stone in his stomach. Heavy, cold, unmovable.

He opened his eyes. Outside the window clouds drifted. White, fluffy, innocent. As if they didn't know that below people killed each other over old documents and ancient secrets.

Victor smirked. At himself. At his naivety. At his stupidity. He could have refused. Told Vichitov: "Sorry, not my thing." Returned to ordinary life. To articles about exhibitions and interviews with labradoodle breeders.

But didn't refuse. Because Valeria. Always Valeria. Too much Valeria.

A woman he'd known two days. Who disappeared leaving a note. Who now led him across all Europe like Ariadne's thread led Theseus. Except Theseus killed the Minotaur and came out of the labyrinth. And he, Victor, had about as much chance of that as a snowflake in hell.

The plane began descending. Victor looked out the window. Below appeared Madrid. Large, bright, spread out under the sun like a cat on a warm stone.

Spain. Country of inquisition and flamenco. Bull-fights and siestas. Cervantes and Dali.

And Toledo. City where once Christians, Muslims and Jews lived together. Until the kings came and decided that diversity — was bad.

Victor half-closed his eyes. Counted to ten. Opened them. Time. Wheels touched ground. The plane braked, rolled toward the terminal. Victor Latov arrived in Spain.

With a key to a house that doesn't exist.

And with hope to find a woman who shouldn't be.

48 Madrid

MADRID hit him with heat. The asphalt melted, turning into a viscous substance capable of holding anyone who dared walk on it at noon. of the airport and felt the air sear his lungs, as if he'd inhaled not oxygen but molten tin.

Still on the plane, between whisky and anxious thoughts about keys and dead poker players, he'd googled "Centro Sefarad-Israel." Address: Calle Mayor, 69. On the way to Atocha station. Perfect.

The taxi took him there in half an hour. The driver talked about football, about weather, about tourists who come and go understanding nothing about real Spain. Victor nodded, not listening. In his head spun: *LV. Ligate V. L. V. Toledo. House. Key.*

Centro Sefarad-Israel was housed in a brick building completely unsuited in design to what was inside. The building somehow resembled simultaneously a city hall and a prison. Brick, wrought iron ascetic balconies. Dark windows. Heavy door. Victor pushed it and entered.

Inside was cool. Quiet. Museum silence, saturated with respect for the past and fear of the future. Walls

hung with maps, photographs, manuscripts. Displays with explanations in three languages: Spanish, English, Hebrew.

Victor slowly walked through the hall.

Map of Iberia before the expulsion. Toledo, Córdoba, Granada, Seville — points marked with Stars of David. Centers of Jewish learning. Synagogues, schools, libraries.

Documents. Letters, contracts, court decisions. In Ladino, in Hebrew, in Arabic. Languages intertwined with each other like lovers' fingers.

Photographs of synagogues. Toledo: Santa María la Blanca. El Tránsito. White walls, carved ceilings, patterns resembling Arabic calligraphy. Christianity, Islam and Judaism merged in architecture like rivers at a mouth.

Victor stopped before a display devoted to the 1492 expulsion.

"March 31, 1492, King Ferdinand and Queen Isabella issued an edict: all Jews must leave Spain within four months or accept baptism. About 200,000 people left. Many took with them keys from their homes. These keys were passed down from generation to generation. Hope to return..."

Under the text — a photograph. Several keys laid out on velvet fabric. Long, old, similar to the one lying in Victor's pocket.

He ran his finger along the display glass. Cold. Impenetrable. Separating past from present with a thin but insurmountable barrier.

"¿Puedo ayudarte?" A voice behind him. Female. Soft.

Victor turned. Custodian. Elderly, with gray hair gathered in a bun. Kind eyes.

"I'm looking for information about Toledo," he said in English. "About the Jewish quarter. About houses left at the end of the fifteenth century."

The woman nodded.

"Toledo — is a special place. Jews lived there over a thousand years. Until expulsion. The quarter is called *Judería*. *Judería*. Now it's a tourist spot. But if you know where to look..." She fell silent, looked at him attentively. "Are you a researcher?"

"Something like that."

"Then you need a guide. In Toledo. Someone who knows not only the history for tourists, but the real one. Hidden."

"Where can I find such a guide?"

"At the tourist kiosk. Opposite the railway station. There works a girl who knows more about Jews in Toledo than they knew themselves. Tell her Miriam sent you."

Victor thanked her and left.

Atocha. Station built like a greenhouse. Palms inside. Turtles in the pond. Tourists with suitcases and bewildered faces.

Victor bought a ticket for the next train. In twenty minutes.

The train went fast, almost silently. Outside the window flashed fields scorched by sun to the color of old parchment. Villages clinging to hills like lichens to stone. Vineyards scattered across hills in terraces as if drawn by Escher.

49 Toledo Bound

And there was Toledo.

City over which time proved powerless. Walls, towers, church spires. Middle Ages. Or a careful reproduction of the Middle Ages — who knows? Victor got off the train. Crossed the road.

Tourist kiosk. Small, neat. In the window — brochures, maps, tour schedules. He entered. Behind the counter sat a guy. Young, bored. Buried in his phone.

“Good afternoon,” Victor said in English. “I’m looking for a private guide to Jewish heritage in Toledo.”

The guy looked up. Nodded.

“One moment.”

He stood, went into the adjacent room. From there came quiet conversation. Then appeared she.

Tall. Slender. Dark hair pulled back in a ponytail. Eyes brown, intelligent. Face serious but not stern. Dressed simply: jeans, white shirt, light jacket. No makeup. No jewelry.

Beautiful. But not with the beauty that asks for attention. The kind that doesn’t notice it.

“Buenos días. I’m Meritxell Garcia. You need a guide?”

Voice low, slightly husky. Catalan accent.

Victor smiled. With the most velvet smile he could manage after a sleepless night, two flights and airplane whisky.

“Yes. Personal guide. Jewish heritage. I can pay well.” For some reason he decided not to mention Miriam from Madrid. This was the same girl — there could be no doubt.

She nodded. Professionally. Without a hint that the smile had any effect on her.

"Fine. When do you want to start?"

"Now, if possible. But first — maybe we could sit somewhere? At a café? I need to explain exactly what I'm looking for."

The girl frowned. Barely noticeable. But Victor noticed.

"I don't think that's necessary. You can explain on the way."

She was already turning toward the door.

"Please," Victor said. "It's important. And I promise — today I'm too busy with Jewish heritage to flirt."

She stopped. Looked at him. Appraisingly. Then smiled, apparently appreciating Victor's determination.

"All right. But coffee to go. In the park there's a good bench. Five minutes."

They left. Found the nearest coffee shop. Got two espressos "para llevar." Sat on a bench under a tree giving shade, meager but better than nothing.

Meritxell drank coffee, looking at him. Waiting.

Victor took out the key. Handed it to her. The key-chain carefully detached still on the train rested in his pocket. She took the key. Turned it in her hands. Eyes widened.

"Dios mío... Where did you get this?"

"Is this what I think it is?"

She nodded. Slowly. Not taking her eyes from the key.

"This is a Sephardic key. Fifteenth century. Maybe even earlier. Look at the notches. Thickness. Patina. This... It's real." She looked at him. "Do you understand what this means? If this key is from Toledo, if it opens some door here... There are people who spend their

whole lives searching for such a key. Families who lost homes but kept memories. Historians. Collectors."

She fell silent. Then looked at the key again. Ran her finger over the bit.

"There are records. In archives. Lists of houses. Owners. Addresses. If I compare the key with the records... I can find the house. Maybe. If it still exists."

"Can you do this?"

"Yes. But..." She looked at him again. "Where the hell did you get it?"

Victor didn't answer. Instead he put his hand in his pocket and pulled out the keychain.

Meritxell froze. Mouth fell open. Eyes stared at the metal plate with the engraved ligature.

"What... What is this?"

"You tell me."

She took the keychain. Brought it to her eyes. Studied it long. Very long. Then looked up.

"This... I think... No, it can't be."

"What can't be?"

She placed the keychain on her palm. Showed it to him.

"There's a legend. About an Order. Knights. They called themselves "Lex Vicit." "Law conquered." Some say they were Templars. Others — that they were Jews who accepted baptism but secretly kept their faith. Still others — that it was something completely different. A secret society. Keepers of knowledge."

Victor nodded as if she were reading him a restaurant menu.

"According to urban legend, they maintained a library. Hidden. Full of documents that were too dangerous for the public. Legal texts. Religious texts. Political texts. Things that could change history if they became available to the wider public."

"Does this library exist?"

Meritxell shook her head.

"Nobody knows. There's no proof. Not a single document mentioning the Order by name. Not a single building. Not one identified member. Only rumors. Stories passed from generation to generation. Freemasons — by comparison — are a publicly traded company."

"But?"

"But..." She looked at the keychain again. "There are rumors about their coat of arms. Scroll and quill. Framed by twelve symbols. Like this one." She ran her finger over the ligature. "Twelve keepers. Twelve keys. Twelve symbols."

Victor felt the hair on the back of his neck stand up.

Twelve statues. Figures from one to twelve. Vichitov.

"Do you know where the library might be located?"

"No. But I know who might know."

"Who?"

"Professor Vals. Ernesto Vals. He teaches at the University of Castilla-La Mancha. Medieval history. Secret societies. Conspiracy theories." She smiled. "Most historians consider him insane. But he knows more about Toledo's hidden history than anyone."

"Can you contact him?"

"I can try. He's... difficult. Doesn't like strangers. Trusts no one. But if I tell him about this..." She held up the keychain. "He might agree to meet with you."

"When?"

"I'll call him now. If he's free — maybe this afternoon. Can you meet me here? At this café? Around five?"

"Yes."

Meritxell stood. Handed him the key and keychain. Victor took them, hid them in his pocket.

"Don't lose them," she said seriously. "If what I think is true... They're worth more than you can imagine."

"I won't lose them. And I'm not here for money" Victor lied, but didn't lie in spirit.

She nodded and left. With quick, confident steps. Without looking back. Her hair pulled back in a pony-tail bounced cheerfully as she walked.

Victor found a hotel. Cheap but clean. Windows opened onto a narrow street where the cobblestones were so old they still remembered Roman sandals.

He went up to the room. Got out his laptop. Opened the browser.

"Lex Vicit."

Nothing.

"Knights Lexer."

Nothing.

"Secret library Toledo."

Hundreds of links. All — about the Alcázar, about synagogues, about public archives. Nothing about secret Orders and hidden libraries. He tried searching for images. "Coat of arms scroll quill twelve symbols." Thousands of results. But none matched.

Victor closed the laptop. Lay on the bed. Closed his eyes. His head spun.

Lex Vicit. Vichitov. Alexei Petrovich Vichitov. Lex Vicit gold mining company. Coincidence? Or not?

Twelve statues. Twelve keepers. Twelve symbols. Figure five — Valeria. LV. Ligature V.

Keys. Library. Documents. Maimonides' letter. Christ's trial. A chain leading through the centuries. From Pontius Pilate to Toledo. From Toledo to Moscow. From Moscow to him, Victor Latov, journalist who can't say no to women with sad eyes.

He smiled. Bitterly.

Somewhere there, in this city, a library was hidden. leading to the door. Or maybe there was nothing. Maybe it was all legends. Fantasies. Games of imagination.

But then why did Vincent Leo die? Why did Valeria disappear? Why did Lipkin in prison shake with fear hearing the words "Figure five"?

No. There's something. Something people are willing to kill for. And die for.

Victor opened his eyes. Looked at the ceiling. Cracks in the plaster resembled a map. Or a labyrinth. Or veins on an old man's wrist who'd waited too long for death.

He closed his eyes again.

Dozed off.

And again he dreamed of Valeria. But now she wasn't standing in a corridor. She stood in a library. Surrounded by shelves. Full of books. Old, decaying. She reached for one of them. Pulled it out. Opened it.

And instead of pages — ashes. Spilled onto the floor. Black, light. Vanishing.

Valeria looked at him. And her lips moved. Saying something. But Victor couldn't hear. Couldn't hear.

And she dissolved. In ash. In darkness. In oblivion. Or was it just fog?

50 The Key

AT five o'clock Victor returned to the café. Meritxell was already waiting. There was a man with her. About sixty, thin, stooped. Thick-framed glasses. Gray hair, disheveled as if combed by wind that forgot its duties. Dressed carelessly: wrinkled trousers, untucked shirt, denim jacket with patches on the elbows. Looked like — a typical university professor who spent more time in libraries than in the real world.

Meritxell nodded to Victor. Introduced:

"Professor Vals. Ernesto Vals. He agreed to meet with you."

The professor extended his hand. Weak handshake, uncertain. Palm damp. Gaze somewhere to the side, over his interlocutor — like someone who's used to being afraid.

"*Buenos días*," he said quietly. "Meritxell says you have something interesting for me."

"Yes," Victor replied. "Very interesting."

They sat at a table. Meritxell ordered three espressos. The professor fidgeted in his chair, adjusted his glasses, drummed his fingers on the tabletop. Nervous. Too demonstratively nervous.

Victor took out the key. Placed it on the table.

The professor leaned in. Studied it long. Very long. Then straightened. Shook his head.

"Ordinary key. Sephardic. Fifteenth, maybe sixteenth century. There are hundreds. Thousands. In museums, in private collections, with descendants." He looked at Victor. "You came to Toledo because of this?"

Victor didn't answer. Instead he took out the key-chain. Placed it next to the key.

The professor froze.

Then grabbed the keychain. Brought it to his eyes. Mouth fell open. Hands trembled.

"Dios santo... Dios santo..."

He jumped up from his chair. Keychain clenched in his fist. Began pacing around the table. Fast. In circles. Muttering something in Spanish. Meritxell watched him with alarm.

"Professor..." she began.

But he wasn't listening. Paced. In circles. Then stopped. Stared at Victor.

"¿Dónde... dónde lo conseguiste?" Voice trembling. "Where did you get this?"

Victor leaned back in his chair. Crossed his arms on his chest. Smiled. Not the friendliest smile, but not the grimace he saved for special occasions like the Last Judgment.

"I'll tell you. But first you explain to me what's so special about this thing that you're jumping like a wind-up rabbit on springs."

The professor sat back down. Put the keychain on the table. Didn't take his eyes off it.

"Do you know what this is?" he asked quietly.

"Roughly."

"Then you understand. This... this is what historians have been searching for centuries. Proof. Of the Order's existence."

Victor nodded.

"Meritxell told me the legend. 'Lex Vicit.' Secret library. Twelve keepers. But legends — are legends. And this — is a physical object. With initials."

The professor removed his glasses. Wiped them on his shirt edge. Put them back on.

"You're right. Legends — are legends. But sometimes they're based on reality."

He took the keychain again. Ran his finger over the ligature. —

"All supposed members of the Order who were at least mentioned in chronicles, documents, letters... All had the initials L and V. Or V and L. In any order. León Valdés. Víctor López. Laura Venegas. Valeriano Luna."

Victor felt something lurch inside.

Valeria Lehmann. V. L.

"Coincidence?" he asked, trying to keep his voice steady.

The professor shook his head.

"No. Not coincidence. It was a rule. One of the twelve commandments of the Order. The first twelve knights, the founding fathers, drew the coat of arms and established rules. Among them "Members of the Order must have the initials L and V."

"Why?"

"Lex Vicit. Law conquered. L and V. Symbol. Reminder of the Order's purpose."

He put the keychain back on the table.

"The other rules were practical. Don't kill — no, that wasn't there. That's stupid, right? Sometimes you have to kill. To protect knowledge. To preserve the secret."

He smiled. Sadly.

"But there were others. Keep the documents. Don't reveal sources. Obey the twelve judges. Pass knowledge to your successor."

"Judges?" Victor asked.

"That's what they called the council. Twelve judges. Always twelve. If one died — they chose a new one."

The Order existed continuously. Since the thirteenth century. Maybe earlier. To our days."

Meritxell interjected:

"Are you serious? You're saying the Order exists now?"

The professor nodded.

"Yes. I'm certain. Of course, they don't advertise themselves. Don't gather in squares. Don't wear cloaks with coats of arms. Don't buy TV ads. But they exist. From a thousand to ten thousand members. Constantly. All over the world."

"And the library?"

"The library... possibly. I don't know where. Nobody knows. But if the Order exists, then the library exists."

He looked at Victor.

"And now... now something strange is happening."

"What exactly?"

"Rumors. Whispers. In academic circles. Among those interested in this. They say the twelve judges have problems. Schism. Conflict. Someone died. Someone disappeared. Someone betrayed. Time of troubles."

He leaned closer.

"Do you understand what this means? If the Order is truly in crisis... if the twelve can't agree... then the library is threatened. Documents could be destroyed. Or stolen. Or sold."

Victor was silent. Things were adding up in his head.

Vichitov. Lex Vicit gold mining company. Twelve statues. Figure five. Valeria. Vincent Leo. V. L. Lipkin. Vladimir Lipkin. V. L.

Everything's connected. All part of one thing.

"Professor," he said slowly. "You said the Order consists of thousands of members. How do they choose new ones? If the rule requires initials L and V?"

"Not everyone with such initials becomes a member. Of course not. But the Order searches. Watches. If someone fits — they invite them. Test them. Try them. And if they pass — they accept them." The professor took the keychain again. "And this... this is a symbol of belonging. Order members wear these. Discreetly. On chains. On bracelets. On keychains. As a sign. As a pass."

"And the judges? Do they have these too?"

"The judges — yes. But not like these. Theirs are more complex. With additional symbols. Indicating their rank."

He handed the keychain to Victor.

"This one is ordinary. Rank-and-file member. Not a judge."

Victor took the keychain. Hid it in his pocket.

"Now it's your turn," the professor said. "Where did you get this?"

Victor thought. How much to say? What to keep quiet?

Decided on a compromise.

"A man hired me. In Moscow. Businessman. Alexei Vichitov. Company "Lex Vicit." He collects antiquities. Looking for documents connected to Maimonides' 1169 letter. Believes there's a chain of documents leading to the transcript of Christ's trial."

The professor nodded slowly.

"Yes. I've heard this theory. Many believe in it. The chain. Each document contains a key to the next. Maimonides' letter — one of the links."

"Vichitov asked me to find this letter. Or at least a trail. I started investigating. Found people. One of them — Vincent Leo. Professional poker player. Italian. Lived in Manchester." Victor paused. "He's dead. Murdered. Before death he gave me the key and key-chain."

Meritxell gasped.

"Murdered? You were there?"

"Yes."

The professor paled.

"So it's true. Time of troubles. The Order attacks itself. Devours its own tail like an ouroboros."

He looked at Victor seriously.

"You're in danger. If they find out you have this... they'll come for you."

"Who... are they?"

"I don't know. One of the factions. Judges. Or those against the judges. Or those who want to destroy the Order."

He stood.

"You need to be careful. Very."

Victor stood too. Extended his hand.

"Thank you, professor. For the information. For your honesty."

They shook hands. Victor reached into his pocket. Took out the key. Handed it to Ernesto.

"Take it. For your collection. Or for a museum. As you like."

The professor took the key. Eyes moistened.

"Are you sure? This... this is valuable."

"I'm sure. I don't need it. And you — will find use for it. Maybe you'll open some door with it. Into the past."

Ernesto smiled. For the first time in the entire conversation.

"*Gracias. Muchas gracias.*" He gripped the key in his fist. "Be careful, señor Latov. And if you learn anything... call me. Meritxell will give you my number."

"I will."

They said their goodbyes. Meritxell hugged Victor. Quick. Friendly.

"Good luck," she whispered. "And really, be careful."

"I'll try."

Victor returned to his hotel. Packed. Checked out. The desk clerk asked if everything had been satisfactory. Victor nodded. Lied that everything was wonderful.

Wonderful. I learned about a secret Order that's existed for a thousand years. About a library that no one can find. About twelve judges who are possibly at war with each other. And the man who gave me this keychain was murdered before my eyes. Yes, everything's just fucking wonderful.

He took the train to Madrid. The train hurtled through night. Outside the window — darkness, occasionally broken by village lights. Victor stared at his reflection in the glass. A tired face. Eyes red from lack of sleep. Stubble that needed shaving.

What am I doing? Why did I get into this?

Because of Valeria. Always because of her.

But where is she? And how is she connected to all this? V. L. Valeria Lehmann. Order member? Possibly. Judge? Unlikely. Then what? Victim? Fugitive? Spy?

And Vichitov. Alexei Petrovich. A. V. No, wrong initials. But the company — "Lex Vicit." Coincidence? Or does he know more than he's saying?

Twelve statues. Twelve judges. Figure Five — headless and armless. Symbol of what? Silence? Helplessness? Or something else?

His head was splitting. Victor closed his eyes. Tried to sleep. Couldn't.

In Madrid he took a taxi to the airport. Bought a ticket for the next flight to Moscow. Two hours. He spent the wait in the bar. Ordered whisky. Double. Then another.

What to tell Vichitov? The truth? Part of the truth? Lies?

"Alexei Petrovich, I found a key that opens nothing. But I learned that there's a secret Order, which you might belong to. Or your enemies. Or your friends. And there was a woman I fell in love with in Crete, and she seems to be a member of this Order. But she disappeared. And I don't know if she's alive. Or what I should do now."

Yes, sounds convincing. He'll thank me, write me a check and forget about me.

Victor finished his whisky. Looked at the keychain lying on the bar.

LV. Ligature. Twelve keepers. Twelve commandments.

"Order members must have the initials L and V."

Valeria. Vincent. Vladimir. All of them. All part of this.

And me? Victor Latov. V. L. I fit too. Like that damned Liels who cooked up this whole mess.

Victor smiled bitterly.

Maybe they'll invite me too? Give me a cloak, a secret keychain and access to the library? No, of course not.

I'm — nobody. A journalist. Who writes articles about exhibitions and interviews steel mill directors.

Who was used. Like a pawn. Like a tool.

And who doesn't know what to do next.

They announced boarding. Victor stood. Walked to his gate. On the plane he found his seat. Window. Leaned back. Closed his eyes.

Only then, in the silence of the plane waiting for takeoff, did he allow himself to think about her.

About Valeria. About how she laughed on the beach. About how she danced in Berlin. About how she looked at him in the bungalow, before disappearing.

Where are you, Valeria? What happened to you? And why can't you just call and say: "Vitya, everything's fine"?

Because it's not fine. Obviously. If it were fine, she wouldn't have disappeared. Wouldn't have left that apostil, acrostic, au revoir. Wouldn't have made me chase across Europe after keys and keychains.

The Order in crisis. Time of troubles. Twelve judges at war. And Valeria — somewhere in the middle. Or on one side. Or...

Or dead.

The thought hit like a fist to the gut. Victor opened his eyes. Looked out the window. Madrid's lights below, like scattered diamonds on black velvet.

No. She's not dead. Can't be. She's too smart. Too careful.

She's alive. Somewhere out there. Waiting for me to find her.

Or waiting for me to stop looking.

The plane took off. Victor watched Spain shrink, become a map, then disappear into clouds.

Ahead — Moscow. Vichitov. Questions with no answers. And decisions he'd have to make.

No way back now. Only forward. Into darkness. To the center. To whatever end waits there.

Victor closed his eyes. Dozed off. He dreamed a strange, tangled dream, like a ball of snakes. Twelve faceless figures standing in a circle. Holding hands. In the center — a scroll. Burning. Ash rising up, turning into letters. Interwoven L and V. Dancing in the air. Dancing on Alexanderplatz.

And beyond the circle, in shadow, stands she. Valeria. Silent. Watching. And her lips move. Saying something. But he can't hear. Can't hear.

And the figures begin to move. Slowly. In a circle. A ritual dance of figures. The scroll keeps burning. Turning to ash. Disappearing. Victor understands: he's late. Too late. Too slow. Everything's already over. Or about to be over. And he can do nothing. Only watch. As everything collapses. As everything vanishes.

In ash. In darkness. In oblivion.

51 Back to Moscow

Moscow offered Victor nothing but rain. Not summer rain, warm, passing, but October, cold, biting. cold, biting. The kind that soaks you through while you're running from plane to terminal, though the distance — maybe ten meters. The sky hung low, gray as a bedsheet in a cheap motel. Wind whipped the flags above the airport building, like a dissatisfied critic — the manuscript of a talentless novelist.

Victor took a taxi. The driver was silent — God bless him for that. At home Victor immediately went to the

phone. Dialed Liels' number. Long rings. Then — a voice:

"Yes."

"It's Latov."

A pause."

"Vitya?" Liels spoke cautiously, like a sapper defusing a bomb. "Where are you calling from?"

"From Toledo." for an unknown reason lied Victor. "Valya, I need to know something. You know about *Lex Vicit*?"

Silence on the other end. Long. Too long.

"I know," Liels finally answered.

"Talk."

"On the phone?"

"On the phone. Or come over, we'll discuss it in person. But be warned, I'm very angry."

Another pause.

"Vitya, I can't on the phone. It's... complicated."

"Then two questions. Fast. Are there judges in Russia?"

"There are. Or rather — were. We tried to find out who exactly. Didn't work out."

"Who's Vichitov? Alexei Vichitov?"

"Don't know. Really don't. I've heard the name, but nothing concrete."

"Where's Valeria?"

"Don't know."

Victor felt something inside tear. Or contract. Or die.

"Valya, if you're lying — I swear, I'll find you and kick you in the balls so hard you won't have offspring to the seventh generation."

Liels didn't laugh. His voice was serious, almost sad.

"Vitya, I'm not lying. I really don't know. We looked. Still looking. She disappeared. Completely. No traces."

"Why did you drag me into this?"

"Because... because you fit. By initials. By mind. By character." He paused. "And because she liked you."

"Fuck off."

Victor slammed down the phone. Stood in the middle of the room. Hands shaking. A lump in his throat — the size of a fist.

Fit by initials. So Liels is in on it. So he knows about the Order. So he's — part of all this.

And I'm — a fool. Who was used. Again.

Victor went to the table. Pulled out the folder with photocopies that Vichitov had given him. Maimonides' 1169 letter. An appeal to collect money to ransom Jews captured by crusaders. Text in Hebrew. English translation made by one of the previous researchers.

Victor spread the sheets on the table. Turned on the desk lamp. Sat. Stared.

"Each document contains the key to the next." Professor Vals said that. Vichitov believed it. Vincent Leo died for it.

So there's something here. Encrypted. Hidden.

But what? And how to see it?

He read the text. Again and again. Looked for patterns. Repetitions. Anomalies. Nothing.

Took a magnifying glass from the desk drawer. Examined letters. Spacing. Lines. Nothing.

An hour passed. Then a second. His eyes watered. Victor stood, made coffee. Drank it in one gulp, burned himself. Returned to the table.

Read. Peered. Lost focus. Saw blurred spots instead of letters.

And suddenly.

The letters. They weren't quite even. Some slightly higher. Some — lower. Distances between words — different. Line spacing — too.

Could be chance. Hand trembled after a hard day. Or he had arthritis. Or he was drunk.

Or not.

Victor grabbed his phone. Photographed the page. Opened it on screen. Zoomed in. Out. Rotated. Changed contrast. Brightness.

And saw.

Lines. Barely visible. Connecting the tops of certain letters. Forming a pattern. Symmetrical. Repeating.

Victor jumped up. Ran to the computer. Downloaded the photo. Opened it in an image editor. Cranked contrast to maximum. Traced the lines with marker. Erased everything else.

And on the screen appeared a drawing.

A coat of arms.

In the center — a scroll and quill. Around it, like wheel spokes — twelve symbols. Ligatures. LV. Interwoven. Repeating.

And inside the scroll — text. Tiny. Barely distinguishable even at maximum magnification.

Victor leaned toward the screen. Squinted. Letters swam. Blurred. Formed into words. Fell apart again.

Half an hour passed. An hour. His eyes burned like coals in a brazier. Victor blinked, rubbed them with fists, drank water. Returned to the screen.

And gradually, letter by letter, word by word, the text revealed itself.

Testimonium Caiphae. Palatium Sancti Iacobi. Compostellae. Sub altare dextro.

Victor leaned back in his chair. Closed his eyes. Caught his breath.

“Testimonium Caiphae.” Testimony of Caiaphas. Caiaphas — the high priest. The very one who according to our information determined Christ’s fate. High Priest of the Temple. Pilate’s Alfred Beria Rosenberg.

“Palatium Sancti Iacobi.” Palace of Saint James. But not a palace. A cathedral. The cathedral in Santiago de Compostela.

“Sub altare dextro.” Under the altar, on the right.

Victor opened his eyes. Looked at the screen. The coat of arms. Twelve ligatures. Scroll with text.

The next link in the chain. A document hidden in Santiago de Compostela cathedral. Under the altar.

Testimony of Caiaphas. About Christ’s trial.

If this is true... if the document exists... it will overturn history. Christianity. Everything.

Victor stood. Went to the window. Outside — Moscow. Rain. Gray sky. Lights flickering, like candles in a church.

What am I doing? Why do I need this? I’m — a journalist. Not a treasure hunter. Not Indiana Jones.

But on the other hand...

Valeria got into this. Deep. Maybe she was looking for the same thing. Maybe she found it. Maybe that’s why she disappeared.

If I find the document — I’ll find her. Or at least learn what happened to her.

He returned to the table. Placed the keychain next to the screen. LV ligature. Same as on the coat of arms.

Vincent Leo gave me this. Before death. Why?

So I'd continue. So I'd find. So I wouldn't stop.

Or so I'd be killed, like they killed him.

Victor smiled. Bitterly. Tiredly.

Theseus, goddamn it. Ariadne, mother of God. Minotaur. Only the Minotaur's — not alone. There are twelve. Judges. Warring with each other. And I'm — in the middle. With a thread that's long since broken.

But I have to go. Forward. Into darkness. Because there's no going back.

He saved the file. Copied it to a flash drive. Shut down the computer. Looked at the clock. Three-thirty in the morning.

Santiago de Compostela. Spain. Spain again.

Galiccia. Way of Saint James. Pilgrims. Cathedral. Apostle's relics.

And under the right altar — a document almost two thousand years old.

If it's there. If they haven't found it. If they haven't destroyed it.

If. If. If.

Victor lay on the couch. Fully dressed. Closed his eyes. Keychain clenched in his fist. Sharp edges digging into his palm. Painful. But somehow calming.

Tomorrow morning I'll call Vichitov. Say I found the trail. I'll convince him that I can handle it myself, and I don't need escorts on this pilgrimage.

And then — to Spain. Second time in a week. Like I'm registered there.

Maybe should've just bought an apartment in Madrid. Would've been cheaper.

He smiled in the darkness. At himself. At his fate. At his idiocy.

"Your initials fit." Thanks, mom and dad. Had you named me John Doe — maybe I'd be living peacefully now. Writing articles about exhibitions. Drinking beer with Dimka. Not chasing across Europe after ghosts and secrets.

But no. Victor Latov. V. L. Perfect candidate for a secret Order existing a couple thousand years.

Irony of fate. Or mockery.

Sleep crept up unnoticed. Victor fell into it like into a well. Deep, dark, bottomless.

Of course he dreamed of the sea. Crete. Beach. Valeria in a white dress. Laughing. Waving. Calling. He walks toward her. Sand hot, burning his feet. Sun blinds his eyes. But he walks. Because she's there. Waiting. Then the sand turns to ash. Black, light. Gives way underfoot. Valeria recedes. Farther. Farther. He shouts. She doesn't hear. Or doesn't want to hear.

The familiar circle of faceless figures closed around him again. The burning scroll. The dancing letters. But this time Victor didn't watch — he walked forward, into the ash, toward the place where she had been, and found nothing.

52 Reminiscences

WAKING UP in Moscow after spending a week bouncing around Europe — pleasant, but unexpected. The city greets you with gray sky, damp wind and a general sense that you've returned not home, but to the dressing room of a provincial theater after the premiere of a play nobody needs.

Victor opened his eyes. Looked at the ceiling. The crack above the bed had gotten longer. Or he just hadn't noticed it before. Either way, should patch it or something. Victor laughed at his own pedantry and decided

he'd definitely deal with the crack — right after he overturns the canons of several world religions and saves Valeria.

The clock showed nine-thirty. Outside — noise of cars, shouts of market vendors, a dog barking. Ordinary Moscow symphony. Not Tchaikovsky, of course, but Schnittke would've liked it.

Victor got up. Poured himself water from the tap. Drank. Cold, tasteless, with a hint of rust. But his own.

So. Santiago de Compostela. Cathedral. Altar, on the right. A document almost two thousand years old.

Question: how to get in without attracting attention?

Answer: no way. The cathedral — one of Christianity's main pilgrimage sites. Crowds of tourists. Security. Cameras. Priests who don't doze off.

If I just go there and start digging under the altar — in five minutes I'll be in the local police station. With subsequent deportation and blacklisting as an undesirable element.

Victor paced the room. Turned on the kettle. Got a jar of instant coffee from the cupboard. Looked at it with disgust. Scooped three spoons.

So I need legal access. Or at least a pretext.

Pilgrims. Way of Saint James. Camino de Santiago. People walk there for months. On foot. From France through the Pyrenees. Eight hundred kilometers. Get some certificate at the end. A pilgrim's credential. Compostela.

Plus — access. To parts of the cathedral regular tourists don't get into. Right to attend masses. Privileges. Attention from priests.

But I don't have time to walk eight hundred kilometers. Or the desire, honestly.

The kettle boiled. Victor poured boiling water over the coffee. Stirred. Took a sip. Burned himself. Cursed.

But I can do the last stage. From Lugo or somewhere nearby. A hundred kilometers. A few days. Get the same compostela. Become a pilgrim.

Only it'll look suspicious. Suddenly appeared, walked a hundred kilometers, got the certificate. Fake on top of fake.

Though who cares? There are thousands of pilgrims. Every day. Nobody checks where you came from or why. The main thing's — stamps. In the special pilgrim passport. They stamp them in hostels along the way. Albergue. More stamps — more convincing.

Victor sat at the table. Opened his laptop. Googled 'Camino de Santiago last 100 km'.

Results — a million. Blogs of happy pilgrims. Forums. Maps. Advice on avoiding blisters. Hostel lists. Recommendations for backpacks and shoes.

Good God. I'm turning into a tourist. Little more — and I'll start photographing food for Instagram.

He scrolled through several articles. Found information. Aha. The last hundred kilometers start in Sarria. Or you can start from Lugo — about a hundred twenty there, but more interesting city.

Lugo. Roman wall. Old town. Hostels for pilgrims.

Good. So here's the plan. Fly to La Coruña. From there bus to Lugo. Day of rest. Then — on foot to Santiago. Three-four days. Get compostela. Enter cathedral as pilgrim. Look around. Search for opportunity.

The plan's idiotic. Chances of success — about like a snowman in a sauna. But there's no other.

Victor closed the laptop. Finished the cold coffee. Took his phone. Dialed Vichitov's number.

Long rings. Then a voice, cheerful, energetic:

"Latov! What news?"

"Alexei Petrovich, I found the trail. The next link in the chain. Need to go to Spain. To Galicia."

"To Galicia? What for?"

"A document's hidden there. The one indicated in Maimonides' letter. I deciphered the code."

Pause. Heavy breathing on the other end.

"You're sure?"

"As sure as one can be looking at an eight-hundred-year-old manuscript."

"Good. How much money do you need?"

"Don't know. Two weeks maybe. Maybe more. I also need to look at something. At your office. Your collection."

"Again? What for?"

"Check a hunch. Can I come today?"

Another pause.

"Fine. Come after lunch. Around three. I'll meet you."

"Thanks."

Victor hung up. Looked at the keychain lying on the table. LV ligature. Interwoven. Ancient. Dangerous.

Figure Five. Headless and armless. Torso. Greece, fourth century BC.

Something's not right there. Something I saw but didn't understand. Need to look again.

Lex Vicit office greeted him with the same marble coolness. Same secretary. Wait time, however, reduced this time to a minute and a half. Victor killed time leafing through magazines about gold mining. Reading them was about as fascinating as a washing machine instruction manual.

Vichitov appeared. Same huge, bald, with tattooed arms. Smiling. Hospitably, but warily.

"Latov! Come in, come in. Want coffee?"

"No thanks. Already exceeded my quota for today."

They walked down the corridor. Vichitov talked about something—weather, dollar rate, new well in Magadan. Victor nodded, not listening.

The museum. Twelve statues. Figures one through twelve. White marble. Silent. Ancient.

Victor slowly circled the hall. Stopped at each figure. Studied. Pretended to be interested.

Figure one. Youth's head. Roman work. Second century AD.

Figure two. Hand holding a scroll. Greece. Hellenistic period.

Figure three. Athlete's torso. Muscular, perfect proportions.

Victor reached the fifth. Stopped.

A torso. No head. No arms. No legs below the knees. Just a body. Female, judging by the curves. The marble darkened with time. Patina. Traces of restoration.

What's wrong here?

He circled the statue. Looked from the side. From behind. Front again.

Strange proportions. Shoulders too narrow. Waist — wide. Hips — wrong shape.

Or... or this isn't a female torso.

It's a child's.

The thought flashed like lightning. And immediately went out. Victor tried to catch it, hold it. Couldn't.

Child's torso. A child. Boy or girl — can't tell. About ten, maybe twelve.

But why? What does this have to do with Valeria? With the Order? With the library?

"Latov, why are you staring so hard?" Vichitov stood behind him. Voice mocking. "Fallen in love with antiquity?"

Victor turned. Smiled.

"Just thinking. Beautiful work. Shame it didn't survive intact."

"Yeah. Time's — a bastard. Destroys everything." Vichitov came closer. "By the way, why are you dressed like that?"

Victor looked at himself. Jeans. Trekking boots. Light jacket. Backpack on his back.

"What's wrong?"

"You look like a tourist. Or a scout. Going hiking?"

"More or less. I decided to become a pilgrim."

Vichitov stared at him.

"A pilgrim?"

"Exactly. To get to the document, I need access to the cathedral. As a pilgrim I'll get more opportunities. Less suspicion."

Vichitov slowly nodded.

"Smart. Unexpected, but smart." He smirked. "Only you don't look like a believer."

"Who does nowadays? Half the pilgrims go there not for God, but for impressions. Or photos for social media. I'll just be one of them."

"Fine. Good luck. And remember — if you find the document, it's mine."

"I remember."

Victor said goodbye and left.

53 Galicia

The Moscow — La Coruña flight had a layover in Madrid. Victor spent eight hours in planes and airports. Read, slept, drank coffee. Thought about Valeria. About the keychain. About Figure Five.

Child's torso. What could it mean?

Child. Innocence. Victim. Or... or something else.

Twelve figures. Twelve judges. Each figure — a symbol?

Then the fifth — symbol of what? Silence? Helplessness? Lostness?

Or Valeria? V. L. Fifth.

Damn. I'm going crazy. Looking for connections where there are none. Like a paranoid who sees conspiracies in bus numbers.

Rain hung over La Coruña like a threadbare curtain. Fine, tedious, Atlantic. The kind an umbrella doesn't help against. You get wet not from outside, but from inside — from melancholy and hopelessness.

Victor took a taxi to the bus station. Bought a ticket for the next bus to Lugo. In an hour. Spent time in a café, sipping "café solo" and watching the locals.

Galicians are very special people. Not quite Spanish. Closer to Celts, maybe. Severe faces, pensive. They speak quietly, in their dialect resembling Portuguese. Look from under brows, but not aggressively. Just assessing. Friend or stranger.

The bus took over an hour. Victor sat by the window, watched the landscape. Green hills. Eucalyptus groves. Stone houses with slate roofs. Small villages clinging to the road like burs to pants.

The end of the world. Finisterra. Once the Romans thought that beyond — was only ocean and emptiness. Wrong, of course. But the feeling remains.

Lugo appeared suddenly. A city on a hill, surrounded by a wall. Not metaphorical, but real. Roman. Two millennia standing, and none the worse for it.

Victor got off the bus. Found a hostel for pilgrims. Cheap, clean, half-empty. Signed his name in the book. Got a bunk in a shared room. Bunk bed, creaky as a nagging wife's voice. But his own.

Dropped his backpack. Washed up. Went outside.

Evening was falling. The sun was setting somewhere beyond the ocean, painting the sky in shades of russet and lilac. The city sank into twilight. Streetlights came on one after another, like candles on a birthday cake for an ancient old man.

Victor walked to the wall.

The Roman wall of Lugo — one of three fully preserved Roman fortifications in the world. Built in the second century AD, under emperor Trajan. Or a bit later — historians argue. More than two kilometers long. Ten-twelve meters high. About four meters thick.

Once it defended the city from barbarians. Then — from Moors. Then — it just stood, because tearing it down was a pity. Or lazy. In the nineteenth century they wanted to demolish it — needed to expand the city. But some official turned out smarter than the others and forbade it. Now the wall — is a UNESCO World Heritage site. Pride of Lugo. Tourist attraction.

Victor climbed the steps to the top of the wall. The path on top was wide, paved with stone. You could walk around. Locals run here in the mornings. Tourists stroll. Lovers kiss at sunset.

He walked slowly. Looked at the city below. Narrow streets. Stone houses. Churches with bell towers. Squares lit by dim lanterns. Somewhere music was playing. Guitar. Spanish, melancholy.

Trajan. Roman Empire. Legions. Conquest of Galicia.

Soldiers built this wall. Hauled stones. Mixed mortar. Laid block after block. For years. In any weather. In rain, in wind. Died of diseases. From accidents. Buried right here, behind the wall.

And now tourists walk on their work. Take selfies. Not thinking that underfoot — two thousand years of history.

Though, who am I to judge them. I walk in others' footsteps myself. Search for others' secrets. Hope to find what another lost.

Victor stopped. Looked west. There, beyond the horizon — the ocean. And even farther — America. The New World.

Tomorrow I'll start the journey. A hundred twenty kilometers to Santiago. Three days, maybe four. I'll walk, as thousands walked before me. Pilgrims. Seekers. Sinners and saints.

Only they were seeking God. Or forgiveness. Or meaning.

And I'm seeking a woman I saw for three days. And a document two thousand years old.

Who's crazier — a big question.

It got completely dark. The city below lit up with lights. Yellow, warm, cozy. Victor stood a while longer. Then descended from the wall. Went to the hostel.

In the common room people were already sleeping. Three pilgrims. Snoring out of sync, like a jazz band without a conductor. Victor lay on his bunk. Covered himself with a thin blanket. Closed his eyes.

Testimonium Caiaphae. Testimony of Caiaphas. Under the altar. Right side.

If it's there. If they haven't found it. If I'm not too late.

Good night, Victor. Tomorrow — you'll wake up a pilgrim.

Idiot with a backpack, searching for what might not exist.

He smirked in the darkness. Turned on his side. And fell into sleep — deep, dreamless, merciful.

54 Camino, Stage 1

THE morning began with Victor realizing: one hundred and twenty kilometers on foot — that might be, perhaps, a tad excessive. Even for a man who runs regularly in the mornings. Or used to run. Five years ago. When he was younger and stupider.

He sat on the edge of the bunk, rubbed his face with his hands. His back ached. His shoulders were numb from the hard mattress. Outside the hostel window, early pilgrims were already chattering. Germans, judging by the accent. Chipper as pioneers at a jamboree.

All right. Plan B. Bus to Arzúa. From there — thirty kilometers or so to O Pedrouzo. One day. Then — twenty to Santiago. Total — fifty. That'll be enough to get the compostela. And not kill myself to hell.

Victor dressed, grabbed his backpack, went downstairs. The hostel lobby was crowded with pilgrims. Someone studying maps. Someone eating breakfast. Someone talking on the phone in a language that sounded as if a Pole raised in Portugal were speaking Spanish.

He went outside. Found the MonBus stop. Bought a ticket. Boarded the bus heading to Arzúa. The cabin half-empty. Two pilgrims with enormous backpacks. An elderly woman with shopping bags. A driver who smoked by the doors until the last second.

The bus started moving. Victor leaned back against the seat. Looked out the window.

Galicia. Green, wet, ancient. Hills covered with forest. Eucalyptus, oaks, chestnuts. Between them — meadows where cows grazed. Lazy as fifth-year philosophy students. Stone houses with slate roofs. Small churches at crossroads. Crucifixes by the roads — tall, darkened with time.

Here everything remembers death. Crosses, cemeteries, memorials. As if the earth itself — one big tombstone.

Though there's something honest in that. Not hiding death. Not pretending it doesn't exist. Simply living alongside it. Calmly. Like with a neighbor who sometimes drops by for tea.

Arzúa greeted him with rain. Fine, drizzling, the kind you don't immediately realize is falling at all. And five minutes later you're soaking wet, water trickling down your collar.

Victor got off the bus. Pulled up his hood. Followed the signs. Yellow arrow on blue background. Camino de Santiago. The Way of Saint James. Come here, pilgrim. Come and don't stray.

The path led from town through fields. Dirt, in places rocky, in places sodden from rain. Victor walked slowly. Breathed deeply. The backpack pressed slightly on his shoulders. His boots squelched.

So, Latov, enjoying being a pilgrim? Romance. Communion with nature. Spiritual quest. And also — wet socks and an aching back.

He smirked to himself.

After a kilometer he caught up with a couple. Man and woman, about fifty. Speaking French. Walking unhurriedly, holding hands. Stopping to photograph yet another cow or church.

"Bonjour," Victor greeted them as he passed.

"Bonjour! Buen Camino!" they answered in unison.

Then he walked alone. Fields gave way to forests. Forests — to villages. Villages — to fields again. Everywhere — silence. Only the sound of rain. The rustle of leaves. Occasionally — a dog barking in the distance.

Good. Peaceful. Nobody shooting. Nobody chasing. Just walking. One step. Another. Another.

Maybe that's the whole point of pilgrimage. Not the end of the journey. But the journey itself. This monotony. The rhythm of steps. The emptiness of thoughts.

Or I'm just tired and talking nonsense.

The path narrowed between two stone walls so old they seemed to grow from the earth rather than stand on it. Moss covered the stones in a green fur, and above, the branches of chestnut trees met and wove into a roof, turning the path into a tunnel. No light from the sky reached the ground. No sound from the road behind. Only his footsteps and the drip of last night's rain falling from leaf to leaf to stone.

Victor stopped. He didn't know why. His body simply refused to keep moving. He stood in the green half-darkness and breathed. Nothing else. No questions spinning. No dead men. No women who vanish. No documents, no Orders, no statues. Just the smell of wet earth, the cold of the air entering his lungs, the faint percussion of water on stone.

Something in his chest — not pain, not relief, something without a name — loosened and let go. He stood there for what could have been a minute or ten. A beetle crawled across the toe of his boot. A bird he couldn't identify sang three notes, paused, sang them again. The same three notes. As if rehearsing a phrase it would need later.

Victor exhaled. Long, slow, like a man who'd been holding his breath since Crete.

Then he walked on.

After about ten kilometers he caught up with a group. All talking at once, interrupting each other. Laughing. One playing guitar on the move.

"¡Hola, peregrino!" someone shouted.

"Hola," Victor replied.

"Where are you from?"

"From Russia."

Excitement. Russia! Moscow! Putin! Vodka! All the stereotypes at once. Victor muttered under his breath, "Ballet, hockey."

Victor smiled, answered questions. No, it's not constantly cold. Yes, there are bears, but not on the streets. No, they don't drink vodka every day. Though some do — yes.

They walked about three kilometers together. Then the Spaniards turned into a village. Needed to get a stamp at the church. Victor walked on.

The landscape changed. Hills became steeper. Forests — thicker. Streams appeared, babbling under boardwalks. Stone walls along the road, overgrown with moss. Crucifixes at crossroads. And everywhere — greenery. Lush, bright, almost unnatural.

Galicía — like Ireland. Only warmer. And the food's better.

Somewhere around halfway he sat down to rest. Found a bench under a shelter. Stone, wet, but at least not in the rain. Took a sandwich from his backpack. Bread, jamón, cheese. Ate. Washed it down with water.

A woman sat down nearby. About forty. German, judging by the accent. Walking alone. Looked tired.

"Guten Tag," she said.

"Guten Tag." Victor tried to dust off his lame German. "Going far?"

"To O Pedrouzo. And you?"

"Same place."

"Good. So I'm not alone."

They sat in silence. The rain intensified. Drummed on the shelter like the fingers of a nervous pianist on a piano lid.

"Are you a believer?" she asked suddenly.

"No. And you?"

"Me neither." She smirked. "Strange, isn't it? Walking as a pilgrim without believing in God."

"Maybe we're looking for something else."

"What?"

Victor shrugged.

"Don't know. Peace. Answers. Ourselves. Or just an excuse to get away from ordinary life for a couple of weeks."

She nodded.

"Yes. Probably."

They stood up, walked on. Together. Silently. Each in their own thoughts.

O Pedrouzo appeared unexpectedly. A small town. A few streets. A church. A couple of bars. A hostel for pilgrims.

Victor wrote his name in the book. Got a bunk. Took a shower. Changed clothes. Went outside.

Evening was falling. The rain had ended. The sky cleared. Sun broke through the clouds, painting everything in golden light.

He found a small restaurant. Little, family-run. Went in. Sat by the window. Ordered 'pulpo a la gallega.' Octopus Galician-style. Local classic.

They brought it. On a wooden plate. Pieces of octopus, boiled, drizzled with olive oil, sprinkled with paprika and coarse salt. Next to it — boiled potatoes. Simple dish. No frills. Unless, of course, you happen to have a fresh octopus lying around in your pantry.

Victor ate slowly. Savored it. The sea creature melted in his mouth with all its tentacles. Paprika was generously splattered around the edges of the plate. Salt crunched on his teeth. The potatoes absorbed the oil and became incredibly delicious.

God. This alone made coming to Galicia worthwhile.

Washed it down with local white wine. Albariño. Light, tart, with a fruity aftertaste.

Then ordered more. And more wine. Sat, gazed out the window. Pilgrims passed by on the street. Tired but content. Talking, laughing. Someone singing.

I don't remember the last time I was this calm.

Twenty kilometers on foot — and the world seems simpler. Clearer. More comprehensible.

Maybe tomorrow everything will go sideways. Maybe there won't be a document. Maybe I'll be arrested or killed. Christ, what nonsense is getting into my head? What would they arrest me for? Let alone — kill me?

But today — today is good. Today I'm alive. Fed. Calm.

Thank you, octopus. You made my day.

Victor paid, left. Returned to the hostel. Lay down on the bunk. Closed his eyes.

And fell asleep. Immediately. Deeply. Without dreams. For the first time in a week — almost happy.

55 Camino, Stage 2

THE morning was clear. The sun shone as if apologizing for yesterday's rain. Birds screamed in the bushes, discussing the latest gossip. Victor woke up refreshed. Well-rested. Ready to walk another twenty kilometers.

Who would've thought. Latov and exercise. And yet my main exercise — lifting a shot glass from table to mouth.

He breakfasted at the hostel. Coffee, toast, orange juice. Packed his backpack. Went outside.

The way from O Pedrouzo to Santiago — the final leg. The shortest. But also the most crowded. Pilgrims here in droves. Some who walked all across France. Some who started from Portugal. Some, like Victor, who cheated and started closer to the finish.

He walked in the flow. Passed the slow. Yielded to the fast. Greeted. Nodded. Smiled.

“¡Buen Camino!”

“¡Buen Camino!”

The pilgrims' mantra. Wishing good journey. Repeated hundreds of times a day. Loses meaning. Becomes just sound, onomatopoeia of the long road.

The landscape changed. Suburbs appeared. Houses became more frequent. Roads — wider. Cars — more. Civilization advanced like tide.

Victor walked, thought. About the document. About Valeria. About Vichitov. About the twelve judges. About the fifth figure.

Child's torso. What does that mean? Child. Innocence. Or... victim?

The Order that kills to preserve a secret. The Order at war with itself. Time of troubles.

And Valeria — somewhere there. At the epicenter. Or already dead.

No. Not dead. Can't be. She's too smart. Too careful.

She's alive. And waiting. For what — I don't know. But waiting.

After about ten kilometers he caught up with a man. Walking alone. About thirty-five. Spaniard. Tanned, wiry. On his neck — a shell. Symbol of the Camino.

"Hola," Victor greeted him.

"Hola. Russian?" Damn accent.

"Yes. Where are you from?"

"From Madrid. Walking my third time. Every year a different route."

They fell into conversation. The man's name was Javier. Worked as a history teacher. Divorced. No kids. Walks the Camino to *clear his head*.

"And why are you walking?" Javier asked.

"For the experience," Victor lied. "Never been a pilgrim before. Decided to try it."

"And how is it?"

"Not bad. Feet hurt, but overall — not bad."

Javier laughed.

"Everyone says that. First time — feet hurt. Second time — soul hurts. Third time — nothing hurts anymore. Just walk."

They walked several more kilometers together. Victor took the plunge.

"Javier, have you heard of *Lex Vicit*?"

Javier looked at him surprised.

"*Lex Vicit*? The Order? The library?"

"Yes."

Javier burst out laughing. Loudly. Heartily.

"Of course I've heard! That's an urban legend. Very popular after Franco's death. In the seventies, eighties. Everyone was looking for secret documents supposedly hidden by the dictator. Or the church. Or someone else."

"Did they find anything?"

"Nothing! Well, more precisely — fakes. Tons of fakes. Someone drew "ancient" manuscripts. Someone forged seals. There were even professional archaeological excavations. In Toledo, in Santiago, in Burgos. But they found nothing. — He shook his head. — Everything turned out to be a hoax. Beautiful, but empty."

"So the Order never existed?"

"Maybe it did. Who knows. The Middle Ages — dark times. Lots of things happened. But the library — definitely not. That's fiction. Conspiratorial fantasy." Javier looked at Victor curiously. "You don't seriously believe in this, do you?"

"No," Victor answered quickly. "Just heard about it. Got curious."

"I see. Well yes, interesting topic. Romantic. Secret Orders, hidden treasures, conspiracies. People love that." Javier shrugged. "I also dreamed of finding treasure as a kid. Dug in the backyard. Found a beer can. That was my greatest archaeological success."

Victor laughed. Not because it was funny. But to hide disappointment.

Legend. Hoax. Fakes.

So all for nothing? Vincent Leo died for a legend? Valeria vanished because of fiction?

Or Javier simply doesn't know the truth. And how would he, with such a name. Now if he were Luis, or Leandro...

*Or Lope. Lope de Vega. L. V. Christ, now I'm seeing
secret conspiracies everywhere.*

*Tomorrow I'll check myself. Under the altar, on the
right. If there's nothing — then everything really is fake.
And I'm — an idiot who believes in fairy tales.*

They reached Santiago together. The city greeted them with a crowd. Tourists, pilgrims, locals. All mixed into one noisy flow. Streets narrow, stone. Houses old, gray. Churches on every corner.

Victor and Javier reached the cathedral. The square before it — enormous. Plaza del Obradoiro. The cathedral — majestic. Romanesque, with Baroque facade. Towers tall, reaching skyward. Gates closed.

"It's late already," said Javier. "The cathedral closes at eight. Tomorrow morning they'll open. For mass."

"I see."

They stood, gazing at the cathedral. Pilgrims were taking photos. Hugging. Crying. Someone praying, kneeling.

"Let's go have a drink," Javier proposed. "Celebrate the finish."

"Let's."

Found a bar. Quiet, local. No tourists. Ordered wine. Red, tart, local. Ribeira.

Sat, drank, talked. About life. About work. About why people walk the Camino.

"You know what's strangest?" said Javier. "Everyone comes here for answers. And leaves with questions. More than they had at the start."

"Perhaps that's the point."

"Perhaps."

They drank more. Then more. Javier talked about Spain. About history. About politics. About how hard it

is to be a teacher in a country where everyone is born with awareness of their own rightness. Especially — a history teacher.

Victor said that in Russia it's even more complicated.

Tomorrow. Tomorrow I'll go to the cathedral. To morning mass. For pilgrims. I'll look around. Find the altar. See what's under it.

If nothing — I'll leave. Return to Moscow. Tell Vichitov it was a mistake. The cipher was false. There's no document.

And Valeria... Valeria I'll have to forget. Like you forget dreams. Vivid, but unreal.

They finished the wine. Said goodbye. Javier went to his hostel. Victor — to his.

Lay down on the bunk. Closed his eyes.

Testimonium Caiphae. The Testimony of Caiaphas.

Tomorrow I'll find out. Whether it exists or not.

And if it exists — what to do with it. Give it to Vichitov? Publish it? Burn it?

Don't know. Not yet.

But tomorrow — I'll know.

He fell asleep. To the snoring of unknown pilgrims. To the noise of cars outside the window. To the quiet ringing of bells somewhere in the distance.

The last night before truth.

Or the last night before disappointment.

56 The Cathedral

THE morning mass for pilgrims began at eight. Victor arrived half an hour early. Not from religious zeal — just wanted to look around while there were few people.

The cathedral inside turned out even more magnificent than outside. High vaults. Columns reaching to the ceiling. Stained glass through which morning light broke, coloring everything in shades inaccessible to the ordinary world. Smell of incense, stone and time.

Impressive. Even for an atheist. Though, perhaps, it's designed precisely for atheists. To overwhelm with scale. Make you feel like a bug before the face of eternity.

Works, have to admit.

Pilgrims were already taking seats on the benches. Some praying. Some just sitting, staring into space. Tired faces. Worn feet. But eyes — satisfied. Goal achieved. Journey complete.

Victor slowly walked along the walls. Pretended to examine frescoes and sculptures. Actually searching for altars.

The main altar — in the center. Huge, richly decorated. Gold, marble, carving. Statue of Saint James on top. Around it — priests, preparing for mass.

Not there. Can't get close. And too many people.

To the right — another altar. Smaller. More modest. But also beautiful. In front of it — several rows of benches. Empty.

The right altar. Must be it.

Victor approached closer. Stopped. Pretended to pray. Lowered his head. Folded his hands.

"God, if you exist, forgive me for what I'm about to do. Though, if you exist, you already know why I'm here. And

if you haven't stopped me so far — it means either you approve, or you don't care. Either way — thanks for the forbearance."

He raised his eyes. Examined the altar.

Stone base. Marble top. On top — crucifix, candles, books. Below — nothing. Just stone. Smooth, solid.

Under the altar on the right? Or under the right altar. What does that mean? Under the top? Under the base? In the floor?

And most importantly — how to get there? Get on all fours in the middle of the cathedral and start prying at stones? Excellent plan. In five minutes the guards will grab me, and in an hour — they'll deport me with a lifetime entry ban.

Mass began. The priest came to the main altar. Spoke in Spanish. Slowly, solemnly. Pilgrims stood. Sat. Stood again. Sang. Prayed.

Victor remained at the right altar. Observed. Thought.

Need to stay here at night. When no one's around. Then I can calmly search everything around the altar.

Question — how to stay? Hide? Where? Behind a column? In the confessional? In some corner?

And most importantly — avoid the cameras.

He looked around. Cameras. Of course, cameras. In corners. Above entrances. Aimed at main passages. At the main altar. At the treasury.

But the right altar — is in a blind spot. Interesting. Accident? Or design?

Though, what's the difference. Main thing — can use it.

Mass ended. Pilgrims dispersed. Victor left the cathedral. Stood in the square. Looked at his watch. Nine in the morning.

A whole day ahead. Need to plan everything. Study the cathedral. Find a place to hide. Check where the cameras are. Where they're pointed. What blind spots exist.

I'm turning into a thief. Or an archaeologist. Or an idiot. All three options equally likely.

He returned to the hostel. Grabbed his backpack. Put in it a flashlight, gloves, knife. The camera in his phone — good enough to photograph documents. Water. Sandwich.

Gentleman's kit for beginning plunderer of church secrets.

Then returned to the cathedral.

The next five hours Victor spent wandering under the stone vaults. Went in, went out. Sat on benches. Stood by walls. Studied every corner. Every column. Every niche.

Cameras. There were eight. Six aimed at main passages and altar. One — at the treasury. Another — at the exit.

The right altar — outside the viewing zone. But there's a problem. To get there, you need to pass by the camera at the main passage.

So, need to go while there are people. Blend with the crowd. Reach the right altar. And there — hide.

Where?

He studied the space around the altar. Benches. Walls. Columns. And — a niche. Small. Behind the altar. Dark. An old statue stands there. Covered in dust.

Behind the statue — space. Enough for a person to crouch. Curl up. Wait it out.

Will work. Not ideal, but will work.

Victor looked at the cameras once more. Mentally traced the route. From the entrance — in the crowd of

tourists. Right. To the altar. Behind the altar. Into the niche. Done.

Simple. If I don't screw up.

He left the cathedral. Had lunch at a café. Returned to the hostel. Lay down. Didn't sleep — too nervous.

You know, Latov, sometimes you should think about your life choices. You could've been a normal journalist. Writing articles about exhibitions. Interviewing ballet artists. Drinking coffee with Dimka.

But no. You decided to search for ancient documents in cathedrals. Hide from cameras. Risk ending up in prison.

All because of a woman you saw for three days. Beautiful. Romantic. So idiotic that it even suits you.

Though, since you've started — you have to finish.

At seven in the evening he returned to the cathedral. Crowd of tourists. Victor joined it. Passed through the main entrance. Camera overhead. Don't look at it. Walk naturally. Like an ordinary tourist.

Right. Past the main altar. To the right one. Fewer tourists here. Almost none.

Victor looked around. Nobody watching. Quickly went behind the altar. Into the niche. Behind the statue.

Crouched. Curled up. Froze.

Done. Now wait.

Five minutes passed. Ten. Twenty. Nobody came. Didn't notice.

Lucky so far.

Victor sat motionless. Listened. Footsteps of tourists. Voices. Echo under the vaults. Somewhere a choir sang. Beautifully. Solemnly.

God, how uncomfortable to sit. Leg's gone numb. Back aches. And most importantly — still three hours to wait.

I hope the document's worth it. Otherwise I'm just a fool who sat for three hours in a niche behind a statue of a forgotten saint.

Time dragged on. Victor thought about various things. About Valeria. About where she is now. Whether she's alive. Whether she thinks of him.

Most likely not. To her I was — what? Cover. Random acquaintance. Tool.

And I fell in love. Like a boy. Like an idiot.

Though maybe I didn't fall in love. Maybe I just fixated. Because she disappeared. Because she's a mystery.

If she'd stayed — we'd see, in a week we'd have broken up. Realized we don't suit each other. She's — too smart. I'm — too cynical.

But she disappeared. And now I'm here. In the cathedral. Behind a statue. Waiting for night to dig with dusty hands in a sacred place.

Absurd. Pure absurd.

Eight in the evening. Voice over the loudspeaker. In Spanish. Then in English. Cathedral closing. Please leave the premises.

Footsteps. Many footsteps. Tourists leaving. Doors closing. Clang of locks.

Silence.

Not complete. Somewhere people walk. Attendants. Guards. Checking halls. Extinguishing candles. Closing doors.

Victor sat motionless. Breathed quietly. Listened.

Footsteps approached. Someone passed by the right altar. Stopped.

Damn. Did he notice?

Pause. Long. Agonizing.

Then the footsteps moved away.

Victor exhaled.

Got away with it.

Another hour. Footsteps became rarer. Then stopped completely.

Silence. Real. Deep. Such that you can hear your own heartbeat.

Victor looked at his watch. Eleven in the evening.

Time.

He carefully emerged from the niche. Stood. Stretched his legs. Took out the flashlight. Turned it on. Narrow beam of light. Directed it at the altar.

Approached. Crouched. Examined the base.

Stones. Tightly fitted. But one — protrudes slightly. Barely noticeable.

Victor put on gloves. Took the knife. Slid the blade into the crack. Pressed.

The stone yielded. Slid out. Behind it — a cavity.

Got it.

Victor shone inside. Something lies there. Wrapped in cloth. Old, darkened.

He carefully took it out. Unwrapped the cloth.

A book.

Prayer book. Old. Leather binding, cracked. Pages yellowed. Text in Latin.

Victor opened it. Flipped through.

And in the middle — a sheet fell out. Photocopy. Several pages, stapled together.

He shone the flashlight on it.

Title: *Liber Sancti Iacobi*. Book of Saint James. Codex Calixtinus. Part two. *De miraculis sancti Jacobi*. On the miracles of Saint James.

Pages: 5, 12, 22, 27.

Victor quickly took out his phone. Photographed each page. Several times. From different angles. To be sure.

Then put the photocopy back in the book. Wrapped the book in the cloth. Carefully returned it to the cavity. Pushed the stone back in place.

Stood. Shone around. Everything in place. No traces.

Done. Now — hide again. Until morning.

He returned to the niche. Behind the statue. Sat. Turned off the flashlight.

Done. I found it. The next link in the chain.

Liber Sancti Iacobi. Codex Calixtinus. Twelfth century. One of the most famous medieval manuscripts.

But why specifically these pages? 5, 12, 22, 27. What's special about them?

I'll figure it out tomorrow. For now — wait for morning. Another eight hours.

Fun. Romantic. My back's already falling off.

He tried to get more comfortable. Didn't work. Too cramped. Too hard.

Someday, in old age, I'll remember this night. And laugh. Or cry. Don't know which yet.

Hours dragged on. Victor dozed. Woke up. Dozed again. Checked the time. Four in the morning. Five. Six.

Finally — seven. Somewhere bells rang. Distantly. Then — closer. The cathedral awakens.

Footsteps. Voices. Doors opening.

Eight in the morning. Morning mass begins.

Victor waited. Fifteen minutes. More people arrived. Noise, movement.

He emerged from the niche. Stood. Looked around. Nobody watching.

Walked to the exit. Calmly. Naturally. Like an ordinary pilgrim who came for morning mass.

Left the cathedral. Onto the square. The sun was shining. Brightly. Warmly.

Victor took a deep breath. Free air. The most delicious.

Done. It worked. I didn't get caught. Not arrested. Not killed.

Yet.

He went to the hostel. Slowly. Legs buzzing. Back aching. Eyes closing.

In the room he collapsed on the bunk. Didn't even undress. Just closed his eyes.

And fell into sleep. Instantly. Deeply. Without dreams.

And in his jacket pocket lay the phone. With photographs of pages from Codex Calixtinus. The next clue. The next link in the chain leading to truth.

Or to death.

Unclear yet.

57 Tomorrow

VICTOR woke at four in the afternoon. His head was buzzing, as if inside his skull they'd held a rock band rehearsal with three drummers. His body ached. Every muscle complained separately, but together they formed a quite convincing choir of discontent.

He stood, swaying. Washed with cold water. Looked at himself in the mirror. Stubble. Bags under his eyes. The look of a man who spent the night in a cathedral, hiding behind a statue of a forgotten saint.

Romance of adventure. Hollywood would approve. True, movies usually don't show how the hero's right gluteal muscle goes numb and hemorrhoids threaten from sitting on a stone floor.

He took out his phone. Opened the photos. Four pages from Codex Calixtinus. Text in Latin. Handwritten. Beautiful but hard to read.

Victor sat at the little table by the window. Enlarged the first photo. Started examining.

Page five. Story about some miracle. A pilgrim healed at the tomb of Saint James. Or rose from the dead. Or something else along those lines. Victor read with a dictionary. He'd studied Latin in school, but forgotten almost everything. Only scraps remained. *Gloria. Sanctus. Requiem aeternam.* And a couple phrases usually remembered when things are especially bad.

All right. So, page five. Number five. Figure five. Coincidence?

Unlikely. In this story there are no coincidences. Everything's connected. Everything has meaning. Question — what meaning.

He switched to the next page. Twelfth. Another miracle. Another pilgrim. Another healing.

Twelve. Twelve judges. Twelve statues. Twelve symbols on the coat of arms.

Good. Moving on.

Page twenty-two. Victor skimmed the text. Nothing special. Another story about a miracle.

Twenty-two. What could that mean?

He thought. Pulled out paper. Wrote: 5, 12, 22, 27.

Five — figure five. Twelve — twelve judges. Twenty-two — what?

Alphabet letter? V — is the twenty-second letter of the English alphabet.

Victor checked. Yes. V — twenty-second.

And the twelfth — L.

He wrote down: L — 12, V — 22.

Lex Vicit. L and V. Ligature.

Good. Starting to come together. And twenty-seven?

After the alphabet. Twenty-six letters in English. Twenty-seven — the next one. Which doesn't exist.

Or... or I'm an idiot. What the hell English alphabet in the twelfth century? It didn't yet exist in modern form.

Victor dove into the internet. Read articles. About alphabet history. About medieval Latin. About a monk named Byrhtferð who in the eleventh century compiled various tables and tried to systematize letters.

Damn. More complicated. In the Middle Ages they used the Latin alphabet. Twenty-three letters. Without J, U, W. They appeared later.

So my theory about letter numbers — is complete nonsense.

He leaned back in his chair. Rubbed his face with his hands.

All right. If page numbers aren't the key, then the key — is in the content. In the texts of the miracles themselves.

Victor tackled the translation again. Read slowly, writing down unfamiliar words, checking the dictionary. An hour passed. Two. Three.

Nothing. Absolutely nothing. Just stories about miracles. Typical for the Middle Ages. Pilgrims come. Pray. Receive healing. Glory to Saint James. Amen.

Maybe I just don't see it? Maybe need a specialist? A medievalist who knows all the nuances of twelfth-century Latin?

Or the cipher's so good you can't see it without the key?

Victor stood. Paced the room. Outside it was getting dark. The day had passed. Wasted. Or not?

LV. Ligature. Need someone with LV initials. Someone famous. Someone who could leave a trace.

Valeria Lehmann. Vincent Leo. Vladimir Lipkin. Valdis Liels.

All of them — modern. Recent. Need someone from the past. From history.

Victor sat at the computer. Googled: "LV initials famous historical figures."

Thousands of results. What's Ludwig van Beethoven doing here?

Leonardo da Vinci. Curious, but how to connect him? All right, set aside for now.

He scrolled page after page. And suddenly saw it.

Lope de Vega. Lope de Vega. Spanish playwright. Golden Age of Spanish literature. Turn of sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. Wrote plays. Many plays. More than a thousand, they say.

LV. Lope de Vega.

Victor read on. Lope wrote religious dramas. Historical plays. About saints. About pilgrimages. About the Reconquista. About knights.

About saints and pilgrimages. Interesting.

But nowhere — not a word about Codex Calixtinus. Not a single mention. Not in a single play.

Strange. The Codex — is one of the most famous texts about pilgrimage to Santiago. Guidebook for pilgrims. Legend.

Lope wrote about the Camino. About Saint James. But about the Codex — silence.

Victor read biographies. Studies. Articles about Lope de Vega's work.

Lope was Catholic. Believer. Wrote during the Counter-Reformation. Glorified faith, church, Spanish identity. His plays were popular. Staged at court. In theaters.

But Codex Calixtinus in the seventeenth century was forgotten. Remembered only in the nineteenth century.

Forgotten. Or hidden?

If Lope was a member of the Order — he knew about the Codex. Must have known. But kept silent. Deliberately. So as not to attract attention.

Lope de Vega. LV. Member of the Lex Vicit Order.

Victor leaned back in his chair. Looked at the ceiling. The crack overhead resembled pilgrim routes on an old map. All roads ended in Santiago de Compostela.

All right. Suppose Lope was a member of the Order. What next? How does this help decipher the pages?

Need specialists. People who know the Codex. Know medieval Latin. Know the Order's history.

He took his phone. Dialed Vichitov's number.

Long rings. Then a voice, irritated, tired:

"Latov? What time is it there?"

"Evening. Alexei Petrovich, have you heard of Codex Calixtinus?"

Pause.

"Of what?"

"Codex Calixtinus. Medieval manuscript. Twelfth century. About Saint James and pilgrimage to Santiago."

"No. Why?"

"I found a trail. In Santiago. The next link in the chain should be mentioned in the Codex."

"A publicly available manuscript? You're sure?"

Victor didn't mention that the Codex had been stolen, hidden, lost for centuries several times.

"As sure as I can be. I need specialists. Medievalists. Someone who knows the Codex. Can you help?"

Vichitov was silent for a moment.

"I can try. I'll call contacts. Find out. But it'll take time."

"Thank you. I'll be in touch."

Victor hung up. Thought. Dialed another number.

Liels answered immediately. Voice wary but calm:

"Vitya. What's the news?"

"Valya, tell me about Codex Calixtinus."

Pause. Long. Too long.

"You're in Santiago?"

"Was. Not anymore. Tell me in detail, everything you know. I've got a carload of free time."

"The Codex... it's a complex thing. Multi-layered. Officially — a collection of texts about Saint James. Miracles, sermons, liturgies, guidebook for pilgrims. But there are theories that some parts of the Codex contain encrypted information."

"What kind?"

"Depends who you ask. Some say — geographical coordinates. Others — names of secret society members. Still others — instructions for accessing hidden repositories."

"And what do you think?"

"I think the Codex — is more than just a religious text. But what exactly — I don't know. Vitya, did you find something concrete?"

"Maybe. Maybe not. Still figuring it out."

"Vitya..." Liels' voice became serious. "Be careful. The Codex — is a dangerous topic. People have died trying to decipher it."

Victor smirked.

"Valya, people die trying to cross the street in the wrong place. Life in general is dangerous."

"You don't understand. I'm serious. If you really found something in the Codex — you're in danger. This isn't an article about an incompetent mayor, these are more serious people."

"Thanks for the warning. I'll keep it in mind."

"Vitya —"

"Talk to you later, Valya."

Victor hung up. Looked at the phone. Then at the photos of Codex pages on the laptop screen.

Liels knows more than he's saying. That's obvious. Tried to extract information. Find out exactly what I found.

So the Codex really is important. Key link. But how to decipher it?

Victor spent the rest of the evening staring at the texts. Translated again and again. Looked for patterns. Repetitions. Anomalies. Strange words. Unusual phrases.

Nothing.

The pages were silent, like ancient stones keeping secrets they don't intend to reveal to the first passerby.

At midnight Victor closed the laptop. Rubbed his eyes. They hurt, as if he'd stood watch on the captain's bridge. Which, basically, he had.

Enough. Need help. Specialists. Libraries. Archives.

So, back to Moscow. I'll find someone there to help figure it out.

He opened the airline website. Looked at flights. Santiago — Madrid — Moscow. Tomorrow evening. Seats available.

Bought a ticket.

Then lay on the bunk. Without undressing. Just closed his eyes.

Lope de Vega. Member of the Lex Vicit Order. Playwright who knew the secret but kept silent.

If he left a trace — where to look for it? In plays? In poems? In letters?

Or is the trace long erased? Destroyed? Forgotten?

Think tomorrow. Now — sleep. At least try.

Sleep didn't come right away. Victor lay in the darkness, listening to his roommates snoring, the noise of cars outside the window, distant ringing of bells.

Codex Calixtinus. Book of Saint James. Pilgrims' guidebook.

Or treasure map? Cipher? Key to something greater?

Pages five, twelve, twenty-two, twenty-seven. What connects them?

Miracles? Names? Dates? Places?

Or something completely different? Something I don't see? Something hiding in plain sight, like a letter written in invisible ink?

Thoughts swirled, layering on each other, tangling like threads in a ball of yarn that a kitten had batted around the floor all day.

And somewhere between these thoughts, between questions without answers and answers without questions, Victor finally fell into sleep. Heavy, restless, full of

scraps of Latin phrases, faces of forgotten saints, pages that crumbled to dust at the touch.

And Valeria. Who stood at the end of a long corridor, holding an open book in her hands, its pages glowing with pale light, like phosphorus in dark water.

58 Three Historians

Moscow lay under the year's first snow when Victor landed. Wet, nasty, melting right on the asphalt, turning into gray slush, like the stomach contents of the city, turned inside out after a wild night.

From the airport he went straight home. Took a shower. Changed. Checked his email.

From Vichitov came a letter. Three names. Three historians specializing in the Middle Ages and religion. All in Moscow. Contacts attached.

Victor looked at the names. Initials. None of them — LV.

Well. Apparently they don't accept just any medievalists into the Order. Or these three — are too honest. Or too stupid. Or just didn't fit by zodiac sign.

He called the first name on the list. Andrei Sergeye-vich Kamensky. Professor at RSUH. Specialist in Latin paleography and medieval manuscripts. Explained, in careful half-truths, what he was looking for.

"Come tomorrow at three," Kamensky said after a silence. "I'll bring a colleague. Elena Markovna Gromova, from MSU. She studies early Christianity, fourth-century sources. If this involves secret orders — she needs to be in the room. We've had this argument before."

They met in the university library. In a private study room that smelled of binding glue and the quiet desperation of unfinished dissertations.

Kamensky turned out to be a man of about sixty, thin, stooped, in glasses with thick lenses, behind which hid intelligent, tired eyes of a man who'd read too many books and become disillusioned with most of them. Gromova — his opposite in every sense. A woman of about fifty, elegant, composed, with the piercing bird-like gaze of someone accustomed to seeing more than is shown. They sat on the same side of the table, but the distance between their chairs could have accommodated a third person — or a century of academic disagreement.

"Codex Calixtinus," Kamensky repeated when Victor explained why he'd come. "Interesting text. Multi-layered. You know the original was stolen in 2011?"

"Heard. Then they found it."

"In an electrician's garage," Gromova added dryly. "Irony of fate — or a measure of how seriously the world guards its manuscripts."

"What exactly are you interested in?" Kamensky asked, ignoring her.

"Pages five, twelve, twenty-two and twenty-seven from the second part. De miraculis. Is there anything special in them? Ciphers? Hidden messages?"

Kamensky took off his glasses. Wiped them. Put them back on — a ritual that apparently helped him think.

"Ciphers in medieval texts — are common. Monks loved hiding information. Sometimes — from censorship. Sometimes — for intellectual sport. But Codex Calixtinus was always considered a clean text. Without particular mysteries."

"And the *Lex Vicit* Order? Heard of it?"

Kamensky shook his head. But Gromova set her coffee cup down with a click.

"I have," she said. "If you believe the sources — and they're hard to trust — the Order was founded in the fourth century. By Eusebius of Caesarea. Or his disciple Acacius. Or Athanasius of Alexandria. Or one of the lesser-known Copts. Rumors, as always, contradict each other."

"Fourth century?" Kamensky's eyebrows climbed above his frames. "Elena Markovna. You're leaping over eight hundred years of missing evidence."

"Missing because it was systematically destroyed, Andrei Sergeevich. Christianity was only becoming the official religion. Constantine accepted the faith. The Ecumenical Councils began. The canon was being formed. Apocrypha winnowed out. Inconvenient texts — destroyed. In such times people appear who want to preserve what others want to destroy."

"Speculation," Kamensky said, but without conviction.

"Then let me speculate further." Gromova turned to Victor. "Eusebius of Caesarea introduced the practice of festal letters. Letters that bishops sent to churches before Easter. Officially — to announce the date of the holiday. Unofficially — to transmit information. Instructions. Sometimes — encrypted."

"And the abbreviation LV? Where does it come from?" Victor asked.

"According to one version — from the name of Pope Liberius. Bishop of Rome in the mid-fourth century. Controversial figure. First opposed the Arians, then was forced to compromise. Returned from exile. Restored his power. Died in 366 AD. But before his death, allegedly, created a secret network of keepers of true texts. Liberius and... someone else. Whose name began with V."

"Who?"

"Unknown. Maybe Victor." Gromova looked mockingly at Latov. "There were several Saint Victors at that time. Maybe Valens. Maybe Vincent. Or maybe it's not a name at all. Maybe V meant something else. *Veritas*. Truth. Or *Via*. Way. Or *Victoria*. Victory."

Kamensky rapped his knuckles on the table — a professor's gesture, calling the lecture hall to order.

"This is all very evocative, Elena Markovna, but the young man asked about the Codex. Concrete leads. Not fourth-century hagiography." He turned to Victor. "There are rumors. Unconfirmed. Leonardo da Vinci left notes in the margins of some manuscripts. Particularly, in the 'Codex on the Flight of Birds.' Codex del vuelo de las aves. There, allegedly, are mentions of secret societies connected to the Way of Saint James."

"Leonardo? What does Leonardo have to do with it?"

"Leonardo was interested in everything. Architecture, anatomy, mechanics, hydraulics. But also — pilgrimage routes. Pilgrim routes weren't just religious paths. It was a communications network. Information network. Along the Camino were built hospitals, monasteries, hospices. People from all over Europe met there. Exchanged knowledge. Ideas. Secrets."

Victor listened without interrupting.

"Leonardo, as far as we know, never walked to Santiago. But he studied the system. Drew maps. Made notes. In the 'Codex on the Flight of Birds' — which is about flight mechanics, wings, air currents — there are strange marginalia. Unconnected to the main text. Mentions of 'guardians of the path.' Of 'twelve watchers.' Of 'the mystery hidden in stone.' "

"You've seen these notes?"

"No. The original is in Turin. Royal Library. Access is restricted. But there are publications. Facsimile editions. Can be found if you try."

Gromova uncrossed her arms. "I'll grant you Leonardo, Andrei Sergeyevich. Twelve watchers, guardians — it fits with what I'm describing. A network that survived from late antiquity into the Renaissance. The question is only when it began."

"The question," Kamensky said quietly, "is whether it still exists."

They looked at each other. For the first time in the conversation, they agreed on something.

Victor wrote down everything he could. His hand was trembling. Both historians noticed.

"You found something tangible, didn't you?" Gromova said.

"Maybe."

"Be careful," Kamensky said. "Knowledge — is always dangerous. Especially old knowledge."

"The fourth century or the fifteenth — it doesn't matter," Gromova added. "If the Order keeps something real, the people guarding it won't distinguish between a journalist and a threat."

Victor wrote down: "Codex del vuelo de las aves. Turin. Marginalia. Twelve watchers. Fourth century. Liberius. LV."

"Thank you both. Very helpful."

Kamensky nodded stiffly. Gromova gathered her bag but paused at the door.

"The fact that Andrei Sergeyevich and I disagree on the century doesn't matter, Victor. What matters is that neither of us doubts the Order exists. Now."

The door closed behind her. Kamensky sat motionless, staring at the spot where she'd stood.

"She's right, you know," he said to no one in particular.

Two experts. Disagree on everything — century, origin, evidence. Agree on one thing: danger. That should tell me something. Probably that I should stop. Which means I won't.

Victor called the remaining name on Vichitov's list. Igor Vladimirovich Nesterov. Worked at the Institute of Universal History of the Russian Academy of Sciences. They met in his office. A small room, piled with books, smelling of old paper and the disappointment of an academic career that never took off.

Nesterov was the complete opposite of both Kamen-sky and Gromova. Loud, self-confident, with a paunch that testified to a love of feasts and a dislike of physical activity.

"*Lex Vicit?*" He snorted when Victor asked. "In-vention. Fiction. Fantasy of idle minds trying to turn history into farce."

"Meaning the Order didn't exist?"

"Didn't exist. Never. It's a myth created in the Renaissance. You know by whom? Antonio de Nebrija. Ever heard the name?"

Victor shook his head.

"Nebrija," Nesterov continued with the air of a teacher explaining the obvious to a dull student, "Spanish humanist. Late fifteenth — early sixteenth century. Grammarian. Lexicographer. Author of the first grammar of the Castilian language. Published, by the way, in 1492. The same year Columbus discovered America and the Jews were expelled from Spain. Symbolic, isn't it?"

"Very. And what does this have to do with *Lex Vicit?*"

"Nebrija was interested in history. Wrote chronicles. Studied etymology. And — loved mystifications. There's a version that he invented the legend of the secret Order of knowledge keepers. Why? To attract attention to

his works. To create an aura of mystery. People love mysteries. Especially — those that don't exist."

Victor wrote down: "Nebrija. 1492. Mystification?"

"But if it's an invention," he asked, "why do people still talk about it?"

Nesterov spread his hands:

"Because people — are fools. They like believing in conspiracies, secret societies, hidden libraries. It's more romantic than admitting that history — is just a series of accidents, mistakes and banal ugly intrigues."

Lovely person. Beacon of optimism. Wonder if life broke him like this, or he was born a cynic?

His phone rang that evening. Unknown number, Spanish prefix.

"Victor? It's Meritxell. Garcia. From Toledo."

Her voice was tighter than he remembered, the Catalan vowels clipped short.

"Of course. How are you?"

"Listen. After you left I kept digging. The archives here — they're a mess, half the indexes are still handwritten, but I found the house. Your key, I mean. Calle del Ángel, number eleven. It's a ruin now, walled up since the sixties, but the land register goes back to 1391. The last Jewish owner was a certain Shlomo ibn Shushan. Silversmith. He left in the first expulsion wave, fifteen years before the Edict. The house changed hands six times after that. Then nothing. Nobody wanted it. As if the place itself pushed people away."

Victor sat on the edge of the bed, pressing the phone hard against his ear.

"And Vals? Have you spoken to him since?"

A pause. Long enough to hear traffic on her end, a moped's whine rising and falling.

"That's the other reason I'm calling. Vals disappeared. His office at the university is cleaned out. Colleagues say he took a sabbatical, but nobody filed the paperwork. His phone is dead. His neighbor told me a van came at night, two weeks ago. Loaded boxes."

"Did the neighbor see who?"

"No. Only the van. White, no plates."

Victor closed his eyes. Another thread pulled taut and snapped.

"Meritzell. Thank you. Seriously."

"There's more. In the land register, next to Shlomo ibn Shushan's entry, someone wrote two letters in the margin. Faded, barely visible. I had to use a UV lamp."

"LV."

"Yes." Her voice dropped. "Victor, be careful. Whatever you're looking for — other people are looking too. And they don't knock on archive doors politely."

She hung up without saying goodbye. The Catalan way, perhaps. Or simple fear.

Victor stared at his notes. Calle del Ángel, 11. Shlomo ibn Shushan. Vals — gone. LV in a fifteenth-century margin.

The Order marks its property. Even across centuries. Even in pencil. Even in margins nobody reads.

Victor spent the next week in libraries.

About Leonardo da Vinci. About the "Codex on the Flight of Birds." Manuscript created around 1505. Eighteen sheets. Drawings of wings, calculations of air currents, sketches of flying machines. Leonardo dreamed of flight. Studied birds. Tried to understand mechanics. Wanted to create a machine that would lift man into the sky.

In the margins — notes. In mirror writing, as usual with Leonardo. Victor found a facsimile edition. Examined it. Translated with the help of dictionaries and a mirror.

Most notes — technical. But some... Some were strange.

"The pilgrim's path — is the bird's path. Free, but follows a route."

"Twelve guardians guard twelve gates. Each gate — a step toward truth."

"Stone speaks to those who know how to listen."

Leonardo knew. Or guessed. Or just fantasized. Who can tell now?

Victor bought a large reproduction of the "Vitruvian Man." Hung it on the wall in his room. Homo vitruvianus. Man in a circle in a square. Perfect proportions. Golden ratio.

Stared at the drawing for hours. Tried to understand. Circle — sky. Square — earth. Man — between them. The connecting link. Microcosm and macrocosm. Harmony. Mathematics. Beauty.

Golden ratio. Divine proportion. Fibonacci. Spiral. Everything's connected. Everything has a ratio.

But how does this connect to the Codex? To the Order? To the fifth figure?

Read about Nebrija. Antonio de Nebrija was born in 1441 in Lebrija, Andalusia. Studied in Salamanca. Then — in Bologna. Returned to Spain. Taught rhetoric and grammar. Served at court. Created the first grammar of the Castilian language. Worked on a Latin dictionary. Wrote about metrics, the calendar, biblical texts.

A Renaissance man. Encyclopedist. Humanist. But a mystifier? Possibly.

Read about Pope Liberius. Liberius. Pontiff from 352 to 366 AD. Time of Arian disputes. Time when the nature of Christ was being decided. Divine? Human? Both? Councils. Exiles. Intrigues. Liberius wavered between sides. Under pressure from Emperor Constantius signed the Arian creed. Returned to Rome. Restored orthodoxy. Died, leaving a contradictory legacy.

Keeper of truth? Or just a politician trying to survive? History doesn't give unambiguous answers.

Victor got out a magnifying glass. Examined a reproduction of "The Last Supper." Leonardo. Thirteen figures. Christ in the center. Apostles around. Betrayal. Last meal before death; did they let Jesus pick up whatever he wanted?

Victor searched for symbols. Signs. Hidden messages. Nothing.

Maybe I'm just going crazy? Looking for connections where there are none? A paranoid seeing conspiracies in every detail?

But something gnawed. Something gave no peace. The feeling that the answer was near. That he'd already seen it. But hadn't understood.

Victor sat at the table. Before him — photographs. Figure five from Vichitov's collection. Child's torso. Without head, without arms, without legs.

Pages from Codex Calixtinus. Five, twelve, twenty-two, twenty-seven.

Keychain with the LV ligature.

Vitruvian Man on the wall.

Everything's connected. But how?

He took a sheet of paper. Began drawing. A circle. Inside — a figure. Man. Arms to the sides. Legs apart.

Then erased the arms. Erased the legs. Erased the head.

A torso remained.

Looked at the drawing. Then at the photograph of the fifth figure.

Torso. Center. Heart. Essence.

Vitruvian Man without limbs. Without head. What remains?

Center of the circle. The point around which everything revolves.

And then it hit him.

Figure five — isn't a symbol of helplessness. Not a symbol of silence.

It's the formula for center. Axis. Balance point.

In the Vitruvian Man the navel — is the center of the circle. Geometric center. The point from which all proportions are measured.

And in the torso without limbs — that's the only thing remaining. The center. The core.

Victor jumped up. Ran to the reproduction on the wall. Held the photograph of figure five against it.

The scale didn't match. But the proportions...

He measured. With a ruler. Approximately. From shoulders to waist of the torso. Ratio to width.

Golden ratio. Approximately. Phi. 1.618.

Figure five was created according to the canons of the golden ratio. Like the Vitruvian Man. Like all Leonardo's works.

But Figure five — is fourth century BC. Greece. School of Praxiteles. Long before Leonardo. Long before Vitruvius.

But the golden ratio was always known. The Greeks knew. The Egyptians knew. It's a universal proportion. Natural. Divine.

Victor sat back down. His head was spinning.

*So figure five — is a key. Not just a statue. A symbol.
Golden ratio. Center. Harmony.*

But key to what?

He looked at the page numbers from the Codex. 5,
12, 22, 27.

Tried dividing.

$$12 \div 5 = 2.4$$

$$22 \div 12 \approx 1.833$$

$$27 \div 22 \approx 1.227$$

Not it. Not golden ratio.

Tried differently. Sums. Differences. Products.

$$5 + 12 = 17$$

$$12 + 22 = 34$$

$$22 + 27 = 49$$

Wait.

Victor stopped. Stared at the numbers.

5, 12, 22, 27.

*What if these aren't page numbers? What if they're
coordinates?*

No. Too simple. Too obvious.

What if they're dates? Or distances?

He took a map of the Camino de Santiago. Measured distances. From Lugo to Santiago — about a hundred kilometers. From Arzúa — thirty. From O Pedrouzo — twenty.

Doesn't fit.

The clock showed three in the morning. Victor didn't notice. Drank cold coffee. Smoked, though he'd quit a year ago. Wrote. Drew. Calculated.

Figure five — center. Golden ratio. Vitruvian Man. Leonardo.

Could Leonardo have been a member of the Order?

Why not? He was interested in everything. Anatomy — dissected corpses. Mechanics — designed machines. Architecture — built fortresses. Art — painted masterpieces.

Why not secret societies? Why not hidden knowledge?

Victor looked at the torso again. At the photograph.

Child's torso. Child. Purity. Innocence.

Or... beginning. Origin. Seed. That from which everything grows.

The center from which everything starts.

And then he understood.

Twelve figures — twelve stages. Twelve steps. Twelve gates, as Leonardo wrote.

And the fifth — center. Middle. Balance point. Zero of the coordinate axis. Place from which both beginning and end are visible. Before it — negative values, after — ...

... — after positive! Anno Domini! What we now casually call 'Birth of Christ.'

Victor leaned back in his chair. Closed his eyes.

Fine. Suppose I'm right. What next?

Twelve gates. Twelve very special events. Like the beginning of a new era. Which one are we at now? Are the previous ones known, and if so — all of them?

He opened his eyes. Looked at his watch. Five in the morning. Outside dawn was breaking.

Enough for today. Head's splitting. Need to sleep. And tomorrow...

Tomorrow back to Vichitov. Look at all twelve figures. Understand the system. Find the pattern.

And then... then search for Valeria. Because without her can't solve it. She — is the center. Figure five.

And until I find her, I won't find the answer.

Victor lay down on the couch. Without undressing. Covered himself with his jacket. Closed his eyes.

And fell into sleep where Vitruvian men flew like birds over an endless road to Santiago, and in the cathedral under the right altar lay a book whose pages were blank, waiting.

59 Knocking Vichitov Down

VICTOR appeared at Vichitov's without warning, like an uninvited guest at a funeral who knows more than he should. The secretary tried to stop him, but he walked past, without slowing his pace, like a ship through a storm, ignoring the spray.

Vichitov sat behind a massive Karelian birch desk, shuffling some papers with the air of a man not quite aware of where he was or what he was doing.

"How many of your figures couldn't you date?" Victor asked without greeting, closing the door behind him with a quiet but final click.

Vichitov raised his head. His face froze for a moment, like an actor's mask who's forgotten his lines. Then he began muttering something, indistinct, blurred, like the excuses of someone caught off guard doing something unseemly.

Victor stopped him with a wave of his hand. Like a conductor cutting off a false note.

"Alexei Petrovich, let's skip that. Either you tell me the truth as it is, without makeup and styling, or I leave

right now and forget about your investigation forever. Choose."

Vichitov was silent, clenching his jaws so hard the muscles moved under his skin like mice under a mat.

"We dated them all," he finally rasped out hoarsely. "All twelve. Expert analyses. Tests. Thermoluminescence. Radiocarbon. Everything's accurate."

Victor smirked. Dryly. Without mirth. Like someone who heard an old joke that was never funny.

"You understand perfectly well what I mean. I'm not interested in the date of creation. What matters in these figures isn't that, but the date of attribution. They're just cases, caskets in which relics are stored."

He turned sharply to the twelfth figure. Stood before it, unblinking, staring at the marble face. Goddess — or siren. Antique work. Second century BC, if you believe the plaque. Hair in waves. Lips slightly parted. Eyes empty, but deep as wells into which stars have fallen and now slowly drown in darkness.

And suddenly — for an instant, for a fraction of a second, for the time between heartbeats — the siren's face changed. Morphed. Became alive. Became different. Became Valeria's.

Victor jerked as if struck. Squeezed his eyes shut. Opened them. The siren looked at him with the same empty gaze.

Obsession. I'm going mad. I see her everywhere. In every woman's face. In every statue. Soon I'll start talking to mannequins in shop windows.

He slowly turned back to Vichitov. Spoke quietly, enunciating each word like coins thrown into crevices of cliffs.

"Your collection is missing more than half the exhibits. There are at least twenty-seven. Possibly more.

The fifth and twelfth — are the most valuable here, the most significant, and instead of hunting for the rest, you decided to concentrate on what you have. The beginning of the modern time axis. You want to devalue the rest by proving you can't find them. Or by proving they're not important. Or by proving they don't exist at all."

Vichitov went pale. His face became the color of plaster on a wall from which a cabinet that had stood there for half a century had just been moved.

"How did..." he began, but his voice broke like a string on a detuned guitar.

"Doesn't matter how. What matters is I'm right. Twenty-seven figures. A system. Sequence. A path. You own only part. Less than half. And you're afraid the rest are in other hands."

Victor came closer to the desk, leaning his palms on the polished surface, leaning forward, reducing the distance to the point when silence becomes impossible.

"Do you know who owns the rest?"

Vichitov shook his head. Sharply. Negatively. Then froze. Stood still, like someone who remembered something important, something terrible, something better forgotten. And nodded. Just as sharply. Affirmatively.

"Don't know," he said slowly, picking his words like shards of broken glass. "But can guess."

"Speak."

"Order split. Civil war. I told you. Two factions. One wants to preserve status quo. Other — to change everything. First own figures from first to twelfth. Second — from thirteenth to twenty-seventh."

"And fifth? You have it. So you're — on first faction's side?"

Vichitov smiled bitterly, with taste of wormwood and disappointment.

"I'm not on any side! I'm just collector. I'm interested in history, not politics!"

"Collector," Victor repeated mockingly. "Who creates company named Lex Vicit, hires detective to investigate disappearance of woman whose name begins with same initials, and owns half the figures. What amazing coincidence."

"It's not coincidence!" Vichitov raised his voice, for first time in whole conversation. "It's fate! I didn't choose this! I was chosen! My father was in the Order! My grandfather! I inherited figure! I'm keeper! I'm obliged!"

"Obligated to whom? To dead old men who made up rules thousand years ago? To ghosts who demand sacrifices?"

"To truth!" Vichitov shouted, standing from table, clenching fists. "To knowledge! To what's greater than us! You don't understand! Fifth figure — is key! It opens path! Without it system doesn't work! Without it rest — are just stones!"

"And with it? With it what? World changes? History gets rewritten? Christianity collapses?"

Vichitov slowly sat back down, as if suddenly aged ten years.

"With it," he said quietly, almost whisper, "can prove that everything believed for two millennia — is lie. That Jesus was condemned not by Pilate. That there was trial. Real trial. Twelve judges. Twelve witnesses. Twelve verdicts. And all — guilty. *Testimonium Caiphae* — testimony of Caiaphas. High priest didn't just insist on crucifixion. He organized tribunal. Legal. By all rules of Roman, or Jewish, or whatever law. And Jesus lost.

Not as martyr. As criminal. Condemned and executed according to law."

Victor listened without interrupting, feeling how cold crawled up spine, like snake seeking warm place to coil up.

"If this becomes known," Vichitov continued, "church will collapse. Not immediately. But gradually. Faith is based on injustice. On fact that Christ was innocent victim. Lamb brought as a sacrifice to the mob. But if he was condemned legally, justly, by rules he himself acknowledged...

"Then he's just a rebel," Victor finished. "A revolutionary. A failure. One of thousands who tried to change the world and died before succeeding."

Vichitov nodded. "Or simply democracy and justice system are shit," he thought, but didn't say aloud.

"Exactly. That's why the second faction wants to destroy the 'Testimonium.' Or hide it forever. And the first — wants to preserve it. As proof. As a weapon. As a lever of power over those who believe."

"And where's Valeria herself in all this? Does she own the remaining figures?"

"Possibly. Or knows where they are. She's — the twelfth in the system. Last of the first circle. A connecting link between past and future. Between us and them. She can't reveal information while the fifth figure is active. While history begins with year zero. With Anno Domini."

"So she wants to destroy the fifth figure? Or steal it?"

"Don't know. Maybe. Or she wants to find a way to bypass the system. Hack the code. Change the rules."

Victor exhaled slowly, feeling fatigue that descended on his shoulders like a wet greatcoat.

"Fine. I'll continue working on the case. But no more secrets. Agreed?"

Vichitov nodded, with not too sincere relief, like a man who'd received a reprieve from sentence.

Victor left office, went down to street, caught taxi. Rode silently, looking out window at city that rolled past, like film stock of old movie, where all heroes already died, but continue moving across screen.

At home he sat at table. Spread before himself everything accumulated over these days. Photographs. Notes. Copies of pages from Codex Calixtinus.

Fifth figure — Anno Domini. Beginning of Christian era. Starting point. Year zero, which, incidentally, never existed. From first year BCE straight into first year CE. Mathematical error that became basis of calendar.

Twelfth figure — siren. Woman. Valeria. Now. Present moment. Point at which we stand, looking back at everything that was, and forward at everything that will be.

Valeria possesses knowledge of remaining figures. But cannot reveal it while fifth is active. Until history is crossed out by document proving that Jesus Christ was condemned legally, by rules, by court of twelve.

Twelve judges. Twelve figures. Twelve gates. All connected.

Victor picked up his phone. Looked at the screen. Checked messages.

Been a long time since I got an SMS from her. No hints. No signs. No cries for help encrypted in innocent phrases.

Either she's really vanished, dissolved without a trace like smoke on the wind. Or she's waiting. Watching. Testing whether I can make it to the end without her hints.

He returned to the copies of pages from Santiago de Compostela cathedral. Pages five, twelve, twenty-two, twenty-seven. Photographs taken in haste, in poor light, with the trembling hands of a man who feared getting caught.

Victor studied them for hours, until his eyes hurt, until they stung, until tears came. Read the Latin. Translated. Searched for acrostics, ciphers, hidden messages in the initial letters of lines.

Nothing. Ordinary texts about Saint James's miracles. About the blind who saw. About the lame who walked. About the dead who rose. Medieval propaganda designed to attract pilgrims.

He almost gave up. Almost put the sheets aside. Almost decided he was wrong, that these were just random pages with no significance.

But something made him look again.

At the fifth page. At an angle. In the side light of his desk lamp.

And then he saw it.

A pattern. Dots. Tiny, barely visible, like pinpricks with a needle. In the margins. Between lines. In the swirls of letters.

Not random. Too orderly. Too symmetrical. Too similar to...

To what?

Victor squinted, leaning closer, feeling his heart begin to beat faster, adrenaline flowing into his blood, sharp and sweet as the first sip of wine after a long fast.

I've seen this before. Somewhere. Sometime. This pattern. This sequence.

But where?

He closed his eyes, trying to remember. Sifting through images. Places. Books. Paintings.

Vitruvian Man? No. That's circle and square. Geometry. And here...

Here it's something else. Constellation? Map? Musical notation?

Victor opened his eyes. Looked at the pattern again. Tried connecting the dots with lines. Mentally. Then took a pencil. Drew on tracing paper. Laid it on the photograph.

A figure. Some kind of figure. Not too symmetrical. Complex.

But which?

The clock showed two in the morning. Outside stood silence, dense and thick as fog over a swamp in which you could get lost forever.

Victor kept staring at the dots, feeling the answer was somewhere nearby, an arm's length away, but he couldn't quite reach it, like trying to grasp a reflection in water that scatters with every touch.

I know this. I've seen this. I understand this.

I just can't remember where.

But I will remember. I must remember.

Because the answers are here. In these dots. In this pattern. In this page that someone, seven hundred years ago, left as a message. As a sign. As a beacon in the dark for those who would come after and search for the way.

Victor laid his head on his arms. Not sleeping. Just resting, giving his brain a chance to recuperate, reboot, find new connections in the chaos of information that had accumulated over recent weeks.

Tomorrow. Tomorrow I'll remember.

Or I'll see what I should have seen today.

60 The Search

VICTOR began making the rounds of friends, acquaintances and half-acquaintances with the methodicalness of a debt collector squeezing debts from those who'd long forgotten their promises. Carried with him a folder with photocopies of the four pages, spread them before people like tarot cards, waiting for someone to say the magic word that would break the curse of incomprehension.

I've turned into a beggar knocking on every door. Only I'm not asking for money, but for meaning. Which, possibly, is worth even more. Or absolutely worth nothing, as will become clear at the end of this circus.

First was Lesha Krotov, conceptual artist, whose installations were regularly rejected by all respectable galleries and accepted by all disreputable ones. Lesha lived in a studio on Red October, in a space that smelled of turpentine, tobacco and disappointment in contemporary art.

Victor spread the pages on a table splattered with paint of all colors humanity had invented over the last five thousand years.

"What do you see?"

Lesha leaned over the sheets, squinted, tilted his head sideways, as if trying to catch the right viewing angle at which chaos becomes cosmos.

"Pattern of dots... Interesting. Looks like a star map. Or a diagram of neural connections. You know, there's this theory that medieval monk-scribes were actually advanced neurobiologists. They studied the brain but couldn't talk about it openly because the Church forbade autopsies. So they encrypted their discoveries in manuscripts. This could be a map of the human brain.

Or part of it. Hippocampus. Or amygdala. Or pre-frontal cortex. The place where thoughts of God are born."

Victor wrote down: "Neural brain map. Encrypted anatomy."

Excellent. Now I'm searching not only for secret Orders and ancient documents, but also medieval neurosurgeons. Soon it'll turn out they did skull trepanation with lasers.

Next was Masha Gromova, pianist and composer, who wrote music for avant-garde theaters and earned her living teaching solfeggio to oligarchs' children. She looked at the pages silently, then went to the piano and began to play.

"These are notes," she said without looking away from the keys. "Or could be notes. If you imagine that each dot — is a sound. Pitch is determined by vertical position, duration — by horizontal distance to the next dot. It makes a melody. Strange. Atonal. Like a Gregorian chant, but distorted. As if someone was trying to record the music of the spheres but heard it through a thickness of water or through prison walls."

She played to the end, the final chords hung in the air, anxious and unfinished, like a question without an answer.

"If this really is music," Masha added, "then very dangerous. Such sound series were used in the Middle Ages for exorcising demons. Or summoning them. Depending on who played."

Victor wrote down: "Musical cipher. Melody of exorcism/summoning."

Wonderful. So now I'm also conductor of an infernal orchestra. Interesting, what salary do they pay for that? Or does payment come immediately in the form of eternal torment?

Third was Igor Semenov, mathematician, who defended his doctorate in topology and left to work at some financial fund where he calculated third derivatives and lost the remnants of faith in humanity's sanity. Igor spread the sheets on his huge monitor, enlarged them, began measuring distances between dots with a ruler right on the screen.

"Fibonacci sequence," he muttered under his breath. "Or almost. Distances between some dots correspond to the golden ratio. This is a fractal structure. Self-similar. If you enlarge any fragment, you get the same picture, just at a smaller scale. Know what this could mean? This could be a diagram of folded dimensions. String theory. Calabi-Yau manifolds. Medieval monks somehow knew about quantum physics. Maybe aliens told them. Or they received revelation from above. Or they simply stumbled upon a mathematical truth that modern science only rediscovered in the twentieth century."

Victor wrote down: "Fractal. Golden ratio. Quantum physics. Aliens?"

Excellent. Now aliens are involved too. All we're missing are Freemasons, reptilians and Elvis Presley, who, as everyone knows, is alive and hiding in the Vatican.

Fourth was Liza Sokolova, biologist-geneticist working at an institute whose name Victor could never remember in full because it consisted of twenty-three words and three abbreviations. Liza looked at the dots with professional interest, pulled out a tablet, began drawing something over the image.

"Looks like a genome map," she said thoughtfully. "Or a diagram of epigenetic markers. See these clusters? They could designate genes that turn on or off depending on external conditions. There's a theory that human memory is recorded not only in neurons but

also in DNA. And not just individual memory but collective. Memory of the clan. Memory of the people. Memory of the species. This could be an attempt to encode some important knowledge at the genetic level. To pass it to descendants. So it would survive even after civilization's collapse. Information recorded in genes is immortal."

Victor wrote down: "DNA code. Genetic memory. Immortal knowledge."

Aha. So the answer's already embedded in me, I just don't know how to read my own genome. Should have studied biology better in school instead of skipping classes for cigarettes behind the garages.

Fifth was Kostya Belov, linguist, specialist in dead languages, who could read Sumerian, Akkadian and some ten other languages whose existence Victor hadn't even suspected. Kostya studied the pages long, traced his finger over the dots, whispered something to himself in an incomprehensible tongue.

"This could be writing," he finally said slowly, weighing each word. "Very ancient. Pre-Christian. Possibly, pre-Cyrillic. There's a version that Slavs had their own writing before Cyril and Methodius came. Called 'features and cuts.' No specimens survived. Or they survived but we don't know how to recognize them. Or maybe this isn't Slavic writing at all. Maybe it's the language spoken by the builders of the Tower of Babel. Before the division of languages. Unified proto-language of humanity. The very one Adam used to name the animals. If so, then anything could be recorded here. An incantation. A prophecy. God's name."

Victor wrote down: "Proto-language. Features and cuts. God's name."

Excellent. Now I'm also Adam who forgot what beasts are called. Or the serpent-tempter trying to remember

where he hid the apple. Either way, the story ends with expulsion from paradise. Spoiler: I'm already expelled. Long ago. Just didn't notice the moment.

Victor came to Pavlik last, when his head buzzed with theories, versions and interpretations, each crazier than the previous, each in its own way plausible and absolutely improbable simultaneously.

His college friend Pavlik had become a legend in narrow circles. Known by the handle P4VL1K_F007, a hacker who cracked everything that could be cracked and much that couldn't be cracked. Worked for himself, lived in an apartment on the outskirts furnished with servers, monitors and equipment racks that hummed like a hive full of electronic bees gathering honey from others' classified data.

Pavlik met Victor in sweatpants and a T-shirt reading "there is no fork," which made Victor smile.

"Show me," said Pavlik without greetings, taking the folder from Victor's hands with the greed of a child who'd received on New Year's exactly the toy he'd dreamed of all year.

He spread the pages on the table, began examining them through a magnifier, muttering something incoherent, scraps of words, fragments of thoughts that folded into a mosaic of understanding inaccessible to the uninitiated.

"Blockchain... no, not that... elliptic curves... maybe... hash function... SHA-256... no, earlier... RSA... asymmetric encryption... keys... public and private... but this is the fifteenth century, what the hell encryption... or... wait..."

He darted to the computer, began pounding the keyboard with the fury of a pianist playing "Ride of the Valkyries" arranged for a hundred and twenty fingers.

Screens flashed with terminal windows, graphs, tables, streams of symbols running like rain in "The Matrix," but not from top to bottom — but right to left.

"Running global comparison," Pavlik muttered without looking away from the screens. "Searching across all known databases of patterns, ciphers, codes, cryptograms, steganography... this will take some time... maybe an hour, maybe three... depends on how deep we dig..."

He turned to Victor as if remembering he existed.

"Want whisky? I've got Maker's Mark. In case a friend drops by. Or evening comes suddenly," added Pavlik, smirking.

"I'd take even that Kizlyar from the kiosk at Three Stations right now," Victor agreed, sinking into a tattered armchair that had once been leather and now more resembled the hide of a dinosaur that survived the Ice Age.

Pavlik produced a bottle and two glasses, poured generously, Russian-style, not stinting, as if the whisky were not blended bourbon but port wine from a grocery store.

They drank silently. Then again. Then once more.

"Tell me," said Pavlik, leaning back in his chair, which probably cost more than all the other furniture in the apartment combined. "What's the story? Why are you chasing dots on medieval manuscripts like Chikatilo after schoolgirls?"

Victor smiled. Dryly. Joylessly. Like a man who'd just been told a joke about a funeral.

"Want the full version or the short one?"

"The full one. We have time. The computer's thinking meanwhile. It's smarter than both of us, so let's not interfere."

Victor poured himself more whisky, took a sip, felt peat and smoke spread through his throat, burning and soothing simultaneously.

"So here's how it is. Woman. Valeria Lehmann. Met her in Crete. Two days like paradise. Then she vanished. Just evaporated, leaving a note 'Forgive it,' or 'Forget it,' or something. I started searching. Chased her across Europe. Trail led through Manchester to Spain. Everywhere one step late. Everywhere found only shadows and rumors."

Pavlik listened silently, not interrupting, pouring whisky into both glasses with the regularity of a metronome.

"Then a call from Liels. My old acquaintance, dark horse, man who knows what no one knows. Says: save your friend, she's in trouble. And right then our editor hands me a client: Vichitov, oligarch, gold mining, company 'Lex Vicit.' Wants to find the same woman. Coincidence? Don't think so. Go to Vichitov. Office like museum. Twelve ancient statues. Figure five — child's torso. Vichitov says: find Valeria, she's in danger, she stole something, she knows something. And also, this gold baron says, find me a document."

Victor paused, finished the whisky, set the glass on the table with a dull thud.

"I start digging. Museum, twelve statues, riddles, anagrams, acronyms. 'Libera me vox index,' though to hell with it, of course. Free me, the voice. Then poker tournament. Meet Vincent Leo. Initials LV. He gives me a keychain with LV ligature. Dies in my arms. Last words: 'Ligature V.L.V.' Riddle upon riddle."

Pavlik leaned forward, eyes flashed with hunter's interest catching a scent.

"Then — Spain. Toledo. Centro Sefarad-Israel. Meet Meritxell Garcia, then Professor Ernesto Vals. Learn about the *Lex Vicit* Order. Secret society. Twelve judges.

All with initials LV. Keepers of ancient knowledge. Vals says: the Order in crisis, civil war, split into two factions. Some want to preserve the old, others — change everything.”

“Interesting,” Pavlik muttered. “Continue.”

“Return to Moscow. Call from Liels. He gives a lead: Maimonides’ letter, year 1169. Decipher it. Says: ‘Testimonium Caiphae. Palatium Sancti Iacobi. Compostellae. Sub altare dextro.’ Testimony of Caiaphas. Palace of Saint James. In Compostela. Under right altar. Go there. Walk on the Camino. Thirty kilometers on foot, like medieval pilgrim, only instead of staff I have smartphone, and instead of prayers — cursing through teeth.”

Pavlik laughed shortly, dryly.

“In Santiago cathedral hide until night. Under right altar find prayer book. Inside — photocopies of pages from Codex Calixtinus. Pages five, twelve, twenty-two, twenty- seven. ‘Liber Sancti Iacobi,’ second part, ‘De miraculis.’ But what’s special in them — unclear. Ordinary texts about miracles.”

“And then?”

“Then a connection to Lope de Vega emerges. Spanish playwright, seventeenth century, initials LV. Wrote about saints, about pilgrimages, but never mentioned Codex. Suspicious. Then — historians. Three. Kamensky talks about Leonardo da Vinci, ‘Codex on the Flight of Birds,’ marginalia about twelve guardians. Nesterov says it’s all fiction by Antonio de Nebrija. Gromova talks about Eusebius of Caesarea, fourth century, Pope Liberius, Order foundation.”

Victor spoke faster, words poured in a stream, like water from a burst dam.

“I buy reproduction of Vitruvian Man. Hang it on wall. Look at figure five. Understand: it’s not just a

torso. It's the center. Geometric center. Golden ratio. Balance point. Fifth figure of twelve, but it's — key to everything. Then go to Vichitov. We argue a bit. Turns out: not twelve figures but twenty-seven. Minimum. Vichitov owns only the first twelve. Rest — the second faction has. Fifth figure — is Anno Domini, beginning of Christian era. Twelfth — is now, modernity, Valeria."

"Valeria — is twelfth? She's the Order member?"

"Seems so. Vichitov says: she can't reveal information while fifth figure is active. While history won't be crossed out. By document. 'Testimonium Caiphae' — testimony that Jesus Christ was tried lawfully. Twelve judges. Verdict by rules. Not martyr but criminal. If this becomes known — church will collapse. Faith will collapse. Everything collapses."

Pavlik was silent, digesting the information. Then asked quietly:

"And what's on those pages? Those very ones you brought me?"

"Don't know. Studied them for a week. Found dot pattern. On page five. Barely noticeable. Reminds me of something, but can't remember what. Showed to artist — he says it's brain map. Musician — says it's notes for summoning demons. Mathematician — says it's fractal and quantum physics. Geneticist — says it's DNA code. Linguist — says it's proto-language and God's name. All right. All wrong. All going mad, like me."

Victor fell silent, emptied, squeezed out like a lemon from which they pressed the last drop of juice for a cocktail no one will drink.

"That's the story. Tragedy libretto in three acts. Prologue already passed. Climax near. Remains only to learn how it all ends. Apotheosis or catastrophe. Though, if you think about it, both — are catharsis."

Pavlik stood, approached the computer, looked at screen. Froze. Leaned closer. Eyes widened.

"Episcopal baccalaureate," he exhaled quietly, reverently, like a fisherman who caught a pike.

Then he turned to Victor, and on his face was the expression of someone who'd just solved millennium problem or discovered immortality formula or saw God with his own eyes.

"Eureka," he said simply. "Vitka, I know what this is."

Part IV

Treasure Hunt

61 The Cavemap

PAVLIK turned to the screen to pull a rabbit from a hat, but instead of a rabbit there'd be the entire universe, folded into a knot.

"Look," he pointed at the monitor, where against black background glowed a diagram assembled from dots connected by lines. "This isn't cipher. Not music. Not DNA. It's map. Geographical, literally indecently specific map. Computer found match in database of geological data. Caves. Cave system. Coordinates: thirty-four degrees fifty-nine minutes north latitude, twenty-four degrees forty-six minutes east longitude."

Victor stared at the numbers, trying to figure out where this could be, sorting through memory the geography he'd studied in school and successfully forgotten right after graduation.

"Crete," said Pavlik, not waiting for question. "South coast. Messara bay. Place called Matala."

Victor felt something in his chest crack, with barely audible crunch, as if his heart suddenly ossified.

"Matala," he repeated quietly, almost whisper. "Hippie caves. Valeria and I spent there a whole day. Climbed through those caves like children through abandoned house attic. She laughed. Said that here lived people who rejected the past for the future, but got only the present, eternal and empty."

Pavlik nodded, enlarging the image.

"Cave system in cliffs. Romans carved them out, then Christian hermits lived there, then fishermen, and in the sixties — hippies from all over the world. Now it's tourist attraction. But look here."

He pointed to one dot that differed from the rest. Was larger. Or brighter. Or just stood out against the general background, like the only false note in symphony that only the composer himself hears.

"This cave is specially marked. See? Double contour. This isn't accident. Someone an entire epoch ago left a map to lead us here. Dig here. Search here. Truth is here, buried in stone, like seed waiting for spring."

Victor was silent, looking at screen, feeling how everything converged, how puzzle finally assembled into picture that scared more than chaos of scattered pieces.

"I need to go there," he finally said hollowly. "Right now. Today. Tomorrow morning. As fast as possible."

"I'm with you," said Pavlik simply, like someone who made decision and wasn't going to discuss it. "Don't argue. You won't go there alone. First, you need someone with brains. Second, I'm interested. Third, I've never been on Crete's south coast. Fourth, I have equipment that might help. Scanners, metal detectors, various electronic junk. Fifth — shut up and don't argue."

Victor smirked. For the first time in long while felt something like gratitude, warm and awkward, like embrace with person you've known long but hug for first time.

"All right. Thanks. We fly tomorrow. I'll buy tickets."

"Already bought," said Pavlik, showing phone screen. "Flight at nine AM. Moscow-Heraklion. Direct. Four hours. I rented car. Pick it up at airport. Everything's handled. Go sleep. Tomorrow will be long day."

Pavlik was always like this. Solves problems before you manage to formulate them. Probably why he's a hacker. Hacks not just computers but reality, finding loopholes where others see only walls.

The plane landed in Heraklion exactly at one PM local time, when sun stood at zenith, merciless and bright, like searchlight at interrogation. Victor collected keys to rented car, small white Fiat Panda that looked as if assembled from parts left over from other automobiles.

Pavlik loaded two backpacks with equipment into trunk, and they drove south, through mountains, along serpentine roads that wound like intestines of giant animal digesting asphalt.

Victor drove silently, concentratedly, but something was wrong. Landscape. It changed. Or not. Or Victor went completely and irreversibly mad.

Mountains seemed higher. Sharper. Cliffs — yellower, as if sun-bleached even more strongly than week ago when he drove here last time. Olive groves stood darker, denser, trees twisted under wind that wasn't there. Sky was same color but looked different. Bluer. Deeper. As if someone added another layer of paint, another tone that wasn't there before.

"Strange," Victor muttered aloud, unable to stay silent longer. "Island changed. I was here week ago. Everything was different. Softer. Simpler. And now..."

"Now what?" Pavlik asked, looking up from phone where he read something about Crete history.

"Now everything's sharper. More contrasted. As if world became more real. Or less. Don't know. Maybe I'm going mad."

Pavlik laughed. Loudly. Sincerely. Like someone who heard excellent joke.

"Buddy, you're not going mad. You're just driving there second time. And second time we always see differently. First time look with tourist eyes. Second — with eyes of one who searches. And when you search, you see details. Shadows. Angles. What you ignored before. Island hasn't changed. You changed. Became paranoid. That's normal. All great detectives — are paranoid. Sherlock Holmes, for example. Addict and paranoid. Saw what wasn't there. And found what was."

Victor smirked, not taking eyes off road.

Paranoid. Excellent epitaph. 'Here lies Victor Latov. Journalist, detective, paranoid. Saw what wasn't there. Sought what didn't want to be found. Died from reality overdose.'

Matala greeted them with silence and sun. Bay lay before them, round and calm, like saucer filled to brim with blue liquid, like blue Hawaiian in hurricane. Caves in cliffs watched sea with empty eye sockets, black voids into which people once crawled to hide from world or from themselves.

They parked at tavern 'Odysseus,' the very one where Victor dined with Valeria an eternity ago, in another life that now seems like dream or someone else's memory.

Odysseus came out to meet them, broad-shouldered, tanned, with smile occupying half his face and absolutely sincere, like child's smile seeing puppy.

"Victor! You returned! This good! Very good! Means Crete you liked! Means you ours now! And your woman? Beautiful woman! Valeria! She with you?"

"No," said Victor shortly, feeling something tighten in throat. "Haven't found her yet."

Odysseus turned serious instantly, as if someone switched off light on his face.

"Pity. Very pity. I thought you find. You searched? Searched well?"

"Searched. Well. So far without result."

"Then continue searching. Don't give up. Woman worth searching — is rarity. Like good wine. Find — will be drunk. Don't find — will regret all life."

Philosopher in apron. Socrates with grill. Diogenes with ouzo. Hands out advice like alms, not asking if needed.

They dined quickly, silently. Grilled octopus Odysseus cooked with same love with which sculptor carves statue from marble. Potatoes fried with rosemary. Tomato salad that tasted like concentrate of summer packed in red firm flesh. White wine, cold and sour, like memory of something good that ended badly.

Sun still stood high, bright and insistent, not planning to go anywhere, like guest who doesn't understand hints.

They went to the caves. Pavlik carried a backpack with equipment, Victor — an army-issue flashlight, heavy, metal, resembling a club that could not only illuminate but also defend against aggressive reality.

The caves were full of tourists. Young couples, families with children, lone travelers who climbed the rocks, photographed, laughed, not suspecting that beneath their feet might be buried truth capable of turning the world upside down.

Or nothing's buried. Maybe this is all nonsense. Maybe I'm chasing a phantom that exists only in my head. Maybe I'm just a psycho who needs treatment, not searching for secrets in caves where hippies smoked weed fifty years ago.

On the far slope hippies began lighting evening fires.

Pavlik confidently walked to the very far edge of the cliff, past the hippies, to where caves became smaller, narrower, unsuitable for habitation. People didn't come here. Too cramped. Too dark. Too un-Instagrammable.

"Here," Pavlik said, checking the printout of the map. "This one. Narrow. See?"

Victor looked. The cave entrance was narrow, like a crack through which one could squeeze only sideways, pulling in stomach and bleeding all air from lungs. Inside — darkness, absolute and dense, like tar.

"I'll go in," Victor said. "You stand guard here. If anything — yell."

"If anything — you'll yell yourself. Loudly. Like a girl. I'll hear."

Victor squeezed inside. Switched on flashlight. Light beam cut through darkness, picking out walls, ceiling, floor. Cave was long and winding, like python's bowels. Smelled of dampness, salt, something ancient and forgotten.

He crawled, ducking, scraping shoulders against stone, feeling shirt tear and skin on arms already scraped bloody. Time stretched like rubber being pulled and pulled, and it doesn't break, only becomes thinner.

At the very end, in the far corner, where cave narrowed to its limit, he saw.

Shovel marks. Fresh. Earth loosened, friable, as after recent digging. Someone was here. Recently. Dug. Searched. And, judging by everything, found.

Victor stood on his knees, shining flashlight on marks, feeling disappointment pour into chest like cold lead.

Too late. Too late again. Story of my life. Always one step behind. Always just don't quite make it. Like runner who finishes second, but there are no medals for second place here.

He crawled back out, dirty, scraped, angry as dog kicked from house into rain.

"They dug there. Recently. Maybe week ago. Maybe less. Someone was before us. Found what they were looking for. And took it. We're too late. As always."

Pavlik nodded philosophically.

"Means we go further. Search for those who found. Or search for what they found. Or at least understand what they found, so we know what we're in."

They returned to the bungalow Victor had rented for two days. Small house with terrace facing the sea, with deck chairs, table and view worth more than all the rent.

Sat on terrace. Victor opened bottle of local white wine, poured into two glasses. Pavlik spread out on table all papers, maps, notes, photographs.

"All right," Victor said, taking sip of wine, feeling fatigue slowly recede, yielding to clarity of thought. "Let's figure it out. In order. From the very beginning."

Pavlik nodded.

"From the very beginning. Order 'Lex Vicit.' Founded in fourth century. By Eusebius of Caesarea or someone from his circle. Pope Liberius. LV. Goal — preserve documents church wanted to destroy. Including 'Testimonium Caiphae' — testimony about trial of Jesus."

"Next. Twelve judges. Twelve Order members. Twelve figures. All with initials LV. That's the rule. That's the symbol. That's the access code."

"Right. Now Lope de Vega. Seventeenth century. Spanish playwright. Initials LV. Wrote about saints, about pilgrimages. But never mentioned Codex Calixtinus. Why?"

Victor pondered, turning glass of wine in hands, watching light refract in liquid, creating little galaxy of reflections.

"Because he was the Order member. Knew about Codex. Knew map was hidden in it. Deliberately didn't mention, so as not to attract attention. But left hints. In his plays. In poems. For those who can read between lines. Lope de Vega worked with the same Codex. Perhaps he's the one who hid photocopies of pages under altar in Santiago. He was in Galicia. Many times. On inquisition business. He had access. He had reason. He guarded knowledge. Passed it on. Down the chain. From one LV to another."

Pavlik nodded, taking notes.

"Logical. Now Maimonides. Twelfth century. Great Jewish philosopher. Physician. Theologian. Initials — not LV. Moshe ben Maimon. MB. But he's involved. Letter of 1169. Cipher. Key to Codex. Why him?"

Victor squinted, looking at setting sun finally beginning to descend toward horizon, painting sky in shades of orange and pink, like blood diluted with milk.

"Because the Order wasn't purely Christian. It was interfaith network. Christians, Jews, possibly Muslims. All who wanted to preserve truth against official dogma. Maimonides lived in Córdoba, then in Cairo. Was physician at Saladin's court. Had access to libraries. To texts. To secrets. The Order used him as keeper. As link between East and West. Between Judaism and Christianity. Initials don't matter when essence matters. He wasn't judge but archivist. Librarian of truth. One who knows where keys lie but doesn't open doors himself."

Pavlik wrote it down, then asked, "And Leonardo? Was he in the Order?"

"Possibly. Leonardo Vinci can be shortened to LV if you ignore that 'da.' He was interested in Camino. Studied pilgrimage routes. Wrote about 'twelve guardians.' Knew about system. Maybe was member. Or maybe just stumbled upon information. Leonardo stuck his nose everywhere. Studied everything. Anatomy of corpses, flight of birds, flow of rivers. Why not secret Orders? This fits. He could have been fifteenth or sixteenth in sequence. Somewhere in middle of second circle."

"And twenty-seven figures? Why exactly twenty-seven?"

Victor poured himself more wine, took sip, lit cigarette he'd swiped from Pavlik's pack.

"Twenty-seven — is three cubed. Space in third-level metamodel. Magical number. Sacred. Twelve — is first circle. From first century BC to twelfth century AD. Conditionally. Each figure — is a century. Or epoch. Or key event. Fifth — is Anno Domini. Starting point. Birth of Christ. Or what actually happened there. Twelfth — is now. Modernity. Valeria. And further — another fifteen. Future. What hasn't yet happened. But already predicted. Encrypted. Built into system."

"So the Order has insiders in the future?"

"Or thinks it knows. Or creates future, following plan carved in stone. In statues. In documents. This isn't prophecy. This is program. Algorithm. Code that executes step by step."

They fell silent, digesting what was said. Outside window sea roared, rolling onto shore with waves that beat against sand with regularity of heart pumping blood through planet's arteries.

"And what was in cave? What did they find?" Pavlik asked quietly.

"Document. Or copy. Or key. 'Testimonium Caiphae.' Or map where it's hidden. Or something else. Something important. Something they hunted. And found. Before us."

"Who's 'they'?"

"Second faction. Those who own figures thirteen through twenty-seven. Those who want to change world. Or destroy it. Or save it. Depends on point of view."

"Valeria?"

Victor took drag on cigarette, exhaled smoke toward sea.

"Valeria — is between them. Twelfth. Last of first circle. First of second. Border. Transition. She can't choose side because she — is both sides simultaneously. Point of bifurcation. Place where history splits into two paths. And both lead to abyss."

Pavlik whistled quietly.

"Beautifully put. Dark, but beautiful. You should write novels. Detectives. About journalists searching for women and finding end of world."

Victor smirked bitterly.

"Already writing. In my mind. Called 'How I Spent Best Years of Life Chasing Shadow I Myself Cast.' Best-seller. Will sell million copies. Posthumously."

They sat on terrace until dark, drank wine, talked about everything and nothing. Then, when stars spilled across sky, like scattered salt on black tablecloth, went swimming.

Sea was warm, calm, dark, like liquid velvet. Victor swam on his back, looking at stars, feeling salt water hold him, like invisible hands, like mother's embrace, or the Almighty's.

We know where to go next. Don't know where exactly, but know direction. Where Valeria is. Where second faction is. Where document is. Where truth is that will kill us all or make us free. No difference. Result is same.

But for now we're here. In Matala. In sea. Under stars. And rushing nowhere.

Because there's nowhere left to rush. Everything already happened. Only remains to reach end and learn who we really are. Heroes or victims. Hunters or prey. Humans or pawns in game whose rules we don't know.

Victor emerged from water, lay on sand, looked at sky, feeling fatigue finally win out, how eyelids grow heavy, how consciousness drifts somewhere far, to where there are no orders, no riddles, no women who vanish leaving only notes saying 'Forgive me.'

Tomorrow they'll fly back. Or travel further. Or stay here forever, turning into new hippies who rejected world for sea, sun and endless present that never ends because there's no more future.

62 Return to Moscow

THE PLANE landed at Sheremetyevo late evening color of lead, melted and spilled across horizon to last drop. Victor and Pavlik rode in taxi silently, each immersed in own thoughts spinning like laundry in washing machine, mixing facts, guesses and fears into homogeneous mass from which impossible to extract anything concrete.

"So here's how," Pavlik finally said, breaking silence that had become too heavy to ignore. "Valeria found document. Or what was in cave. Or key to it. Now she's deciding who to sell to. Vichitov or Liels. First faction or second. Or nobody at all, keeping it herself,

as trump card in game where all other cards already discarded."

Victor nodded, looking out window at city flashing past glass, gray, gloomy, indifferent to fates of those trying to solve riddles older than city itself.

"Seems so. She's one step ahead. As always. Knew about map before us. Came to Matala before us. Dug up what's needed and vanished again, like ghost that materializes only to remind you still haven't understood anything."

"Then we need bait," Pavlik said thoughtfully, tapping fingers on knee with rhythm of someone considering complex chess combination. "Need to make her establish contact. Show we have something valuable. Something she'll want to get. Or take away."

"Decoy duck," Victor muttered. "Fake. Bluff. Game without aces up sleeve, but with such look as if you have all aces."

"Exactly. You call Vichitov and Liels. Say document's with you. At apartment. Invite both for nine in evening. They'll come. Won't be able not to. Too important. Searched too long."

"And Valeria?"

"Valeria will find out. She's watching you. Or them. Or everyone at once. She has sources. Agents. Eyes and ears everywhere. She'll come. Must come. Because can't allow document to go to someone else."

Victor smirked. Bitterly. Joylessly. Like someone who realized his life turned into bad detective story where he plays role of bait about to be devoured.

Excellent. I'm bait. Worm on hook. Mouse in mouse-trap. Ram being led to slaughter thinking he's going to pasture. Spoiler: there will be no pasture. Will only be knife and blood on grass.

At home they worked quickly, methodically, like surgeons preparing operation that could end either in recovery or death, but in any case will change everything.

Pavlik pulled out laptop, printer, paper that looked old, yellowish, as if it had lain several centuries in trunk in attic. Victor found online samples of medieval Latin texts, fonts, styling.

They composed document. "Testimonium Caiphae." Testimony of Caiaphas. Supposedly record of trial of Jesus Christ. Twelve judges. Twelve verdicts. All verdicts: "guilty." Execute. By law. Justly. Without mercy.

Text was plausible but not perfect. Expert would recognize fake in a minute. But Vichitov and Liels — aren't experts. They're businessmen. Players. Collectors. They need faith, not knowledge. They need symbol, not truth.

Pavlik printed text on old paper, treated edges with weak tea solution to give effect of time, held over candle to add slight smell of smoke and wax. Result looked convincing, like theatrical prop that works onstage but falls apart if you try to pull hilt from scabbard.

"Will do," Pavlik said, setting sheet aside with caution of jeweler holding fake Koh-i-Noor, but pretending it's real stone. "For first impression. For effect. Main thing — don't let them examine long. Show, hide, act further."

Victor nodded, pulling out phone. Dialed Vichitov's number. Short rings, then familiar voice, wary, tired, like voice of person who hasn't slept normally in long time and expects nothing good from calls at ten in evening.

"Alexei Petrovich. Victor. Found it. Document. At my place. Tomorrow, nine evening. Come. See for yourself."

Silence on other end of line. Long. Viscous. Then the phone started talking monotonously.

"You're sure? Is it really what we were looking for?"

"See for yourself. Nine evening. Don't be late."

Victor hung up, not waiting for answer. Dialed Liels' number. He answered after first ring, as if sitting with phone in hand, waiting for exactly this call.

"Valdis. I have what you were looking for. Document. 'Testimonium Caiphae.' Tomorrow, nine evening, my apartment. Come. Alone. No ensemble."

Liels laughed. Quietly. Dryly. Like rustle of sand pouring through hourglass.

"Victor, you surprise me. Every time. Hope you understand what you got into?"

"I understand. Nine evening. Waiting."

Victor hung up. Looked at Pavlik.

"Done. Fish on hook. Remains to wait till it bites."

"And me where?"

"Back room. Hide. Stay quiet. Listen. Come out only when I say. Or when everything goes sideways. Second's more likely."

Pavlik nodded, pulling from backpack small pistol, black, compact, resembling toy, but Victor knew it wasn't toy.

"You serious?" Victor asked, staring at weapon.

"You thought I'm joking? We're playing with people who kill for less. Vincent Leo died for keychain. Vladimir Lipkin sits in prison because he saw statue. You think they'll stand on ceremony with us? I have license. Legal. All by law. Just in case."

Victor nodded, feeling cold creep up spine, slowly, methodically, like snake that doesn't rush to bite but already chose victim.

Pistol. Excellent. Now I'm not only bait but participant in armed conflict. Wonder what sentence they give for forging medieval documents and organizing ambush with use of firearms? Ten years? Fifteen? Or straight to life, if someone dies?

Next day dragged like rubber band stretched to limit, about to snap but doesn't snap, only becomes thinner and more transparent. Victor tried to work, write article for newspaper, but words wouldn't come together, thoughts scattered like cockroaches when you turn on light.

Pavlik sat in back room, at computer, silently, concentratedly, doing something Victor didn't understand and didn't try to understand. Technomagic. Digital sorcery. Hacking reality through screen.

At eight evening Victor took shower, changed clothes, drank shot of vodka for courage, which didn't increase, only burned throat and made head buzz. Laid fake document on table, covered it with folder. Checked how door to back room opened. Quietly. Without creak. Good.

At nine zero zero doorbell rang. Victor opened. Vichitov stood on threshold, dressed in strict suit, with face of person who came to funeral and isn't sure who exactly they're burying.

"Come in, Alexei Petrovich."

Vichitov entered, looked around, sat in armchair Victor indicated with gesture. Was silent. Waited.

Minute later doorbell again. Liels. Tall, elegant, in black coat, with smile that didn't reach eyes, cold and attentive, like sniper's eyes choosing target.

"Valdis. Come in."

Liels entered, saw Vichitov, smile became wider, even more false.

"Alexei Petrovich. What unexpected meeting. Victor, you gathered us for auction?"

"Not auction. Presentation. Sit. Listen. Then decide what to do."

Both sat. Silently. Tensely. Like two predators who met at same prey and haven't yet decided whether to fight or share.

Victor began telling. Slowly. In detail. Started with Crete. With Valeria. With that day on beach when she laughed and sea was blue and life seemed simple as children's rhyme. Told about disappearance. About chase. About Europe. About call from Liels (he nodded dryly). About Vichitov's office. About twelve statues. About anagram. About poker tournament. About Vincent Leo. About his death.

Told unhurriedly, adding details, emotions, feelings he hadn't mentioned when retelling everything to Pavlik. Spoke about how he was afraid. How he doubted. How he wanted to drop everything and go somewhere far, where there are no Orders, no riddles, no women who vanish leaving only emptiness.

Vichitov and Liels listened. Impatiently. Fidgeted on chairs. Exchanged glances. But were silent. Waited.

Victor told about Spain. About Toledo. About Professor Vals. About order 'Lex Vicit.' About civil war. About two factions. About twenty-seven figures. About Santiago. About cathedral. About pages from Codex. About map.

"And here I'm back in Crete," Victor said, pausing, sipping soda from bottle that stood on table. "Matala. Caves. I was there alone. Found that very cave marked on map. Crawled inside. In very far corner..."

He fell silent, stretching moment, enjoying tension hanging in air, dense and palpable, like fog before dawn.

"In very far corner found this."

Victor took folder from table. Opened. Took out sheet. Yellowed. Old. With Latin text that danced before eyes in weak light of desk lamp.

“‘Testimonium Caiphae.’ Testimony of Caiaphas. Record of trial of Jesus Christ. Twelve judges. Verdict: guilty. Execute. This is what you were looking for.”

Vichitov and Liels simultaneously leaned forward, like marionettes pulled by same string. Eyes lit up. Greed. Avarice. Desire, sharp and merciless, like knife.

And in this moment door to apartment burst open. Not opened. Burst open. As if rammed from outside.

On threshold stood Valeria.

Alive. Real. Not ghost. Not memory. Her. In black leather jacket, jeans, with hair pulled back in ponytail. In right hand — small pistol, neat, elegant, but no less dangerous.

“Everyone quiet,” she said quietly, calmly, with absolute confidence of person who has situation under control. “Nobody moves. Nobody speaks. Victor, put document on table.”

Victor froze. Heart pounded so hard seemed about to burst from chest and fall on floor like bird shot down mid-flight.

Valeria. She’s here. She’s real. She’s holding pistol. She’s taking document. Everything going according to plan. Or not. Or I have no idea what’s happening.

Valeria stepped into room. Quickly. Confidently. Grabbed sheet from table. Shoved into jacket pocket. Backed toward door. Didn’t lower pistol. Looked at everyone in turn. At Victor longer. Gaze was cold. Empty. As if there had never been anything between them. No Crete. No sea. No laughter. Nothing.

“Sorry,” she said quietly, almost whisper. “But this isn’t your game. Never was yours.”

And left. Door slammed shut. Silence hung in air, heavy and sticky, like tar.

Vichitov came to his senses first. Jumped up. Ran to door. Opened. Looked into corridor. Returned.

"She's gone. Vanished. As always."

He looked at Victor with fury mixed with disappointment.

"You set us up! You're working with her! You..."

"I didn't set anyone up," Victor said wearily. "She came herself. Took document. Left. I didn't know. Didn't plan. Everything went out of control."

Vichitov snorted, not believing single word. Turned around. Left apartment, slamming door so hard plaster showered from ceiling.

Liels rose slowly. Straightened coat. Looked at Victor with long, assessing gaze.

"Interesting performance. Almost believed. But document — fake. I've seen real medieval texts. This — isn't one of them. Good work. Professional. But not original."

He headed for door. And in this moment from back room emerged Pavlik. With pistol in hand. Pointed at Liels.

"Valdis, sit down. We need to talk. Like adults. Without running around."

Liels stopped. Turned. Saw Pavlik. Smiled. Sadly. Wearily.

"Victor, you disappoint me. Thought you were smarter. Would understand you're playing game where all pieces already placed. And you're just pawn. Sacrificed first."

"Maybe," Victor said, sitting back in armchair, feeling fatigue pile onto shoulders like sack of coal. "But even pawn can reach end of board and become queen. Or

at least learn truth before being taken. Sit, Valdis. Tell us. Who is Valeria. What role she plays. And most importantly — how the hell to find her.”

Pavlik approached closer, not lowering pistol, and pointed it at armchair. Liels sighed. Sat. Folded hands on knees. Looked at Victor with expression of teacher explaining to dumb student what everyone else understood long ago.

“Valeria Lehmann. She’s half Italian. Mother — from ancient Roman family. Father — Russian aristocrat. Initials — V.L. Fits order rules. She’s — twelfth. Last of first circle. Her task — maintain balance. Be mediator between factions. But she chose side. Second faction. Those who want to change world. Destroy old order. Make ‘Testimonium Caiphae’ public. Destroy church. Free humanity from lie civilization’s rested on for two thousand years.”

“And what does she need from me?”

“Nothing. You were just cover. She met you not by accident. Knew Vichitov would hire you. Knew you’d start searching. Watched you. Used you as instrument. As bloodhound leading to trail. You did all dirty work. Found map. Deciphered pages. Led her to Matala. She dug up document. And now you’re no longer needed. Game’s over. You’re free. Or dead. Depends on how much you’ll interfere further.”

Victor was silent. Digested what was said. Felt something inside break, crack, crumble into shards, sharp and painful.

Instrument. Bloodhound. Pawn. Cover. She never loved me. Never needed me. Just used me. Like disposable lighter. Struck, lit, threw away. Simple arithmetic of betrayal.

“Where is she?” Victor asked hollowly, and was surprised himself how unnatural his voice sounded.

Liels was silent. Then pulled business card from pocket. Placed on table.

"Address. Where she lived when it all began. Maybe you'll find something there. Maybe nothing. Don't know. But that's all I have. Moscow. It's on Petrovka. Good luck, Victor. You'll need it."

Pavlik lowered pistol. Liels stood. Headed for door. On threshold turned around.

"One more thing. She's dangerous. Not because she's evil. But because she believes. And people who believe are capable of anything. Even what simply evil people aren't capable of. Remember that."

Door closed. Quietly. Finally. Like coffin lid.

Victor sat in armchair, staring into void, holding business card with address that might lead him to answers. Or to death. Or to something worse — to truth better not to know.

Pavlik put pistol on table. Sat nearby. Poured two glasses of whisky from bottle he'd brought from kitchen. Extended one to Victor.

"Drink. Tomorrow we'll go to address. See what's there. And today — just drink. And forget. At least for couple hours."

Victor took glass. Drank in one gulp. Felt throat burn, warmth spread through body, dulling pain lodged somewhere deep inside, where no whisky can reach.

Instrument. Bloodhound. Pawn. Story of my life. Written not by me. Played not for me. I'm not even spectator. I'm extra. Background character. One who stands in crowd and pretends to exist. And then credits. And everyone forgets he was even in frame.

He poured himself more. And more. Until bottle was empty. Until world became blurred. Until he stopped thinking about Valeria. About betrayal. About

how love — is just chemical reaction that can be caused, controlled and stopped, like any other experiment.

63 The Stone Box

MORNING started with hangover that was felt not so much in soul, heavy and sticky, like tar used to coat ship bottoms before sending them on final voyage. Victor woke on couch, not remembering how he got there, with aftertaste of whisky and bitterness in mouth that no whisky could wash away.

Pavlik sat at table, already dressed, sober, with cup of coffee in hand and expression of person who'd thought all night about problem and found if not solution, at least direction worth digging further.

"Awake? Good. We need to talk. Seriously. Without self-flagellation and philosophy."

Victor got up, stretched, felt how all muscles protested against existence in principle. Poured himself coffee from cezve that Pavlik had already brewed, sat opposite.

"Speak. I'm listening. Though don't promise to understand. Brain hasn't woken yet. Running on reserve batteries."

"Valeria took fake. Means she doesn't have real document. Otherwise she wouldn't have bitten on bait. Wouldn't have risked bursting in on you with pistol. Means in cave wasn't document. Or not just document. Something else. Key. Map. Coordinates. Symbol. Anything that leads to real *Testimonium Caiphae*."

Victor nodded, sipping coffee, feeling how hot liquid slowly returned him to life, to reality, to necessity of thinking rather than simply suffering.

"Logical. But what exactly? What could have lain in that cave seven hundred years, not destroyed, not losing meaning?"

Pavlik leaned back in chair, folding hands behind head in pose of person enjoying contemplation of process of unsuccessful attempts to think.

"Option one: metal plate. Bronze. Copper. Silver. With engraved text. Or symbols. Resistant to time. Doesn't rot. Doesn't crumble. Romans used such for important messages."

"Possible," Victor agreed. "But we would have seen metal glint. Digging traces were there, but metal traces — none. Either she took everything very carefully, or it's something else."

"Option two: stone. Small but heavy. Granite. Marble. Basalt. With inscription. Or with engraved map. Stone is eternal. Will survive any centuries. Legends about Moses' tablets didn't come from nowhere."

Victor thought, imagining Valeria crawling out of narrow cave with stone in hands, dirty, scraped, triumphant.

"Maybe. But why grab fake from me then? If she already has stone with inscription, she could simply decipher and move on."

"Option three: ceramics. Clay tablet. Sealed amphora with parchment inside. Clay is resistant if properly fired. Babylonian tablets reached us through four thousand years. Why not medieval ones?"

"Too fragile. One clumsy movement — and everything crumbles to dust. And shard traces would remain. No, not ceramics."

"Option four: bone. Human or animal. With carving. With text. Resistant to moisture, to time. Incas and Maya used bones for records. Why not medieval monks?"

Victor grimaced, imagining human bone with Latin text, lying in dark cave, waiting for someone to find it and read message written in blood.

"Creepy. But plausible. Though again — we didn't see bone traces. Maybe she took everything. Or maybe it's not physical object at all."

"Then what? Ephemeral? Spiritual? Astral?" Pavlik smirked. "Valeria meditated in cave, achieved enlightenment and now knows where document is because Universe whispered in her ear?"

Victor laughed. First time in last twenty-four hours. Bitterly. Dryly. But still laughed.

"Why not? We're already up to our ears in conspiracies. Secret Orders, ancient documents, murders, fakes. Only thing left is to add UFOs, telepathy and time travel."

Though honestly, I wouldn't be surprised if it turned out the Order is managed by reptilians from Nibiru who came to Earth two thousand years ago to establish Christianity as part of plan to enslave humanity. In world I've been living these recent weeks, that would be quite logical.

Pavlik poured himself more coffee, looked thoughtfully at window where Moscow was waking, gray, indifferent, familiar.

"Okay. Let's try from other end. Where might actual document be? Not key to it. But it itself. *Testimonium Caiphae*. Original. First century AD. Two thousand years. Where can you hide parchment so it survives?"

Victor lit cigarette without asking permission, because this was his apartment, his life, his right to slowly kill himself with nicotine and bad decisions.

"In dry place. Without air access. Without light. Desert. Cave. Sealed tomb. Dead Sea Scrolls were found exactly like that. In jars. In caves by Dead Sea."

"Means we're looking for similar place. In Europe. In Mediterranean. Where the Order could hide document so nobody found it, but they themselves could retrieve when needed."

"Rome? Catacombs? Under Vatican? Too obvious. Too dangerous. Church controls every stone."

"Jerusalem? Temple Mount? Even more dangerous. Three religions fight over every meter there."

"Athos? Monasteries on mountain? Closed libraries? Possible. But access is limited. Even for the Order members."

"Santiago? Cathedral? We were already there. Found only copies of pages from Codex."

They fell silent, hitting dead end that seemed insurmountable, like wall behind which could be anything, but getting there impossible, because wall too high, too thick, too real.

Victor stubbed out cigarette, looked at Pavlik with expression of person whose light bulb suddenly switched on in head, bright, blinding, almost painful.

"I have photographs. Of Valeria. Hundreds of photographs. From Crete. We photographed each other. Sea. Beach. Caves. Her against sunset. Me against ruins. Romance, damn it. And I'm journalist. Can write article. About mysterious woman who disappeared. About search. About mysteries. People love such stories. Eat them like hot pies. And Valeria won't like this. At all. Publicity — last thing person who's hiding needs."

Pavlik smiled. Broadly. Predatorily. Like wolf who caught scent of prey.

"Blackmail. Classic genre. Offering her silence in exchange for truth. Photographs stay with you. Article doesn't come out. But she tells everything. From beginning to end. Dots all i's. Crosses all t's. Beautiful. Dirty. But effective."

"Exactly. We'll go to her. To address Liels gave. Most likely she won't be there. But attempt isn't torture. And if she's not there — we'll leave note. She'll get it. She has people. Eyes. Ears. She'll find out. And will make contact. Because she won't be able not to."

I stopped being worm on hook. Now I'm fisherman. With rod. With bait. With patience and fury. She used me? Excellent. Now my turn. This isn't revenge, because revenge — weapon of weak. This is simply last move in game that was supposed to end in zugzwang. But I still have room to maneuver.

Petrovka. An old house, Stalin empire style, with columns, molding and the feeling that here once lived people important, significant, who believed they were building the future, and didn't know they were building a prison for themselves.

Apartment seven. Third floor. Victor and Pavlik climbed the stairs slowly, silently, like thieves who don't want to be noticed, though they came to steal not things but the truth, which in the modern world isn't even considered theft.

Victor rang the doorbell. Once. Short ring. Nothing happened. Silence. Complete. Absolute. Like in a grave.

He was about to ring again, but the door opened.

Valeria stood on the threshold. In home clothes — jeans and a gray sweater that was too big for her, as if she'd put it on after someone who was bigger, stronger, warmer. Hair loose. Face without makeup. In her right hand — the same small pistol she'd held yesterday.

She looked at Victor long, silently, with expression impossible to read — surprise? fear? regret? all together?

"Victor," she said finally quietly, almost a whisper. "You shouldn't have come. This isn't your war."

"Maybe so," Victor answered calmly, surprised that his voice doesn't tremble, that his hands don't shake, that his heart beats steadily, like a metronome counting the seconds until the end of the performance. — "But you made it mine. When you used me. As a tool. As a bloodhound. As an idiot who believed that a couple of days on Crete meant something. So now it's my war too. And I came to make a deal."

"What deal?"

"Simple one. I want to hear the story. All of it. From beginning to end. No gaps. No omissions. Truth. Only truth. In exchange — the photographs. All photographs I took on Crete. Hundreds of them. You in each one. Your face. Clear. Recognizable. And also — silence. I won't write an article. Won't tell anyone. Your secret stays secret. You'll continue doing what you do. I just want to know. Understand. Why. What for. How."

Valeria was silent. Didn't lower the pistol. Looked at Victor with the expression of a person who weighs on internal scales the risks and benefits, the price of life and death, truth and lies.

Then slowly lowered the pistol. Stepped back. Opened the door wider.

"Come in. Alone. Your friend stays outside."

"Pavlik comes in with me. Or nobody enters. Your choice."

Valeria sighed. Tiredly. Resignedly.

"Fine. Both enter. But weapons on the table. At the entrance. Immediately. Or I shoot. Without warning."

Pavlik pulled his pistol from his pocket, placed it on a small table by the door. Valeria nodded. They entered.

The apartment was small, ascetic, almost empty. A living room with a couch, a table, two chairs. A window with a view of Petrovka. Books on the shelves. Many books. In Latin, Italian, Spanish. Old. Worn. Beloved.

Valeria sat on the couch. Victor and Pavlik — on chairs opposite. The pistol she placed beside herself. Within arm's reach. Just in case.

"Where to begin?" she asked rhetorically, looking at the window, as if seeking there an answer that lay not outside but inside, in memory, in the past, in the choices she'd made and that made her.

"From the beginning," Victor said simply. "From the moment when you decided I was suitable. That I could be used."

Valeria nodded. Began speaking. Slowly. Quietly. Like a person confessing before death, knowing there will be no forgiveness, but at least the soul's relief is possible.

"I was born in Rome. In a family that's belonged to the Order five hundred years. V.L. Suitable initials. I was prepared from childhood. Taught languages. History. Theology. Was told that I'm the twelfth. That the balance rests on me. That I must be a bridge between the past and the future. But I didn't want to be a bridge. Bridges — are what people walk on. Use. Don't notice. I wanted to be human. Decide for myself. Choose."

She paused. Victor was silent. Listened. Didn't interrupt.

"I chose the second faction. Those who want to reveal *Testimonium Caiphae*. Show the world that Christ was convicted by law. That the crucifixion — isn't martyrdom but the execution of a criminal. I believe that humanity must know. That truth is more important than stability. That a lie, even a holy one, remains a lie."

"And I was part of the plan?"

"Yes. Vichitov was looking for someone for the investigation. Someone smart, but not too much. Someone who would dig but not understand where he's digging. Liels suggested you. I agreed. Pulled you to Crete.

It was easy. You..." she fell silent, choosing her words, "you're a good person, Victor. Sincere. Naive. Exactly what's needed to live a happy life, or to use blindly. I disappeared. You began searching. As I calculated. Found and understood the note. The keychain from Vincent. All the pieces I left. Went to Spain. Returned. Found the pages in Santiago. Deciphered the map. Led me to Matala."

"And in the cave?"

Valeria stood, went to a closet, took out a small box. Stone. Gray. Matchbox-sized. No lock. No seams. A whole piece of basalt, processed so skillfully it seemed not stone but something living, frozen, waiting for the moment to come alive again.

"This was in the cave. In the farthest corner. Buried half a meter down. I dug for three hours. With a trowel. Then with my hands. Like an archaeologist who found a treasure and fears breaking it. This is a box. But I don't know how it opens. No lock. No hinges. No visible mechanisms. Just stone. Whole. But something's inside. I hear it. When I shake. Something heavy. Metallic. Maybe a key. Maybe a map. Maybe the document itself in a metal capsule."

She held the box out to Victor. He took it in his hands. Heavy. Cold. Smooth. Turned it over, felt it, looked for a hidden button, a lever, anything. Nothing.

"Could I have a glass of water?" he asked, not looking up from the box.

Valeria nodded, went to the kitchen. Victor heard how the faucet opened, how water poured into a glass, how she was returning.

"Here..."

And in that moment the apartment door exploded.

It didn't just open. It exploded. Literally. With a crash. With the screech of hinges. With the scream

of a person who can no longer restrain himself, who is tired of waiting, who came for what's his.

On the threshold stood Vichitov. With a pistol in hand. Face twisted by fury, hatred, despair.

"Bitch! You destroyed everything! Everything!"

He fired.

Valeria jerked, dropped the glass, clutched her chest. Blood gushed through her fingers, bright, red, too real. She raised her pistol. Fired. Once. Twice. Three times.

Vichitov fell. Heavily. Finally. Like a tree felled at the root.

Valeria seemed to spill onto the floor. Slowly. Quietly. Like a leaf that tore from a branch and flies down, spinning in the air.

Pavlik ran out from the kitchen, where he'd managed to hide when Vichitov burst into the apartment.

"What the hell?!"

Victor stood with the stone box in his hands, looking at the two bodies on the floor, feeling how reality was falling to pieces, how the script he'd been writing in his head was suddenly rewritten by others, and now the ending is completely different from what was planned.

He dropped to his knees beside Valeria. Felt for a pulse on her neck. Nothing. Looked into her eyes. Empty. Open. Looking at nothing.

Went to Vichitov. Same thing. Dead. Finally. Irrevocably.

"Dead," he said hollowly. "Both."

Pavlik swore. Long. Inventively. In three languages.

"Need to leave. Now. Immediately. The neighbors will call the police. We can't be here when they arrive. We won't explain anything. They'll accuse us. Jail us. Or worse."

Victor nodded. Stood. Looked at Valeria one last time. Her face was calm. Almost peaceful. As if she'd finally found what she'd been searching for. Peace. Silence. End.

Something cracked in his chest — not a thought, not a decision, but something physical, structural, like a load-bearing wall giving way in a condemned building. He knelt beside her and pressed his lips to her forehead. Her skin was already cooling. He stayed like that for several seconds, or several minutes, he couldn't tell, while the sound of his own breathing filled the room with something raw and terrible and wholly unlike Victor Latov.

Then the wall rebuilt itself, brick by brick, mortar and all. He stood.

"Sorry," he thought. "Or no. Not sorry. You used me. I used you. We're even. Now you're dead. I'm alive. This isn't justice. This is simply chance."

They left the apartment. Quickly. Quietly. Pavlik took his pistol from the table. Victor shoved the stone box in his jacket pocket. Descended the stairs. Went outside. Walked away. Without looking back. Not running. Just walked. Like ordinary people with ordinary business on an ordinary day of ordinary life.

Behind them somewhere a siren wailed. Police. Ambulance. Already coming. Already too late. For everyone.

Victor walked and thought that in his pocket lay a box worth more than all Vichitov's and Liels' fortunes combined. In it — possibly — the key to *Testimonium Caiphae*.

Choice is mine now. For the first time in weeks, the only hand on the wheel is mine.

Part V

Epilogue

64 The Offer

“CAN you come right now?”

The other man sounded insolent, like a person accustomed to being obeyed not because he's right, but because he's rich, influential, dangerous. The clock showed quarter to three after midnight. The curtains trembled, like the nerves of a condemned man awaiting a shot, not knowing where the bullet will come from.

“Of course,” Victor threw into the receiver with that special intonation meaning “go to hell, but I'll come because I'm curious to watch you burn in there.”

The phone slipped from his hand, sticky with sweat, fell on the couch, bounced like something alive. The room stuffy, like an oven where they forgot to open the damper, and all the smoke returned back, eating into walls, furniture, lungs. On the table stood a whisky bottle, almost empty, with drops of condensation on the glass, like tears on the face of an old prostitute who long forgot what real feelings are.

Didn't want to go. Absolutely didn't want to. But Victor understood long ago: when they call you at three in the morning, it means only one thing — you're already in the game, whether you want it or not, and the only choice — play to the end or surrender at the very beginning, admitting yourself weak, cowardly, unworthy.

And I'm not going to surrender. Not after everything that happened. Not after I went through hell, purgatory and a bit of heaven on Crete, which turned out to be scenery for a spectacle where I — the main idiot. Now I decide who's the idiot. And it's definitely not me.

Victor finished the whisky straight from the bottle. His throat burned, his eyes darkened for a second, then cleared. He stood, threw on his jacket, checked his pocket. The stone box lay there, heavy, cold, like a dead man's heart. Left the apartment without looking back.

The street was empty. Moscow slept, if Moscow ever sleeps at all, and not just short periods of respite between one madness and another. Rare cars rushed past, not noticing a person walking on the sidewalk with a facial expression saying: "Don't approach. I'm dangerous. Not for you. But dangerous."

A taxi stopped immediately, as if waiting for him specifically. Victor named the address. Foggy, eight. Liels' house. The last instance before the finale, which would be either triumph or catastrophe, but definitely not boring.

In the car he took out his phone. Called Pavlik.

"I'm going to Liels'. Foggy, eight. Come in twenty minutes. Wait outside. If I don't come out in an hour — call the police. Or don't call. Decide yourself."

"Understood. Will do," Pavlik answered briefly, asking no questions, because he knew: if Victor calls at three in the morning, it means questions are already inappropriate.

Liels' house was an old mansion in the center, with columns, molding and the appearance of a building that remembers revolutions, wars, perestroika and still stands, because stone is stronger than people, and history — is simply a sequence of tenants who come and go, leaving no trace.

Victor rang the doorbell. Once. Sharply. Confidently. Like a person who came not to ask, but to demand.

The door opened almost instantly. Liels stood on the threshold, dressed in a black suit, a white shirt, no tie.

His face calm, like a poker player holding a royal flush and knowing he'll win, but not rushing to show cards.

"Victor. Come in. You're expected."

"By whom exactly?" Victor asked, crossing the threshold, feeling how the air in the house was dense, heavy, saturated with something ancient, forbidden, dangerous.

"You'll see."

Liels led him down the corridor into a large drawing room. There sat people. Eleven people. Men and women. Different ages. From thirty to seventy. All dressed strictly, formally, as at a funeral or business negotiations where the fate of the world is decided, not just shareholders' profits.

Victor knew only Liels. The others looked like random passersby. But he felt that all of them looked at him with the same expression — assessment, interest, hope, mixed with fear and distrust.

A gray-haired man about sixty-five, sitting in the center, stood. Tall, thin, with the face of an ascetic and the eyes of an inquisitor. He spoke in English, with a slight Italian accent, slowly, coining each word like a coin placed on the scales of justice.

"Mister Latov. Suppose you already understand why you're here. We — are the council of the Order *Lex Vicit*. The first faction. Guardians of the old Order. Valeria Lehmann — was the twelfth. She's dead. The place is vacant. We offer it to you. Your initials fit. Victor Latov. V.L. You passed the test. Found what you sought. Proved worthy. We're ready to accept you. With all rights. With all duties. With all the knowledge passed from generation to generation for seventeen centuries already. Yes, Vichitov is already out of the game, but the game itself hasn't even reached the endgame yet.

Victor listened silently, standing in the middle of the room, feeling on himself twenty-two eyes that waited for

his answer, a decision, a choice that would determine not only his fate, but perhaps the fate of all who sat in this room.

He smirked. Quietly. Dryly.

"No, thank you."

Silence. The gray-haired man blinked, as if he'd misheard.

"I appreciate the theatrics — the midnight summons, the solemn circle, the initials that conveniently match. Very dramatic. But I'm a journalist, not a monk. Find another twelfth."

"You have the box," the gray-haired man said quietly. "Give it to us. It's ours by right."

"The box stays with me. I might open it in a year. Or never. Not your concern."

"You don't understand what you're doing."

Victor turned toward the door. Paused.

"One more thing. I've prepared an investigation. Your Order, the twenty-seven figures, the civil war, Valeria, Vichitov — everything. It's in a safe place. If something happens to me, it publishes itself. So let's agree to leave each other alone."

He opened the door, went into the corridor. Liels followed him with his eyes, with a facial expression mixing respect, regret and something resembling sadness.

"You're making a mistake, Victor."

"Perhaps. But it's my mistake. Not yours. Not theirs. Mine. And I have the right to it."

Victor went outside. The cold night air struck his face, fresh, clean, like water from a mountain spring. He breathed deeply, felt how his lungs filled, how his pulse slowed, how the tension released.

On the sidewalk stood Pavlik. With a cigarette. With the facial expression of a person who waited and didn't know if he'd see his friend again.

"Alive?"

"Alive. Let's go."

They caught a taxi. Rode silently. The city was waking. The first janitors swept garbage. Rare cars hurried to work. The sky lightened, gray, low, indifferent.

In Pavlik's lair it was warm, cozy, smelled of coffee and electronics. Computers hummed like a hive. At least here nothing had changed.

Pavlik sat at the table, opened his laptop, tapped keys.

"The analysis results came. Carbon. Spectral. Tomography. A bunch more stuff, names you won't remember anyway. The box — basalt. The age — approximately fifteen hundred years. Plus-minus a hundred. Hollow. Inside — something metallic. Judging by the density — bronze or copper. The shape — elongated. Possibly a scroll sealed in metal. Possibly a tablet. Possibly a key. Can't know without opening."

He looked at Victor with a long gaze.

"Shall we open it?"

Victor was silent. Looked at the box lying on the table between them, gray, smooth, impenetrable. Inside — possibly — the key to *Testimonium Caiphae*. To the document that could destroy the church. Change the world. Or change nothing, because the world doesn't change from knowledge, it changes from pain, from blood, from wars, not from old parchments with Latin texts.

"No," he said finally calmly, firmly, like a person who made a choice and doesn't intend to change it. "Won't open. Put it in a bank safe deposit box. Lock it. Forget

the key. Let it lie. A hundred years. Two hundred. A thousand. Someday someone will open. Or won't open. It won't be our problem.

Pavlik looked at him with surprise mixed with respect.

"And that's it? Just like that? We went through all this hell to put box in safe and forget?"

"Yes. Just like that. Some secrets should stay secrets. Not because they're dangerous — because nobody needs them. People don't improve from old parchments."

Pavlik looked at him for a long time.

"So all of it was for nothing?"

"Not for nothing. I learned when to fold."

Pavlik poured two glasses of whisky. Extended one to Victor.

"To freedom?"

"To freedom. And to the fact we're still alive. That we can still choose. That we can still say 'no.' Even when the whole world screams 'yes.'"

They drank. Silently. To the hum of computers continuing their work, indifferent to human dramas, to choices, to secrets, to boxes lying unopened, keeping inside something that might change the world, or might simply crumble to dust when someone finally decides to open.

65 The Decision

A week later Victor put the stone box in a bank safe deposit box. In one of those banks that guarantee safety a hundred years forward, though nobody knows whether

in a hundred years this bank, this country, this civilization will exist.

Closed the door. Turned the key. Shoved the key in his pocket. Went outside.

Moscow lived its life. People hurried to work, from work, on errands, without errands. Cars hummed. The sky was gray. The trees shed leaves. Everything was ordinary. Normal. Familiar.

Victor walked down the street, feeling in his pocket the weight of a small key that opens the door to a secret capable of destroying the world. Or not destroying. Or meaning nothing at all, because the meaning we give things ourselves, and things are indifferent to our inventions.

He smiled to himself. For the first time in a long while. Sincerely. Without bitterness. Without sarcasm. Simply smiled, because he was alive, free, walked down the street of the autumn city, and nobody demanded of him decisions, choices, sacrifices.

And let the Order search for a new twelfth. I will live. Write. Drink coffee in the mornings. Sometimes remember Crete. The sea. Valeria, who is no more — and feel again that crack in my chest, the one that healed crooked and aches when the weather changes, as all badly healed fractures do. And know that somewhere in a bank safe deposit box lies a box that could have changed everything. But didn't. Because I decided otherwise.

The End.